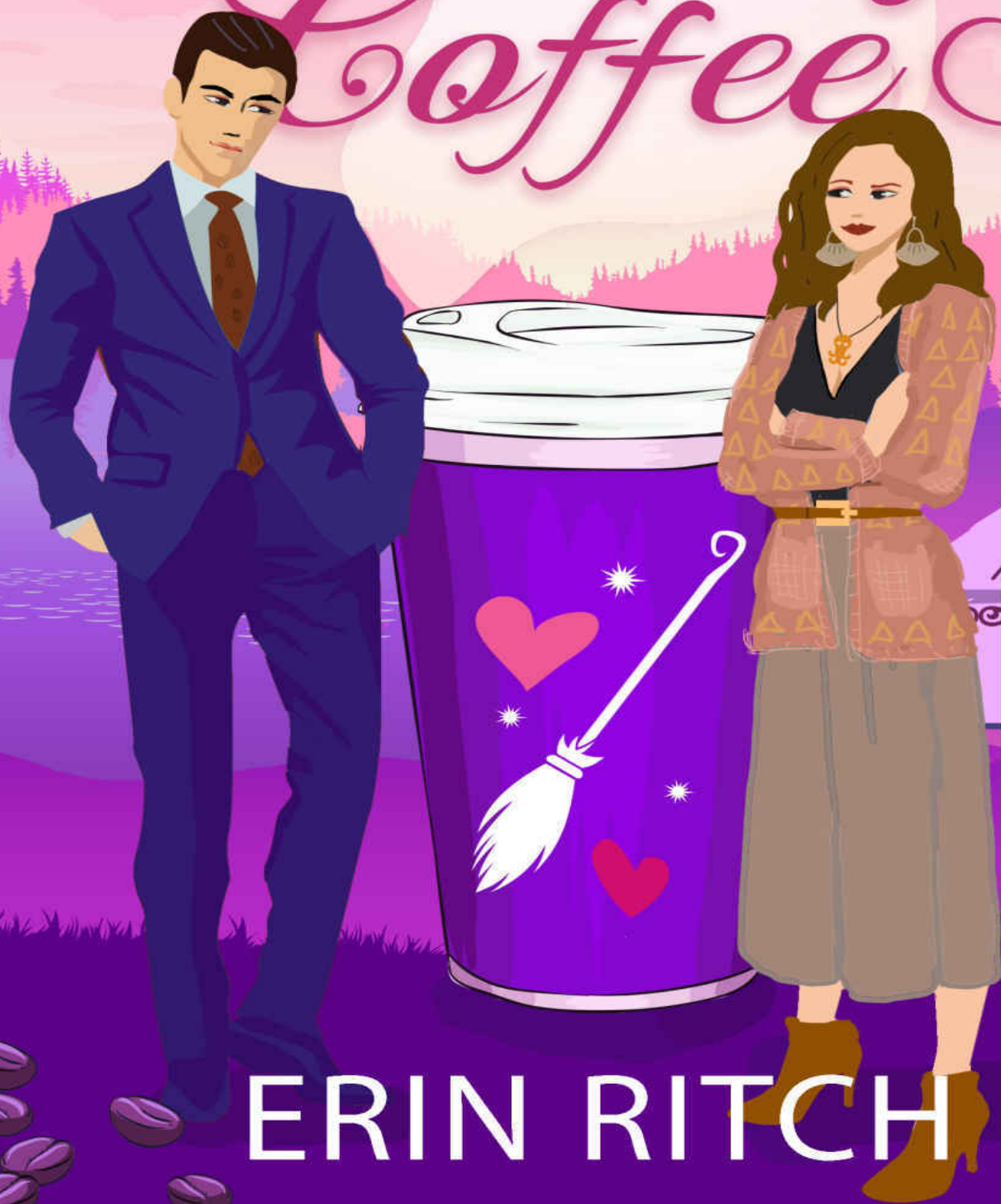


Witchy Coffee



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Erin Ritch



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Chapter One

AN UNMISTAKABLE PART OF the Pacific Northwest culture is coffee. It is the first thought in the morning and the last stop before the end of lunch break. Drive-thru shops are scattered along the roadsides like giant toadstools, dispensing the magical elixir in hot, iced, or blended form. Indoor cafes serve as meeting places, reading spots, internet connections, and rainy day observatories. To the people that live here, the roast of the coffee beans reminds them of the deep woods of the landscape, the aroma conjuring memories of the soil after a long rain, steam rising from the earth with warm intentions.

Florence Mackenzie is a barista, a disciple of this gift from the gods since sneaking her first sip of coffee from her father's mug at age five. She loves the joy her creations bring to the bleary-eyed customers who stumble up to the counter with their order, ready to face the day once their mocha latte is in hand. But today, Florence Mackenzie almost does not like coffee. Because today, she was fired.

"I feel real bad doing this right before Christmas," Sam said as he handwrote Florence's final check. He struggled with his pen, tapping the last of the ink on his checkbook. Sam only came to the coffee cart when it involved money, new baked goods to sample, or when the supervisor on duty was too timid to fire someone. He owned a half dozen Sam's 'Spresso carts throughout the Portland, Oregon metro area and was looking to expand even more, which kept him a busy and well-fed man.

Sam carefully pulled at the check one perforation at a time, finally extending the \$76.12 out to Florence. "But let's not part with hard feelings. Maybe we'll see you again at Sam's 'Spresso. Next coffee's on me."

Florence took the check and glanced up at her co-workers, who were crowded around the drive-thru window, their breath fogging up the glass. They ducked away quickly. It had been a coup and they knew it. There was no loyalty-in-arms at Sam's 'Spresso, apparently. Florence looked back down at her check that was now splattered with raindrops, where her misspelled last name was blurring into an inky smear.

"It's M-a-c-k-e-n-z-i-e," Florence corrected, holding up the check. "You forgot the *a*."

"What's that?" Sam asked, replacing his blue checkbook into the pocket of his waterproof fleece jacket.

"It's M-a-c-k-e-n-z-i-e. You misspelled my last name."

Sam chuckled, the lines increasing around his twinkling blue eyes. "Nah, I don't think so, sweetheart. I spelled it just like the river, we're all square."

"I know, that's what everyone does." Florence's eyes were not twinkling but her face was getting flushed. The change in her voice caused a clamor inside Sam's 'Spresso as faces returned to the window. "Please fix it and I will be on my way."

Sam adjusted his pants. "Are we having a problem here?"

"Problem?" Florence squeaked. "Let's see, you fired me because Courtney is clearly threatened by my superior skillset and because I was the obvious choice for manager. Do you really think I've been mixing up my oat milk with my almond milk this entire time? It is literally my last day before Christmas vacation starts, a vacation that I scheduled a Christmas ago. And now, to top it all off, you think I can't spell my own last name?"

Sure, I could add an *a* myself. But Sam, I think you owe me an *a*, don't you?"

The check hovered in the space between Sam and Florence, wilting more and more with each passing moment it was exposed to the rain. The whizzing cars that passed nearby only added more puddle spray to the mix. Florence's not-waterproof hoodie soaked up the rain like a washcloth. Beneath her hood, Florence felt the crown of her head begin to dampen but she didn't budge.

Sam stared at her for a beat and slowly reached for the check. He squinted at his own handwriting and added an exaggerated *a* before returning the drooping check. Shaking his head, Sam reached up and knocked on the coffee cart drive-thru window glass. Conspirator Courtney slowly slid open the window, looking down her contoured nose at Florence's drenched frame.

"Get this kid a chamomile tea, would ya? Boy, does she need it."



Florence plopped the Sam's 'Spresso cup of chamomile tea onto the kitchen counter. Her friend and roommate Harper Carlisle peeked over the edge of her laptop from where she was sitting at the kitchen bar. Their small apartment, five stories up a flight of perpetually damp stairs, was worth the climb for the view of bustling downtown Portland and the majesty of snowy Mount Hood. The inside of their "flat" as they liked to call it was an ode to all the similar things they loved - crafting, cinema, candy, candles, and of course, coffee. The roommates told themselves the mismatching chairs,

sofa, and random kitschy items throughout their apartment was intentional and all part of their shared aesthetic.

Harper removed one earbud, releasing the chatter of the podcast she was listening to. Her thick dark hair was knotted atop her head and she was also dressed in a hoodie, although not soaking wet like the one Florence peeled off her torso and tossed in the hamper.

"What is that?" Harper asked, her nose picking up an unusual aroma. She raised an eyebrow. This was not a house of tea.

"Chamomile tea," Florence sighed loudly as she continued to peel off one soaked article of clothing after another. She had walked home from Sam's 'Spreso instead of taking the bus, stomping from crosswalk to crosswalk. No one had paid attention that she was soaked. They were all soaked. "It's my severance package. I was fired."

Harper removed her other earbud and shut her laptop. "No."

"Yep," Florence called as she entered her bedroom. "Courtney rallied her minions and convinced Sam I'd given a customer with an allergy the wrong milk substitute on purpose."

"Did you?"

"No! Not even by accident! And then...Sam misspelled Mackenzie."

Harper clenched her teeth. She'd known Florence for several years now and had been witness to a myriad of *M-a-c-k-e-n-z-i-e* meltdowns.

Digging through her dresser drawers, Florence grabbed the comfiest sweats, socks, and oversized sweater she could find. Her previously straightened hair that she so painstakingly spent the morning flat ironing had now reverted back to its natural state, which was somewhere between wavy and frizzy. With a flick of her wrist, her auburn brown hair was pulled

atop her head just like Harper's. Their love of top knots was just another thing they had in common.

Dumping the cold tea down the kitchen drain, Florence rinsed the cup thoroughly of any remaining tea residue and repurposed the cup, filling it to the brim with hot black coffee from the coffee pot. That coffee pot only slept when they slept, programmed to rise before Florence and Harper so the flat was filled with the aroma of Arabica in the morning.

"So, now what?" Harper followed suit and refilled her oversized mug through habit and not need.

Burying herself under every blanket within arm's reach, Florence fashioned herself a cocoon of fleece. "I'm going home for Christmas and I'm going to enjoy myself, employed or not. You know I'll be pitching in at The Yurt, maybe I can keep my tips instead of adding them to the New Year's fund like usual."

"The Yurt" was first known as Windia Coffee and Goods when Florence's Great-Grandfather Mackenzie opened the shop in Windia, Oregon in the 1940s. With a stunning view of the Pacific, which felt almost too close at times, the shop flourished and became a notable landmark for Windia with its rotunda-shaped design meant to mimic a Yurt. When Florence's grandmother took over management in the decadent time known as the 1980s, she changed the name of the shop to Sea Witch Coffee to reflect her lifestyle as a practicing Wiccan. There was such a fuss caused by relatives over the name change that Florence's grandmother was pressured to change the name back, only to find that Windia Coffee and Goods had been registered by a coffee shop in Illinois. The shop then became Mackenzie's Coffee and Goods which was easier to register due to the popular local spelling of Mckenzie, notably without an *a*. By this time locals had started

to call the shop The Yurt and paid no attention to the name changes as long as they could continue to find their favorite drinks and enjoy the views unbeatable by anywhere else.

"You know I can always get you in at the store, right?" Harper said as she reopened her laptop. Her store was a trendy resale shop in the Pearl District of Portland. This was one of the reasons Harper always had her nose in her laptop; she was scouring the endless realms of the internet for hip but affordable fashion. She wasn't rattled by her roommate losing her income. If Florence Mackenzie was good at anything, it was always knowing how to land on her feet.

"I know, but..." Florence didn't finish her sentence, letting her stained sweatshirt do the talking. She didn't belong in a fashion store. She belonged with coffee and happy customers in an early morning chill. She'd figure it out, she always does. But for the next two weeks, she resigned to belonging back on the Oregon coast. Florence sunk deeper into her fleece cocoon and closed her eyes. Before long she heard the sounds of the pier, the hypnotic chiming of a train crossing, and the rush of water across the sand. The sounds of home, Windia.

Chapter Two

MOST INHABITANTS OF THE Pacific Northwest have a general knowledge of Windia, known as the faraway town tucked into the tip of the northwestern Oregon coastline. Once robust from a booming salmon-canning industry, the old fishing town is rooted in history. But now the canneries are abandoned and decrepit and Windia has found content with its identity as a quaint coastal town and not much else. Besides, nothing could change the heart of the little community - the sea. Buildings are built and then fall, roads pave the way only to crumble into dust. But the sea continues no matter and the sea at Windia is cold and headstrong, endlessly fed by the ancient Columbia River. The air has an extra chill, not exactly a bite, but a briskness that tells you to keep moving, or maybe you'll become part of the sea, too.

The two-hour drive west from Portland to Windia was a twisty trip across forested mountains and short, obscure highways. There was always a decent amount of traffic, which Florence often found strange. There were few homes through this remote stretch of Oregon, so where was everyone coming and going to? Hiking? Camping? Bigfoot hunting? Or maybe just escaping to the sea?

The sunset light flickered through the trees like a giant roaring train, racing to keep up with Florence as she drove from inland to the coast. She had spent the morning packing, her lunchtime cleaning her room and then the kitchen, and her afternoon returning library books and filling her car

with gas, snacks, and presents for her family. It was only a two-week trip but something told Florence these would be a long two weeks. It was passing the span of two different years after all, and Florence made sure to leave Harper her Christmas present - a giant coffee mug, of course, and a treasure-revealing candle to burn all New Year's Eve and New Year's night.

Having lived in Portland for almost four years now, Florence had spent quite a lot of time in her used Volvo with the broken radio but functioning compact disc player. Her only CDs were those from high school, which only added to the sense of nostalgia she experienced while driving back to her childhood home. And while there were many reasons she left Windia, there are always many reasons she's ready to go back and they all run through her mind on that drive home, music from the past ushering her along the way.

Florence always knows she's almost home when the sand starts to mix with the forest soil and the trees thin out with branches outstretched in a windblown stance. The sky starts to open up, sometimes gray with rain or sometimes a flat whitish blue, as though the sky was thinner that far north. Florence couldn't hear the ocean roar but she knew it was there, and in an instant, she would round a curve and be met with steep, rocky cliffs and endless, glistening sea.

It was hard not to look but Florence had to focus on the road in front of her, a twisty highway built into the mountainside. When it rained too hard sometimes the land would break free and wash out the highway, causing travelers to seek out another short, obscure highway to reach their destination. All the little towns sprinkled along the coastline knew the drill; one day you'd be inundated with city folk, the next you'd be cut off

completely. But you were never truly cut off completely. There was, and always will be, the sea.

A sign reading *Welcome to Windia, Established 1811* was planted beneath a giant arbor of dormant lilacs at the entrance to town. Florence remembered when the sign was erected, replacing an older sign that read *Windia, Salmon Canning Capital of the World*. No one had ever bothered to fact-check that statement so the town budgeted the money to replace the sign one summer years ago. They decided their founding date was not only an accurate statement but also helped to distinguish Windia from the other little coastal towns that were scattered down the Pacific coastline. Today, Windia embraced the industry that most little coastal towns do - tourism. And luckily for the Mackenzie's unique little coffee shop, warm caffeinated drinks go perfectly with a chilly downtown stroll or a thought-filled afternoon on the beach.

Florence had just barely passed the Windia sign when she was met with another sight that made her feel right back at home. Her grandmother seemed to treat the whole town of Windia like it was her personal backyard, and Florence did a double-take when she passed her grandmother outstretched on the grass next to the Windia sign, her arms and legs splayed out as if to make snow angels. With a splatter of gravel dust and a squeak of her brakes, Florence pulled over to the side of the road and looked in her rearview mirror, only to see her grandmother's head pop up in response.

"I knew it was you!" her grandmother called as Florence stepped out of the car. "The rhododendrons in the back told me you'd be here around sunset!"

Florence's grandmother Pearl Mackenzie, oftentimes known as the town's uncertified herbalist, professed herself to be a witch. The coffee shop's brief

stint as Sea Witch Coffee had been under Pearl's management and Florence heard the most amazing stories of the antics her grandmother conjured up in that shop after hours. Growing up, Florence assumed everyone's grandmothers disappeared into the woods at midnight to pray or hung three bells on the front door to keep out evil spirits. She had countless memories of foraging for truffles, nettles, and blackberries with her grandmother, learning to identify a variety of forest life. But Florence also had countless memories of moments that burned with embarrassment, such as finding her grandmother seemingly passed out by the entrance to town.

"Hello, Pearl," Florence greeted her grandmother, who had always insisted her grandchildren call her by her real name, not "some conventional abomination like grandma or maw-maw."

Pearl stood up with an ease not typical of her age and dusted off her maroon-colored velvet overalls which was topped with a flannel of contradictory colors. Ever since Florence could remember, Pearl had dyed her hair an almost bluish-black, but in recent years had relinquished to the stubborn white shade that fits her name so well. She was carrying a denim backpack, likely filled with random treasures Pearl finds on her adventures around Windia.

"Hello, my beauty. Are you well?" Pearl greeted, walking up to the Volvo. A passing car honked and Pearl squinted to see the driver then waved enthusiastically. She returned to inspecting her granddaughter's vehicle.

"Yes, I'm well," Florence replied, watching Pearl scan the front and back seats. Even if she had been sick, she'd never tell her grandmother for fear of being offered one of Pearl's Healing Remedies. She'd had enough of those over her lifetime to know the spicy tea concoctions only resulted in hot sweats and trips to the bathroom, which of course, Pearl said was the point.

Pearl wrinkled her nose. "I see you inherited your mother's love of cozy clutter, as she would call it."

"I have a small trunk," Florence sighed, turning around as another passing car called out to Pearl, something about "Mortimer loved the liver shake!"

"Well, I suppose it makes sense since you'll be staying home for good now," Pearl said wryly.

Florence smiled at the obligatory now-you're-home-and-here-to-stay comment that happened every visit to Windia. Pearl looked up from her survey of Florence's Volvo and locked eyes with her granddaughter. Her soft eyes said everything.

"I do love it when you're home."

Opening the driver's side door, Florence hesitated before she climbed in. She had to compose herself, carefully constructing the expression she showed her grandmother, who could read her like a book she'd written herself. When she was finally sure her eyes had no hint of tears and her smile was brisk and genuine, Florence returned her gaze to her grandmother.

"Home is Portland now." She tried to sound convincing. "Remember, this is just Christmas break."

"And New Year's," Pearl added, her heavily-adorned finger wagging in her granddaughter's direction.

"Also, I lost my job, so who knows where I'll end up." Florence had no reservations about sharing her job loss with Pearl, a woman who had made it through most of her existence by avoiding conventional work. Her stint as operator of The Yurt (or Sea Witch Coffee) was the closest she had ever

gotten. Also, her grandmother was not one to dole out criticism, instead shrugging in response, as if to say *onto the next*.

Opening the passenger side door, Pearl shoved the pile of empty snack bags to the floor and held Florence's patchwork tote bag in her lap. Florence started the car just as a sprinkle of rain started to fall from the sky. Pearl smiled up into the sky and Florence could almost read her mind.

Florence was home in Windia. The rain was falling in a gentle shower. Now they'd travel that familiar route to the coffee shop where all roads seemed to lead and endless beginnings seemed to blossom.

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Chapter Three

AT FIRST, FLORENCE THOUGHT the thick clouds outside The Yurt were the result of some sort of random ocean phenomena, a reality they had all grown used to being only steps away from the sea. But when she and Pearl pulled into the parking space in front of the shop it became apparent the clouds were actually smoke, not ocean mist.

"Oh sweet Gaia," Pearl sighed. "Mia's been baking again."

Smoke sneaked out of every creak and crevice of The Yurt, from the original double doorway painted a sandy gold to the little stovepipe poking out from the rooftop, the seagull-shaped chimney cover rattling in the wind. With a pent-up burst of smoke, Florence's sister-in-law Mia Mackenzie yanked open a front window, sticking her head out for an inhale of fresh air. Her long dark hair fell out of her braid, sweaty tendrils sticking to her flushed face. She closed her eyes in an obvious attempt to calm herself and when she opened them, looked straight into Florence and Pearl's souls.

Both granddaughter and grandmother ducked as Florence began to unbuckle her seatbelt. "I guess we should go help."

"Darling, no one can help Mia's baking," Pearl grumbled as she climbed out of the car.

Passing several coughing customers on her way up the thick porch steps to The Yurt, Florence felt the chill of the ocean at her back and the burn of Mia's intense look on her face.

"Don't say it," she warned through the window before disappearing back inside The Yurt. She reappeared moments later in the doorway, dressed in jeans, a T-shirt, and a filthy cotton apron covered in greasy handprints. She pulled Florence in for a tight hug.

"Say what? That I love you and I'm excited to see you?" Florence knew Mia was referencing the many, many years of teasing remarks that her sister-in-law had endured over her baking and cooking skills. And Florence was typically the worst offender of all, especially given she was the annoying younger sibling of Mia's husband and childhood sweetheart.

But several years ago, Florence stopped teasing. Several years ago, everything changed.

"Just couldn't wait till I got back, could you?" Pearl huffed as she stomped up the porch steps. Pearl was the heart behind the food served at The Yurt and her baked sweet and savory treats were known far and wide.

Mia pulled back from her embrace and looked at Florence. "Customers were asking for more lemon bars," she called out, closing her eyes in resignation. Mia had been with this family long enough to know it wasn't worth the battle. "And I didn't know how long you'd be gone."

"There's no time limit on the wind!" Pearl hollered from the kitchen located at the back of The Yurt. Her voice was then drowned out by the clanking of pots and pans and the whir of the food processor.

Mia sighed heavily and opened her eyes again. "I love you and I'm excited to see you, too," she laughed, wrapping her arm around Florence's shoulder and walking her inside.

Of all the things that had changed inside The Yurt over all the years, the things that never seemed to change were the smell and the light. They went hand in hand for Florence, woven clearly into an intricate tapestry of

memories. The Yurt smelled of old, seasoned wood floorboards, sharp spices laced with spray from the sea, and of course, bold, dark coffee. The entrance to The Yurt opened right into the structure that earned the coffee shop its moniker, offering panoramic views through the original heavy glass windows installed to stand the test of the time. Those windows had provided views of countless ocean storms, glittering sunsets, and quiet mornings. Blue, amber, gray, diffused white; The Yurt glowed with a kaleidoscope of Pacific Northwest colors every day for the patrons that walked through or settled at one of the tables scattered throughout The Yurt, all located in the same place Great-Grandfather Mackenzie had placed them himself.

As the town grew and so did the traffic, The Yurt grew as well. An expanded shop space and a proper coffee counter with a posted menu were built in the 1970s. It was around the time that Pearl took over that a glass window box display was installed beneath the long driftwood counter, filled with Pearl's baked goods, handmade amulets, and a countless rotation of treasures found on the shore. A small chalkboard on the countertop listed the drink special for the day.

"I'll try a Salted Sea Mussel Macchiato," Florence ordered. "With sand sprinkles, of course."

"Decaf?" Mia asked with an arched eyebrow, looking past Florence to the nearly-setting sun that sparkled off the ocean waters like firelight.

Florence gasped. "You insult me."

"Okay, it's your sleep." Mia shrugged as she grabbed a mug. "Tell me about P-Town. How's Harper?"

"Harper is good, she's great actually." Florence walked around the lobby of the coffee shop, her hands running over the familiar and examining the

new. "I love Portland, there's lots to see and do. I lost my job. They just built this new little brewery down the street from my apartment and they make the best ciders."

Mia stared at Florence flatly as her sister-in-law rambled on, sprinkling the final touches on the Salted Sea Mussel Macchiato. She waited until Florence was done before handing over the steaming mug. Florence took the mug, which was shaped like a lighthouse, and tried to read Mia's face. If she had picked up on the "I lost my job" comment at all, she wasn't showing it. Or maybe she was saving her big sister talk for later.

A shuffling sound drew both women's attention as Mia's 7-year-old daughter, Diana, rounded the corner. It was an old name for such a young girl, but with her long dark hair and porcelain skin, it seemed to fit her well. Mia had been fascinated with Roman mythology since junior high school when she presented a project on various myths for English class. That would be the same class where she would meet Diana's father and start a journey that would eventually make her part of the Mackenzie clan.

Florence bent down and gave her niece a long hug. "Every time I visit you feel so much taller," Florence remarked.

"And every time you say that," Diana retorted with a smile.

"And every time you say that I said that."

Aunt and niece burst into laughing. Diana really did seem taller since Florence's last visit over the summer. And she probably had new interests and new outfits and new discoveries to share. Florence took a long, heavy drink of her macchiato. These were some of the things she missed.

Mia checked her watch and began walking around The Yurt, flipping over the "closed" sign and shutting all the open windows. The Pacific's powerful breeze had made quick work of clearing the smoke from Mia's

burnt lemon bars. It was now dark outside and the only remaining evidence of the sea was the sound of the roaring waves crashing and withdrawing against the sand.

The smell had greatly improved inside The Yurt as well, with Pearl emerging from the back kitchen with one tray of savory chicken, apricot, and pork pies and another tray of leek, goat's cheese, walnut, and lemon tarts. Items such as these had regularly taken the place of dinner in the Mackenzie household over the years. Without a word, each girl rushed to the counter and took a treat in each hand, sighing as the first bite melted into their mouth. They turned as the front door of the shop opened and a man walked through.

Tall and well-dressed in a tailored blue suit, the man smoothed any stray strands of his slick dark hair. He stopped in the doorway and paused at the women's surprised expressions, turning around and pointing at the door.

"It was unlocked-" he started to explain and then stopped mid-sentence when he had to dodge a half-eaten pork pie thrown in his direction.

"I told you to leave!" Mia shouted, who was the flinger of the pork pie.

Florence watched with wide eyes as her grandmother and sister-in-law descended upon the well-dressed man, who held up his hands in a show of submission. She put down her lemon tart and brushed off her hands, ready to join Mia and Pearl in whatever skirmish they had planned. She turned to her niece, who was watching from her seat behind the counter, appearing only mildly interested in the raised voices bouncing around The Yurt.

"What is going on?" Florence asked.

Diana shrugged and took another bite of pork pie. "You know, usual stuff."

"If you'd just let me say-" Well-Dressed Man tried to speak again, a little louder this time.

Pearl waved a spatula at Well-Dressed Man, who was now backing up towards the doorway.

"There is nothing else to say, blasphemer!" she roared.

"Blasphemer? Really?" he chuckled nervously.

The spatula was then pointed directly at Well-Dressed Man. "Don't make me use this."

"Ladies, no need for violence, I hear you loud and clear," Well-Dressed Man soothed, reaching for the front door. He looked up and locked eyes with Florence, a glimpse of hope flickering in his smile. "Hello there, we haven't met. I'm-"

Well-Dressed Man couldn't finish his sentence before getting whacked in the head by Pearl's spatula. Florence gasped and covered her mouth. Even Mia stopped chattering in response to the attack, even though she'd been the first to throw down the gauntlet. No one said a word as Well-Dressed Man carefully fixed his hair and nodded curtly. With one last glance at Florence, he opened the door and officially left The Yurt, slamming the door behind him.

Pearl gave her spatula a triumphant kiss and turned to the younger women. "Well, that took care of that!"

Chapter Four

IT TURNED OUT THAT Well-Dressed Man had a name (Samson Richards,) a vague background (affiliated with an expanding coffee empire,) and a reason for drawing the ire of the Mackenzie women. According to Mia, a week before Florence's arrival, Samson Richards had "waltzed into The Yurt like he owned the place, ordered a large plain latte, and presented the Mackenzie's with a contract." The contract, according to Pearl, "threatened to destroy the very heartstrings of the Mackenzie legacy in Windia." In less dramatic terms, the contract was an offer to buy The Yurt and its land before Samson Richard's coffee empire client comes to Windia and lures away all their customers.

"So, buy The Yurt or competition comes to town?" Florence attempted to clarify.

"Oh, competition is coming to town no matter what, he made that abundantly clear." Mia yanked at a stubborn branch of rosemary and accidentally uprooted the entire bush. It was the same sort of vigor that Florence recognized from high school lacrosse games. Mia looked to see if Pearl had noticed and quickly patted the plant back in the earth.

Florence, Pearl, and Mia were out in the front garden of the family home, conveniently built by Great-Grandfather Mackenzie right behind The Yurt. In the spring and summer, the garden was packed with wildflowers, sunflowers, sweet peas, ground cherries, towering stalks of corn, and vines of tangled pole beans. But in the winter, the garden was reduced down to its

skeleton, picked clean by their wandering chickens. Beneath the garden soil dormant life dreamed of next spring, but for now the hearty rosemary bushes served the Mackenzie's well, and luckily for Windia, Pearl made a wicked lemon rosemary cookie.

"Just to make sure I completely understand," Florence started carefully. She was all for supporting family, but sometimes she wondered if Windia had its own way of thinking, separate from the rest of the world. It was time to insert some Portland-way-of-thinking. "We're mad because this man offered us money for the shop before he plans to build another coffee shop in town, creating healthy competition, which is his right to do so?"

Mia and Pearl both stopped and stared at Florence as though she had just uttered the most profane word for the first time. Mia opened her mouth to talk but Pearl shushed her.

"I'll handle this," she said.

Mia looked at her watch. "I have to go pick up Diana, anyway."

With a parting look, Mia left to retrieve Diana from school. Florence felt five-years-old as Pearl dropped down her basket of rosemary and approached her granddaughter. Her eyes spoke volumes.

"Have you forgotten what this place represents?" Pearl asked firmly, her gaze unwavering as she stopped within arm's reach.

Florence shook her head, fighting back the tears that burned around her eyes. "I haven't."

"Then you don't care."

"Of course I do! This is our family home. But maybe it's time-"

"Time for what?"

"To let it go...to move on."

Pearl searched Florence's eyes, a moment of realization flickering across her face. She sighed. "I see, now. Why hadn't I seen it before? I guess I'm getting old. And I guess I thought you too young."

Florence said nothing, the lump in her throat growing heavier and heavier.

"Your mother and brother really do feel everywhere." Pearl looked around and found a dozen memories, a hundred more if she really stopped and listened.

Florence agreed. And that was the reason why she left four years ago, at a Christmastime much like this. At the end of a year that claimed both her mother and her brother, leaving Mia with a young child and no support, leaving Florence and Pearl with a coffee shop and no proprietor. Florence's mother had been everything to the shop - the heart, the bloodstream, and soul. She had been everything and more.

"And aren't those memories worth fighting for?" Pearl insisted, grabbing Florence by the shoulders. "For Mia, for Diana...for us?"

Melting into her grandmother's arms, Florence wept into her jasmine and orange blossom embrace. Sometimes the love and pain she held for this place became too much, intertwined in a confusing web of contradictory feelings. Pearl held her granddaughter until the tears transitioned into hiccups and the hiccups transitioned into sniffles. Eventually, Florence's breathing returned under her control and she pulled away, wiping her face on her flannel sleeve.

"Okay." Florence cleared her throat. "I'm good."

"Good," Pearl echoed. "Because there's something else."

Florence blinked her swollen eyes and wiped her face again. "What?"

"A small problem." The look on Pearl's face had changed. Florence couldn't quite read it, but it looked...ornery. She didn't like it when her grandmother looked ornery.

"A small problem?" Florence pressed.

"That Mia doesn't know about."

"What?"

"And we need to keep it that way."

"Now I'm scared."

Waving her hands dismissively, Pearl produced her most convincing smile. "Let me begin by saying I've already spoken with my little mushroom friends and they've assured me we are quite all right," she explained.

"Oh, well, that's good to know."

"But it's about the land rights, dear."

"The land rights?"

"Yes."

"What about it?"

"Well, you know what I say about who *really* has the rights to this land, don't you? The Clatsop's were here far before Lewis and Clark and it really is garbage that-

"Pearl!" Florence exclaimed. "What is it? Are we behind on property taxes or something? What?"

Chuckling to herself, Pearl looked over into the forest, as though looking for one of her fae folk friends to help her out.

"We don't pay property taxes," Pearl said quietly.

Florence leaned a little closer. "Excuse me?"

"Because we don't..." Pearl dragged out every syllable. "Own this land."

"Own what?"

"All of this."

Florence looked around herself. She looked at her childhood home, the front garden, The Yurt, the beautiful pathway down to the Pacific crafted painstakingly by Great-Grandfather Mackenzie's very own hands. Turning slowly to her grandmother, Florence made a large sweeping motion, almost knocking herself off her feet.

"All of this?" she squeaked.

"No, darling, of course not *all* of this," Pearl crooned, doing her best to take on a calming countenance.

"Oh good," Florence breathed. "For a second, I thought-"

"We own the structures, of course," Pearl rattled on. "Anything your dear Great-Grandfather built with his very capable hands. He really was incredibly industrious, I looked up to him so. But he wasn't really a man for details. Such as purchasing land, for instance."

Florence's mouth began to slowly hang open so Pearl rushed on.

"This is such a lovely, lovely spot, we all agree. I'm sure it wasn't malicious, I'm absolutely positive about it. Your great-grandfather wouldn't pick a penny up from the ground for fear of being a thief. I'm sure he simply thought, well, this is as good a spot as any, and started to build for his family and that was that."

"No." Florence shook her head wildly. "No, not *that was that*. Cities have survey crews...they...I don't know, they have planning commissions and such. Someone had to have noticed something."

Pearl made a feeble attempt at a smile. "Not yet."

"We're essentially squatters, then," Florence resigned. Now they had a new nickname for the coffee shop.

"No, what a filthy word!" Pearl exclaimed. "We've taken care of this land like no one else. Think of all the dreams we've created for anyone that stood on that sand with a coffee in their hand."

Florence thought about this. If not for the rational side of her that insisted this was wrong and highly illegal, she didn't disagree.

"Does everyone know?" she whispered.

"No, only me. And now, you," Pearl whispered back. "I discovered it when we were preparing the transition of the shop to me as the Sea Witch. Your great-grandfather wasn't well, I didn't want to upset anyone. Well, anyway, I put it out of my mind after that."

Florence straightened her shoulders, feeling honored that her grandmother entrusted her with this information. And then a thought crossed her mind.

"So this is why you so vehemently scare off potential buyers?" Florence moaned, rubbing her head hard. "Because..."

"Because there's nothing to sell," Pearl finished.

"And if they sniff around too much..."

"They'll discover our secret and we'll all be out on our tushies."

"Or fined!" Florence added. "Or sued! Or imprisoned!"

Pearl and Florence whirled around with matching gasps as Mia's car returned to the house.

"Mia doesn't know," Pearl whispered loudly, firmly grabbing Florence's hand. "That poor girl does everything here for us, and she's got Diana...Goddess knows she has more on her shoulders than most can bear."

"Okay, okay," Florence whispered back.

Pearl turned her granddaughter's face to look her straight in the eye. Pearl's eyes were a pale blue, as though plucked from the ocean waves. "So

will you take up arms and fight?" she asked.

Mia looked over at the exchange between the two Mackenzie women as she unbuckled Diana's seatbelt. "Everything okay?" she called out.

Florence broke her gaze with Pearl. She worked hard at the expression she presented as she bent down to embrace Diana, who come bounding up to her like a puppy.

"Yes, fine," Florence called back. "We're just discussing how to give Mr. Richards a Mackenzie send-off from Windia."

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Chapter Five

FLORENCE ADJUSTED HER OVERSIZED sunglasses in the reflection of the rearview mirror. It was a typical late December rainy day in Windia and she had no reason to be wearing oversized sunglasses other than the reason that was gnawing at her stomach. Parked outside the uniquely blended grocery and hardware store known as Windia's Wonderland, Florence wrestled with the tidal wave of emotions that nearly drowned her there in the front seat of her Volvo. Windia's Wonderland belonged to the family of her old high school flame, Paulie Vandermeier, and he would no doubt be working that busy Saturday afternoon. She was sure of it.

All of Mia's rational platitudes repeated in Florence's mind. *You were the one who broke up with him. He probably doesn't even want to talk to you anymore. Grow up and go get the beans.* The Yurt was running low on both coffee and espresso beans and that was a big problem with the final afternoon coffee rush likely to show up at any moment.

She had to do this. This was stupid, she didn't even know why she felt nervous about an imagined encounter with someone she no longer cared about from a long time ago. Plus, she was on a time crunch; she had to pick up Diana from school after this shopping trip.

"Go in, get the beans, get out," Florence told her reflection, grabbing her purse and exiting the car before she could stop herself.

Stalking through the rainy parking lot, Florence already recognized three different people on her way inside, compounding her feeling of dread. But when she entered Windia's Wonderland, she was transported back to a thousand happy memories. The smell of frozen food and sawdust, the cool, overhead lights that flickered wildly when turned on and off, the sounds of cash registers, and the far-off hum of the workshop out back. There had to be no other place like it in the world and somewhere inside Florence was glad it had never changed.

Although management and mission statements had changed over the years, one thing always stayed true at The Yurt - the beans. And while no Mackenzie would ever admit to a customer what brand they purchased, most of Windia, of course, already knew. The Mackenzie's would buy their beans by the cartload at Windia's Wonderland and the loyal locals just played along, exchanging knowing glances while in line at the checkout.

Florence grabbed a cart and kept her head down, making a beeline for the coffee aisle. She didn't even have to look up for directions as the aisles hadn't changed since Windia's Wonderland's inception in the 1980s.

"Coffee?" a passing voice called out.

Stopping instinctively at one of her core words, Florence kept her head down and glanced across the aisle at a pair of cerulean blue laced boots poking out from under a long, layered skirt. Her eyes continued to trail upwards to an ivory shirt topped with a deep green velvet suit jacket. A smiling face met Florence next, nestled within a crown of tumbling dark curls. The woman stood behind a small table positioned at the end of an aisle, covered with tiny sample cups waiting to be filled from a large silver thermos. Stacks of both espresso and coffee beans sat in a box beside her, *There's magic in every bean!* printed in scrawling letters across each bag.

Florence never turned down coffee and the welcoming look on the woman's face made her forget she was in Windia's Wonderland, hiding from a potential encounter with an ex-boyfriend.

"Absolutely," Florence said, pulling down her hoodie to reveal her tousled hair.

The woman nodded and clicked open the thermos. Florence watched the contents pour into the sample cup as though time stood still. The liquid was the color of deep mahogany, the smell was light yet like the salt of the earth. Florence took a heavy inhale of the aroma before taking a sip, followed by a complete chug of the heavenly beverage.

"This is our Serendipity blend." The woman held up the bag of beans somewhat awkwardly, as though this was her first time doing a sales pitch. Mr. Vandermeyer, the owner of Windia's Wonderland, often let artisans or small vendors demonstrate their wares in the store, typically on weekends when the traffic was heavier.

After tapping every last drop out of her sample, Florence handed back her cup, feeling filled to the brim with warmth and even a tinge of...happiness?

"What company are you with?" she asked, almost in a haze. She shook her head and pushed back her sunglasses, reaching for a bag of beans and squinting at the label.

"We're based here in the northwest but our...reach everywhere."

The woman's face was so youthful yet so old, leaving Florence very confused. She shook her head, unable to understand what the woman had said. What was in this coffee?

"I'm sorry." Florence shook her head again. "Your *what* reaches everywhere?"

The woman repeated herself but Florence still couldn't make it out. The missing word was a blur, as though her mind was not allowed to understand it.

"Her *beans* reach everywhere," a voice piped in dryly. "You know, as in, shipping?"

The voice startled Florence out of her warm and fuzzy bubble as she whirled around to find Samson Richards standing behind her. He was pushing a cart filled with various packaged foods like crackers and protein bars. He still appeared to be dressed overly formal for Windia, a pair of slacks and a collared shirt visible under his black parka. Samson's expression was one of exasperation yet curiosity and it was then that Florence realized she was completely blocking the entrance to the coffee and tea aisle.

Shoving her cart to the side of the aisle, Florence lowered her sunglasses back onto the bridge of her nose. She waved for him to move by and then crossed her arms against her chest.

Nodding crisply in reply, Samson Richards first stopped at the coffee sample table, where the saleswoman was already pouring him a cup of steaming goodness. He thanked the saleswoman and watched Florence as he drank the sample, who was still staring at him with a defiant stance.

"Samson Richards." He held out his hand as he introduced himself. "I didn't get your name before your sister threw some sort of greasy pastry in my face."

"She's my sister-in-law and it was a pork pie, but yes, she's like a sister and you'd be lucky to eat one of those greasy pastries, as you call it," Florence replied, the overhead fluorescents reflecting like exploding stars in her sunglasses.

One eyebrow arched on Samson Richards' face. "So you're a Mackenzie."

"Florence Mackenzie." She had no idea why she just told him that.

"Florence Mackenzie," Samson repeated slowly. He blinked and turned to the saleswoman. "What's this called?"

"It's our Serendipity blend," the woman responded with a smile. "Do you like it?"

Samson blinked heavily a few additional times and nodded. He shook his head quickly as though shaking water out of his ears and turned back to Florence. He was just about to say something when the hourly chime rang out over the intercom.

"Oh my gosh," Florence gasped.

"What?" Samson asked, looking around.

"It's 3 o'clock, oh my gosh, it's 3 o'clock." Mia had given Florence strict instructions to be at the school right at 3 o'clock when Diana gets out of class. Florence breathlessly grabbed her cart and went running down the aisle. She skidded to a stop in front of where, for over forty years, Frank's Classically Roasted Beans had been located - one shelf for coffee beans and one shelf for espresso beans. But instead of the stacks of familiar blue and brown bags, the shelves were bare-bones empty.

"Oh my gosh," Florence gasped again, pushing up her sunglasses as though the tinted lenses were skewing her vision. "This can't be happening."

"Fungus," a familiar voice said from around the end cap. Just as Florence had feared, her ex-boyfriend Paulie Vandermeier circled the corner. He looked much like he did four years ago, except maybe a bit more tired and slumped in the shoulders. His dark brown curly hair was trimmed short and his sad puppy dog eyes studied Florence's face carefully.

"We've been out all week," Paulie continued, motioning to the empty shelves. A sign hung on the middle shelf stating, "Fungus infestation at source - no end in sight."

"No end in sight," Florence mumbled, her throat clenching at the direness of the statement. She was sweating heavily now under her hoodie that had done no good in helping to hide her from an embarrassing encounter with Paulie.

"Florie, you look great. I didn't know-" Paulie began but stopped when Florence started wildly flailing her hands.

"I'm so sorry, Paulie, I can't do this right now, I have to get coffee and I have to go get my niece," she explained frantically.

Paulie frowned. "It's Paul, now."

"Well," Florence huffed. "Then it's Florence now to you!"

Paulie apologetically followed Florence down the aisle as she raced back to the saleswoman, who had been watching the scene unfold with an amused expression on her face. Samson was still there watching too, and Florence pushed past him unceremoniously as she gathered bag after bag of Serendipity blend.

"I'll take it," Florence said as she filled her arms with bags of beans and dumped them in the cart. "Can I just pay you here? I really need to go, my little niece is waiting."

"Oh, I'm so sorry," the saleswoman said in her slow, comforting tone. "The purchases do need to go through the store's registers."

"Please!" Florence begged. "I really need to go, how much? I'll just give you the cash." She began rifling through her bag.

"Florence," Paulie interjected. "Before you go..."

"No!" Florence shouted at her ex-boyfriend, sending him back a few steps.

"I'm so sorry, I can't accept cash. The purchases do need to go through the store's POS system," the saleswoman insisted congenially.

"I'll take it, you go," Samson stepped in.

"You're not taking these!" Florence held the bags to her chest as though her life depended on it. And if she didn't return to The Yurt with coffee beans, her life *might* depend on it.

"No," Samson sighed, rolling his eyes as he reached out to peel a label off a bag of coffee beans and then one from a bag of espresso beans. "I'll take the UPCs up to the register and tell them to ring up 10 bags each. So just go get your niece."

"Oh, that's a lovely solution," the saleswoman gushed, turning to Paulie. "Isn't that lovely?"

Paulie scowled.

Florence hesitated a beat. "Really?"

"Yes, go!" Samson insisted.

"But how much cash do I give you?" Florence turned to the saleswoman. "Ma'am, how much did you say these were?"

"Do I need to pull the fire alarm?" Samson roared, stepping back as he waved for Florence to go by.

"Okay, I feel like I'm stealing, but okay..." Florence tiptoed by. She stopped and turned back, locking eyes with Samson. "Thank you."

Samson stared back. "You're welcome."

"Florence, I-" Paulie interjected.

"Oh, Paulie, stop!" Florence shouted, completely over any nerves she had about seeing her ex, which were quickly transitioning into familiar

confirmations of why she broke up with him.

Rushing out through the rain, Florence tossed the bags of beans into the car and tore off to Windia Elementary. Diana had only been waiting several minutes on the curb outside her school, declaring her silence could be bought with a large ice cream cone.

As Florence sat parked outside the Frozen Dreams ice cream parlor, allowing time for Diana to finish her bribe before turning to The Yurt, her mind wandered to the check stands at Windia's Wonderland, where a well-dressed man would be handing over a UPC label and trying to explain the whole ridiculous situation. She couldn't help it, but she began to smile for the first time that day.

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Chapter Six

" 'T WAS TWO DAYS BEFORE Christmas, and all through The Yurt, the Mackenzie girls were crazy, and one of them hurt."

"I'm fine," Mia said drolly. "It's just a scratch."

"More like a laceration," Florence retorted as she stretched to reach the top of the Christmas tree. It wouldn't be a traditional Mackenzie Christmas without rushed, last-minute decorating which usually resulted in some sort of injury. Past accidents included falling off ladders, splinters, broken ornaments, shouting matches, and much, much more.

Mia pouted from her seat behind the coffee shop's counter. She looked wonderfully festive in her red sweater, reindeer earrings, and elf headband. She held her bandaged hand up in the air, a result of rushed knife handling while opening a new box of twinkle lights.

Bopping along in rhythm with the Christmas music playing over the radio, Florence was relishing her moment at the top. Mia couldn't help customers or decorate with her fresh injury and she was very put out by it. So Florence was in charge and the energy she felt surprised even herself.

"Stop looking so bah humbug," she ordered.

"This is just for today," Mia grumbled.

"And I will love every minute of it."

"I think I need to go lay down."

"I think that's an excellent idea."

"You'll remember to--"

"-hang the tinsel last?"

"And don't forget Aunt Julie's hound dog ornament-"

"-has a loose ear that's barely holding on with tape?"

"And Barb's coming by to-"

"-drop off some fresh eggs and then we repay her with an almond milk mocha, no whip, and no charge?"

"And Diana likes to-"

"-turn on the Christmas tree lights first, but not before the tree skirt goes on, because that completes the whole look?"

Mia stared at Florence, her eyes narrowing with a hint of humor. Florence smiled. She knew why Mia did all these things and worked so hard. Mia had loved Florence's mother like her own. These Christmas traditions were her mother's traditions. This shop was her shop and Mia fought each day to keep it that way. Mia nodded, secure in the knowledge that Florence truly *did* know what she was doing, and left for a well-deserved afternoon nap.

Florence looked around the shop, alone for the first time in a long time. It was early afternoon and the sea was roaring outside with frothing, tumbling waves visible through the rain-splattered window glass. The shop still smelled like the gingerbread cookies that Pearl had baked before taking Diana out for an afternoon walk. But Pearl's cookies were no ordinary gingerbread men; they were owls and narwhals and even Bigfoot himself. The wind gave a great burst and rattled the seagull atop the chimney, a sound so familiar to Florence that it conjured a hundred different memories at a time, all taking place there in the center of that little coffee shop.

With another burst of wind, the front door opened and a heavily bundled figure entered the shop, pushing the door closed behind them. Beneath a

furry hood was Barb's smiling face, flushed from the exertions of fighting the ocean winds. She motioned that she was catching her breath and held out two cartons of farm-fresh eggs.

"Your grandmother said..." Barb huffed. "It was an emergency."

"An egg emergency, yep, that sounds like her," Florence laughed as she took the cartons. "Almond milk mocha, right?"

"Yes," Barb answered contentedly. She followed Florence further into the shop, admiring the Christmas tree on the way. "Well, you know she can't make egg strata with store-bought eggs. That would be a travesty."

Florence laughed and stopped when she realized Barb was completely serious.

"Do you think I could ask for two mochas?" Barb seemed hesitant to ask, likely knowing it would prompt a follow-up question.

"Oh?" Florence asked with a small smile. "For anyone I know?"

Barb blushed deeply, a red that rivaled the velvet ribbon on a jar of peppermints she was examining.

"How is Mark doing?" Florence did, of course, know who the second mocha was for. Mark was Barb's longtime unrequited love, a polite and quiet man who knew nothing of her adoration. Barb and Mark had worked together in the same small office space at the telephone company for over 10 years; she scheduling and taking payments, he going out on service calls. Together they kept Windia connected, although they themselves were terribly disconnected. But the way they took care of each other was a true office marriage that left most people wondering why it had never left the walls of Windia Telephone and Internet.

"He's doing great," Barb answered quickly, her eyes lighting up. "He's going to buy a boat soon, he's been saving up since I've known him. I'm so

happy for him, it's his dream."

"Oh, is he leaving the phone company?" Florence asked as she looked below the counter for lids. "Is it already retirement time?"

She meant it as light conversation but when Florence emerged from below the counter she realized her comment had cut Barb to her very soul. All the lovely red had drained from her face and she clutched the cross around her neck as though warding off evil spirits.

"No, no," Florence stammered. "I'm sure he's not leaving. He wouldn't leave! What would you do? What would we do, I mean? He's not retiring, he's way too young. Fishing is for the weekends only, anyway."

Barb nodded absently, still stunned by Florence's suggestion. In hopes of steadying her longtime family friend, Florence placed a warm almond milk mocha in each hand.

"Have some coffee," Florence urged as if she was dispensing a prescription.

Barb nodded tearfully and took a long sip. She paused, looked at Florence, and took another sip. "This tastes different," she said, taking a longer drink. "Good different, mind you."

Florence beamed. If only Mia was here to see this, who, 24 hours later, was still upset that Florence didn't demand to check the back stock rooms of Windia's Wonderland for more Frank's Classically Roasted Beans.

"It's a new blend we are trying out, just started today." Florence wrapped up a handful of gingerbread cookies and handed them to Barb, who cradled her and Mark's coffees as though they were filled with a life-saving elixir.

"Well, I love it," Barb gushed, rushing towards the door. "And I must get this to Mark while it's nice and hot."

With another gust of wind, Barb left and passed another customer on the way in. Florence could tell it was a man by his stature and her heart skipped a bit when he pulled down his hoodie, revealing a more casually dressed Samson. Even though he was wearing jeans and a black hoodie, he still managed to look dapper, as though those jeans and that hoodie had been tailored just for him.

Samson peeked around the edges of his hoodie collar at the empty coffee shop. "No pork pie-flinging sister-in-law's around?"

Florence crossed her arms, mostly to cover the coffee stains all over her shirt. "No, she's napping."

Samson entered The Yurt a few more steps, slicking back his damp dark hair. "How about any spatula-wielding grandmothers?"

"Out for a walk. And she's with my little niece, in case you're afraid of her, too."

"Oh, she's who I'm most afraid of," Samson said gravely, a smile pulling at the corner of his mouth. "I recognize a killer instinct in her eyes, already."

Florence frowned even though she knew he was joking. "Recognize a killer instinct," she repeated. "Since you see the same in yourself, you mean? If you're here to threaten..."

Samson held up his hands in mock surrender and approached the counter that separated him from Florence. "I'm only here to have an actual conversation with the sanest Mackenzie I've met so far."

Florence thought back to her behavior at Windia's Wonderland. Mia and Pearl must've really put this guy through the wringer.

"And, I would like to honestly and succinctly explain what we're offering," he continued, pausing as he waited for any kind of resistance

from Florence. "Does that work for you?"

Florence motioned for him to continue. Samson reached into his back pants pocket and pulled out a rolled-up bunch of papers, smoothing them out across the countertop.

"This is only a preliminary offer, just to gauge your interest and see where we can meet in the middle," Samson explained. His voice seemed to change in tone, as though he was making a board presentation. "You have an amazing spot here, I don't know how you ever got it."

Florence struggled to control the raging blush that was spreading across her face like wildfire. He either *did not* know they didn't own the property, or he *did* know and was baiting her. Something inside told her that Samson was a bit more straightforward than that. She said nothing and motioned for him to continue.

Samson straightened up, as though this was the furthest he had ever got in his presentation. "Well, let me say first we have no interest in simply coming to Windia and running you all out of business. Which would likely happen, in all honesty, if we came to town."

Florence's face flushed with a different kind of heat, now.

"After all," Samson continued, motioning around the coffee shop. "My father started off much like you all, with a small shop of his own in Portland. He'd like to see you all taken care of."

Florence's eyes began to narrow.

"Windia's not big enough for both of us, you know that. So we'd like to send you off with a pocket full of money and we'll take over from here." Samson exhaled loudly. He pushed the offer further across the countertop. "I think you'll be pleasantly surprised."

Clearing her throat, Florence reached out for the offer and scanned the first few lines. Her eyes stopped and she looked over the page at Samson's face.

He grinned in response. "Good, right?"

"Samson Richards," she said.

He blinked. "Yes?"

"Samson. Sam's *son*." Now Florence's face went pure crimson.

"Yes, that was the general idea when I was named."

"Sam's 'Spresso. Your father is Sam of Sam's 'Spresso."

"That's right...is there a problem?"

"Sam's 'Spresso wants to buy my family's shop?"

In an instant, the offer was slapped back down on the counter.

"I used to work for Sam's 'Spresso." Florence felt her voice begin to shake, which was never a good sign. It was like the early warning tremors before a volcano explodes. "Until your father fired me."

"Well," Samson grumbled as he gathered the offer off the countertop and tucked it under his arm. "I can't ever imagine why."

"Get out! Your family will never, *ever* own this shop!" The walls seemed to reverberate with the recognition of the Mackenzie rage. The Yurt was used to this behavior.

"Then you leave us no choice!" Samson threw up his hands, backing up towards the front door. "You are the most impossible group of women I've--"

The rest of Samson's statement was stopped when a gingerbread Bigfoot struck him square in the face. Florence had another up and ready, her arm twisted back and prepared to launch. Samson stared at Florence for a beat then reached down for the cookie, taking a giant bite out of Bigfoot's head. He pointed the headless cookie in Florence's direction.

"It's on!"

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Chapter Seven

EVEN IN THE MIDST of chaos or uncertainty, there was always comfort to be found in holiday traditions. And for Florence, after her brother and mother died, these traditions became even more important to uphold, afraid to let those last remnants of their hearts and soul disappear forever. That's why she kept coming home year after year, even though it hurt, and it scared her that this year it felt more important than ever. But now, in the Christmas Eve kitchen with the last light of a busy day fading away, Florence forgot the world outside and focused on the simple joy of prepping a Christmas morning strata.

"You're sure you have this covered?" Mia asked, the bags under her eyes threatening to drag her down to the ground. She'd been all over town that day, taking Diana to see Santa, picking up last-minute gifts, and stopping by two different cookie exchange parties hosted by her friends. The Yurt was closed on Christmas Eve and Christmas Day, it had always been that way. No business on holidays, Great-Grandfather Mackenzie would say. Considering what Florence had recently learned of their decades-long squatting on prime Windia beach property, Florence began to scrutinize her great-grandfather's business practices a bit more closely.

Florence looked at Mia mid-egg crack. "Really?"

The Mackenzie women were all gathered around the kitchen island, the unfinished traditional Christmas morning strata between them. The smell of fresh eggs, bacon, and yesterday's bread hung in the air with hints of their

fir Christmas tree and a cranberry-scented candle wafting in from the living room.

"Go to bed, dear," Pearl insisted gently, but Florence caught a bit of orneriness in her voice. Mia was too tired and Diana was too young to notice.

Or was she? "Santa would want you to go to bed, too," Diana chimed in demurely.

They all exchanged glances over Mia's head, which was now resting on the kitchen island countertop.

"You're right," Mia yawned. "Anyway, I'm sure Di will have us all up bright and early."

"You know it," Diana said as she ushered her mother in the direction of the bedrooms. After exchanging good-nights, Diana turned to Pearl and gave an exaggerated wink, to which Pearl responded with a big thumbs up.

Florence waited until she heard two doors shut then whipped around to her grandmother. "What are you up to?" she whispered.

Pearl rummaged through the kitchen junk drawer loudly, dumping out note pads and chip clips and old birthday candles. She triumphantly pulled out a large permanent black marker and waved it around like a wand.

"Just a little bit of magic," she said with a sly smile. "You want in?"

"That depends." Florence had been dragged into "just a little bit of magic" more times than she could count. Her role as co-conspirator in her grandmother's antics over the years had landed them in embarrassment, hot water, and the occasional triumph.

Pearl reached over for her purse, pulling out handfuls of leaves and sprinkling them on the counter. Florence gasped and saved the strata,

covering it with foil and placing it in the refrigerator until tomorrow morning.

"Oh, I think you'll want to partake, especially considering how mad you were last night," Pearl said as she turned her purse over to shake out every leaf.

Florence washed her hands at the sink, stinging as she thought back to her exchange with Sam's 'Spresso offspring Samson Richards. She silently dried her hands and folded the kitchen towel neatly. Outside the big bay window over the sink, the ocean roared in the darkness of early night. To most people, it said *stay in and rest*. To Florence, she heard *it's time for mischief*.

"What are we doing?" Florence asked quietly as she joined her grandmother at the kitchen island, glancing around the corner to make sure Mia and Diana were still in their rooms.

"Excellent." Pearl spread the leaves out across the counter, each leaf varying with different amounts of dampness, spottiness, and color. It was obvious from their texture and smell that they had been in Pearl's bag since her forest walk with Diana the day before.

"I had a chat with Rowena yesterday," Pearl explained as she inspected leaf after leaf. "She's always at the top of my phone tree when I need a nice, earthy banishment spell."

"Wait." Florence shook her head. "Ms. Rowena, the librarian?"

"Yes."

"Is a witch?"

"Come now, dear, you know better than that. She's a *practicing Wiccan*," Pearl corrected.

"And she's given you banishment spells exactly how many times before?"

Pearl wriggled and shrugged her shoulders, her eyes squinting as though tallying numbers in her head.

"Oh dear, never mind," Florence breathed heavily, rethinking some past boyfriends that suddenly relocated to another state. "Okay, is this about Samson Richards?"

Pearl smiled and nodded. She waved her hand across the countertop of leaves in a flourish. "Pick the leaf that speaks to you."

"Why me?"

"Just do it."

Florence skimmed the counter and chose a particularly crisp-looking leaf with strong veins and a distinct light and dark side. She held it up and Pearl quickly discarded the other leaves, handing her granddaughter the permanent marker.

"Next, write his full name on one side of the leaf," Pearl instructed magically.

"This isn't going to kill him, is it?" Florence clarified.

"No, of course not," Pearl snapped.

"I don't know his middle name."

"It's Elijah."

"And how do you know that?"

"Just do it."

Florence obeyed and wrote *Samson Elijah Richards* in the neatest writing she could manage on a forest leaf. She held it up for her grandmother's inspection.

"Good, good," Pearl whispered, carefully taking the leaf in her hand. "Now, go get your coat and boots. We're going for a walk."

Tiptoeing quietly into the laundry/mudroom, Florence returned to the kitchen and bundled up. Her grandmother was somehow completely ready to go once she returned, even though 30 seconds earlier she was wearing her Christmas-themed pajamas and fuzzy slippers.

Leaf carefully cradled in her hand, Pearl motioned for Florence to join her at the kitchen door that led outside. They opened it slowly, inch by inch, attempting to avoid the tell-tale creaking associated with that door. This was not a task for skeptical Mia or apprentice Diana.

As the two Mackenzie's passed through the doorway, Florence turned to Pearl. "There's a phone tree?"

Pearl patted Florence on the arm. "I'll tell you later."



This was not the first time her grandmother had led her on an evening adventure through the woods and Florence was sure it wouldn't be the last. Even with the ocean literally at their fingertips, the forest always seemed to be Pearl's place of retreat, where she disappeared to de-stress, reconnect, and like tonight, get into mischief.

"So did you have to do this for all the past potential buyers?" Florence asked as she stepped carefully along one of the many foot trails her grandmother had etched in the forest floor. The Yurt was unique in countless ways, one being the ocean in the front yard and the forest in the back, as though the coffee shop served as a portal between the two.

Pearl hacked at a protruding blackberry bush vine with her walking staff.
"No, certainly not. This guy is especially sticky."

"And we are *not* killing him, right?" Florence clarified again, unplugging her boot from a bog of mud.

"No." Pearl turned around and shined the flashlight in Florence's face.
"And why, do you care?"

"Of course I care!" Florence pushed away at the flashlight beam.

"About him or killing?" Pearl drew closer with the flashlight to inspect her granddaughter's expression.

"Him! Killing! Killing him! Why are we even talking about this?"

"You brought it up. Maybe we should go back."

"No. No!" Florence insisted, stomping in place. "Just tell me what we're doing!"

Pearl lowered the flashlight. "Well, you don't have to yell," she said primly. "I'll tell you."

And Pearl did tell Florence, filling her in on the specific details of Ms. Rowena's Earthy Banishment Spell. The intended's name was to be written boldly and clearly on a leaf of choice, one that would withstand the current of a winter river's rage. Under a waxing moon, just like the one on that crisp, Christmas Eve night, the leaf was to be placed upon a rushing river stream to be carried away to another place, just as the intended will be. No killing or violence involved, just a simple whisking away by the river waters that were going that way, anyway.

After walking for some time, the sound of Florence and Pearl's crunching footsteps were drowned out by the approaching river rapids. Florence could almost feel the spray of water in her face even before spotting the river, as though water droplets were hanging in the air. Finally, they reached the

river's edge, a burst of brightness after walking beneath the dark and shadowy forest canopy. Florence felt cold and a little afraid, even with Pearl by her side. The creatures of the forest watched and listened.

Pearl started whispering to herself and Florence took that as a sign it was time to release the leaf into the water. She read Samson's name one more time, stopping with a moment of hesitation. But she loved her family and loved her home and she couldn't let anyone threaten that. Besides, it was just a friendly nudging out of town.

The river seemed to leap up and snatch the leaf and before Florence could blink, Samson Elijah Richards vanished into the darkness.

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Chapter Eight

CHRISTMAS DAY TRANSPORTED THE Mackenzie's to a world away from their problems, where traditions and presents and good food wrapped them in a soft cocoon. Mia relaxed, truly relaxed, knowing The Yurt was closed up tight for the holiday and there were no activities to be done. Pearl spent the day not cooking, reflecting on the completeness that came from her family being all together. Diana bounced from one present to another, from art supplies to a new pair of headphones to a walking staff just like Pearl's. For Florence, Christmas Day allowed her a break from her thoughts on unemployment, her family's lack of property ownership, and the fact that she'd just banished Samson Richards down the river.

By the end of the day, there was one more tradition to be completed. They always sang Christmas carols in the darkened living room, with only the Christmas tree lights to illuminate their faces. In the past, the carols were always led by Florence's mother, but in her absence Pearl took the reins and led the songs ferociously, the hint of tears outlining her eyes and threatening to release. Florence learned if she closed her eyes and sang loudly with the others it was as though they were all truly together, after all.



December 26 was business as usual, with morning alarms set (except for Diana, who was on Christmas break.) The dark morning air was filled with the smell of maple cinnamon rolls, strawberry and rosemary scones, and of course, coffee. Florence knew she could claim she was "on vacation" and sleep in, but she would never really do it. Helping out at The Yurt didn't feel like work, it felt like another normal daily activity like eating lunch or brushing her teeth.

As she unlocked the front door, Florence was surprised to find a customer already waiting outside. The days following Christmas were usually sleepy ones, allowing the Mackenzie's a gradual return to normalcy.

"Good morning," Florence greeted, stepping aside.

"Morning," the customer chattered, rushing inside The Yurt. "Cold out there! Hope you have the heater on."

Before Florence could process what was going on, a stream of customers followed suit, dutifully lining up one behind the other until no other patrons could fit inside the warm building. Squeezing past the last customer, Florence braced the December wind and blinked into the bleary morning light. The line of customers stretched down the block, bundled Windian after bundled Windian, some chatting and laughing as they waited for the line to move. Florence rubbed her eyes and looked again. She had never seen anything like it.

One excitedly-waving customer snapped Florence out of her confused trance. Barb was dressed in a deep red sweater with a poinsettia-patterned scarf wrapped around her neck. Her cheeks were flushed, complimenting her beaming smile. Standing beside her was Barb's secret love Mark, who was dressed in a heavy coat and gray wool cap.

"Florence!" Barb squealed. "Did you have a good Christmas? How was the strata?"

Florence jogged over to Barb and Mark, who were approximately 30th in line. She still felt stupefied at the size of the crowd and it took her a few beats to find her voice.

"Good, it was good," Florence stammered. "Barb, what is going on? I've never seen this many customers in my life!" She pinched herself for good measure.

Barb looked around, as though she had just noticed that the line stretched to the front and back of her. She shrugged. "Well, honey, your coffee is amazing! We've all been talking about it!"

"You have?"

"Why, yes, especially that new blend. It really is amazing!" Barb shivered and nestled into Mark's shoulder. He leaned over to give Barb a kiss on the forehead and whispered something in her ear, which prompted a giggly, "Oh stop!"

Florence's mouth dropped open.

"In fact," Barb continued. "Something about those two coffees I picked up from you got us talking." Her eyes searched Mark's face, who met her gaze steadily. "We realized how much we meant to each other."

"I'll have enough money saved up for my boat soon," Mark chimed in. "We're going to leave the phone company and fish together."

"It'll be such an adventure!" Barb said breathlessly.

At this point, Barb and Mark didn't seem to notice Florence even existed, as they chattered away about future plans the way new lovers do.

"I'm so happy for you." Florence almost choked up as she gave her friend a hug. There was nothing like seeing well-deserved happiness finally come

to someone that had waited so long and patiently.

Realizing the line had not moved an inch since she ran up to Barb, Florence could almost hear Mia shouting out for her in her mind.

"I better go," Florence excused herself. "Again, I am so happy for you."

"We'll see you in there!" Barb exclaimed, holding up a rhinestone coffee tumbler. "Mark bought me this!"

Florence hoped Barb and Mark were ready for a lengthy wait. She dashed past the line of customers and squeezed inside to the warmth of The Yurt, a heat that had multiplied tenfold with the additional bodies packed into the small space. Florence had also never heard it so loud inside The Yurt, creating a melody of laughs and yawns and plans for the day. Above it all the familiar clanking of baking sheets, the whirl of the mixer, and the diluted curses of Pearl could be heard in the back kitchen. Mia never stood in the same spot for more than two seconds as she moved from register, to coffee bar, to window box. She saw Florence approaching and threw up her arms, flailing them wildly.

"What is going on?" she gasped. She threw an apron in Florence's direction as she joined her behind the counter.

"It's the new blend," Florence said between breaths, putting the apron on backwards. She turned in time for Pearl to shove a dozen warm chocolate scones into her arms, which rallied a gasp of excitement from the waiting customers. Florence placed them on the counter and smiled as she took the next customer's order.

As Mia stood steaming milk, she grabbed a bag of Serendipity blend beans and inspected the label. She turned the bag around again and again. "Have you tried any? What's so special about it?"

Florence met Mia at the espresso machine. "I tried it at the store. It was good, it had a kick," she explained, adding spookily, "They say there's magic in every bean."

Mia shook her head. "Don't let your grandmother hear that." She handed off a few finished drinks and watched as the front door opened, allowing one customer out and another one in. "How many people are out there, exactly?"

Florence thought carefully before answering, weighing the risk of the full truth versus a half-truth. She finally settled on, "A lot." Before Mia could question her further, Florence turned to the next customer.

"What can I get you?" she asked.

The customer's face was toasty warm and he was seemingly unfazed by the long wait to reach the counter.

"I've gotta try some of your new house blend," he said. "Everyone's talking about it!" The customer grabbed a chocolate scone from the counter. "And this, too. You all are the best. I can't believe this new guy, thinks he stands a chance! I'll keep coming here, for sure."

Florence stopped pouring milk and turned to look at the customer. Her ears began to burn.

"New guy?" she queried in a high-pitched voice.

"Yeah," the customer replied mid-bite. "The guy with the cart downtown? Sam something...I don't know, just saw it there this morning." He brushed his hands as he finished the last bite of the scone. "Man, Pearl can really bake."

Florence could hear her heart pounding in her ears and the flush in her cheeks take over her entire face. She handed the iced peppermint mocha to the customer and stared at his lips, trying to make out what he was saying.

"How much?" he asked.

Florence waved her hands and shook her head, communicating *no charge*.

The customer beamed. "You guys really are the best!"

Before the next customer could reach the counter, Florence backed away towards the kitchen. "I'm just taking a quick break!" she shouted before turning and running into the kitchen, Mia's protests following close behind.

The small kitchen at the back of The Yurt was truly Pearl's space, with an old Kalamazoo Princess cookstove, herbs hanging from the ceiling to dry, and piles upon piles of baking sheets and cookbooks. The space smelled amazing, packed with a hundred different aromas that all complimented each other perfectly. The windows were open to compete with the heat of the stove and Pearl's own body heat as she flittered from one corner of the kitchen to the other. Diana had woken from her 14 hours of sleep and was now sitting at the kitchen island, sampling whatever treat was on the cooling rack for breakfast.

"Grandma!" Florence huffed, panic stealing her breath. "We've got a problem!"

Pearl swung around with a sheet full of sausage, egg, and cheese breakfast rolls, allowing it to clatter to the countertop as she picked up the next awaiting tray, shoved it in the oven, and slammed the door. She put a hand on her hip and turned to look her granddaughter up and down.

"Well, if you're calling me Grandma, it must be pretty bad."

Florence composed herself, grabbing a breakfast roll off the tray. She took a big bite and fanned her mouth.

"The spell," she said between bites. "It didn't work. One of the customers just told me Samson's opened some sort of coffee stand downtown."

Pearl slammed the lid down on a pot boiling atop the stove, immediately pivoting to a long roll of dough stretched across a nearby cutting board sprinkled with flour. She smiled to herself before talking.

"If you remember correctly, magic doesn't always happen overnight. Sometimes there are logistics involved." She raised an eyebrow. "And sometimes magic manifests in ways we don't expect."

Diana looked to her aunt, whose face suddenly turned bright red. Florence knew exactly what her grandmother was referring to and it involved a teenage version of herself and a spell to expand upon certain parts of her body. That spell had resulted in a padded undergarment arriving in the mail the next day.

"Well, we can't sit on our hands until the spell does kick in." Pearl brushed her floured hands across her apron, which was already covered in layers of butter, lard, egg, and grease. "There's only one thing left to do."

Florence and Diana exchanged glances, waiting for what was to come next.

"Sabotage."

Chapter Nine

CONVINCING MIA THEY NEEDED to stock up on more coffee beans, Florence excused herself from The Yurt, armed with a small pack of saboteur tools provided by Pearl. She donned her darkest hoodie and snuck out to her car in a needlessly covert way, passing the line of customers that was moving faster now that Diana jumped in to run the cash register, a skill none of the Mackenzie's knew she could do. Stopping first at Windia's Wonderland, Florence skulked inside the empty store which was barely staffed due to the low volume of customers in the morning. Windia tended to be a sleepy town that didn't rush itself in the morning, except when it came to their coffee, that is.

There was no sight of Paulie or the Serendipity blend coffee saleswoman, but much to Florence's relief, the end cap of coffee and espresso beans was still there and well-stocked. Florence shoveled bag after bag of the rich, dark beans into her empty cart, leaving a reasonable amount behind. She looked around the end cap for a business card or some sort of contact information for the manufacturer or saleswoman, but there was only the beans in a simple cellophane bag with the label reading, *There's magic in every bean!*

Next, Florence began her scouting mission to find Samson Richards and his downtown coffee cart. It wouldn't be hard, as downtown Windia consisted of Main Street and a few branching side streets. Every coastal town had a Main Street with local shops for passing tourists, but Florence

always thought that Windia's were extra special. From a patisserie that *almost* rivaled Pearl's baking, to a store of wind chimes constructed solely from treasures of the sea, to a mystical wardrobe boutique that sold flowy skirts and elven crowns; store after store exuded the uniqueness that was her hometown. Main Street also served as the town's unofficial gathering place for Halloween festivities, emergency meetings, and especially Christmas light viewing, which were still lit up in remembrance of the previous day's celebrations.

And there in the middle of it all, in the center of Four Corners Square built to honor the north, south, east, and westerly winds, sat a Sam's 'Spresso coffee cart. A beaming Samson Richards was handing out samples to the gathered crowd, his deep jovial laugh ringing through the quiet morning air. Parking in front of the Mermaid Scales Fitness Center, Florence grabbed her saboteur supplies and snuck towards Four Corners Square. She didn't recognize many faces in the crowd, assuming most of them were tourists or maybe sinister decoys brought in by the Sam's 'Spresso empire.

Florence stooped behind a small potted fir and surveyed Samson Richards through the branches. She pursed her lips together and sighed loudly. He was ridiculously engaging with each customer, chatting and inquiring about their day, asking their opinion on the drink-of-the-day and handing out full stamp cards for a free drink on their next visit. It was like the clouds had parted and the sun was shining down on him, unrealistically dapper-looking for the morning after Christmas in slacks and a red and black checkered flannel shirt, its collar poking out perfectly above the collar of his leather jacket. His shoes looked too expensive and too suede for the gathered puddles across the square and his hair looked tousled but as

though he had planned it that way. Florence leaned closer into the fir, trying to hear his response to a doe-eyed female customer who asked Samson to tell her about himself.

"What are you doing?" a voice loudly whispered.

Florence screamed, turned, and then toppled into the potted fir all in one uncoordinated movement, knocking over the pot with a loud crash and sending sprays of dirt, fir needles, and hidden snails across the ground. Untangling herself from her saboteur bag and rolling unceremoniously off the top of the little fir tree, Florence looked up into the face of Paulie, standing over her with his hands on his hips.

"Really?" Florence snapped. "Did you have to?"

"Well, what *are* you doing?" he repeated.

"None of your business!"

"You're hiding in a tree."

"Why don't you just go back to your dad's store and leave me alone."

"I'm the manager now," Paulie said flatly. "My dad passed away."

Florence sighed and shook her head. "I'm sorry, I didn't know..."

"Which I would have shared with you, but I've had no chance-"

Paulie started to reach out to help Florence up but stopped as a large shadow stretched between them. Florence turned around as a strong hand reached under her arm and pulled her up from the ground, revealing Samson standing right behind her.

"Oh." Florence's face burned, both from embarrassment and anger at Paulie, who stood speechless, tucking his outstretched hand under his arm.

"Morning!" Samson greeted with a grin, looking from Florence to Paulie. He held up a tray of steaming sample cups. "Care to try a Bigfoot Mocha?"

Paulie took a sample without hesitation, trying to mask any kind of reaction as Florence studied his face intensely. He quickly finished the sample in one final gulp and handed back the empty cup.

"It was fine," he admitted, his tone blatantly false.

"Right." Samson nodded, his grin unwavering. He turned to Florence. "And you?"

"Absolutely not," Florence answered, jutting her chin out in the air.

"I've done nothing to tamper these samples, no spit or cyanide, I assure you," Samson insisted, holding one hand up in an oath. "I came right over when I saw you fall out of a miniature tree."

"Still not trying it."

"It's a drink of my own design, not on the usual Sam's 'Spreso menu."

"Speaking of Sam's 'Spreso..." Florence motioned to the coffee cart behind them. "What are you doing here?"

Samson's expression became playfully thoughtful. "Well, after our little tete-a-tete-"

"Your what?" Paulie interjected.

"Never mind," Florence snapped.

"As I was saying, after you threw a cookie in my face, I left on Christmas Eve to go home to Portland for Christmas," Samson explained. "And while I was driving, an idea suddenly struck me."

Florence tried to stop fidgeting.

"If you won't sell and we feel that Windia is perfect for our first coastal shop..." Samson looked back to the crowd behind him. "Then I guess it's time for a little friendly competition."

"There aren't enough residents in Windia or even enough tourists to properly support two coffee shops," Paulie said, his brows furrowed.

"Then I guess we let the customers decide," Samson shot back.

"That's childish."

"That's business."

"There are dozens of other coastal communities out there to pick from. Go there."

"We've done our research and we think Windia fits us best, not that it concerns you."

"I'm a business owner myself in Windia, so it does concern me."

Both men stopped and turned to look at Florence, who was uncharacteristically quiet. Paulie had said exactly what she was thinking. Sometimes Florence thought it truly was magic that The Yurt stayed afloat, making just enough to keep her family provided for and happy. This was nothing that a silly magic spell or bag of tricks or flying pastry was going to solve. This was real life. If another coffee shop detracted even a quarter of The Yurt's business away, Florence didn't know how they would make it. She started to see visuals of her family house dark and empty, The Yurt's front doors boarded up, the path leading down to the ocean overgrown and impassable. Florence shook her head to stop her thoughts from proceeding.

"Are you okay?" Paulie whispered.

"Fine," Florence choked. She reached down to pick up her unused saboteur bag, rapidly blinking back tears. She had to get out of there before she truly lost it.

"Where's your car? I'll walk you there," Paulie offered.

Florence declined as she fumbled with the potted fir, pushing it back upright. She brushed the soil from her clothes and walked away from Four Corners Square, finally allowing her tears to flow freely as she left the two silent men behind.

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Chapter Ten

ON THE SHORT DRIVE back to The Yurt, Florence's tears ranged from fear, fatigue, and hurt to anger, frustration, and determination. Her face was dry though a bit splotchy as she carried several tote bags of Serendipity blend into the coffee shop. Mia and Diana had done great work while she was gone on her saboteur/restocking trip, whittling the line down to a manageable size. Without a word, Florence stacked away the extra bags of beans and pushed up her sleeves, starting on the next customer's order.

Before the clock struck ten, the last of the morning customers were happily on their way out into the world, braced with a hot cup of Serendipity blend. Once the door shut, Mia collapsed down to the ground, her body splayed out across the coffee-splattered floor behind the counter.

"That was insane," she huffed, covering her face with her apron. "I'm too old for this."

"*You're* too old for this?" Pearl asked, emerging from the kitchen. Her white hair was even whiter with a dusting of flour.

"I can't believe I'm saying this, but let's close the shop for the rest of the day," Mia lamented.

"Whether we're too tired or too old or too whatever for all this, we have to keep going," Florence stated loudly. "We need to keep this buzz going, keep those customers coming in." She tried to sound encouraging and authoritative, as though rallying the troops before battle.

Mia looked up from the floor, her face scrunched into a scowl. "We just did a week's, maybe even two weeks, worth of business in a few hours. I love the extra income too, but we'll burn out fast at a pace like that. I can't see it lasting."

"Then we hire more help."

"We can't afford that."

"But you just said-"

"Yes!" Mia exclaimed, standing up stiffly from the ground. "Yes, we made some extra money this morning. And it will go straight to overdue bills. But I can't count on that every morning and frankly, I don't know if I want to!"

"I'll be here to help out!" Florence insisted.

"Until you run off like you always do," Mia muttered.

The Yurt fell silent, completely silent, so that the only sound was the ocean in the distance. Florence felt the tears threatening to return so she avoided Mia's gaze, a woman that was like a big sister to her.

Mia rubbed her face hard, her own eyes tearing. "I'm sorry. I'm so sorry, that was not okay," she whispered.

"Another coffee shop opened downtown, a Sam's 'Spreso cart in Four Corners Square," Florence blurted out.

"What?" Mia's face drained of all color.

"Still want to close the shop for the day?" Florence snapped, regretting the words as soon as she said them.

Mia said nothing, her eyes trailing off to the ocean views beyond the window glass, a view she had looked at and treasured a million times, no matter how tired she was. She turned to Diana, who was crouched down at her mother's feet and listening to the adult's conversation. Taking her hand,

Mia led Diana out the back door to the house, where they would lay down for a cuddle and a nap.

"Well," Pearl sighed as she dusted off her hands. "That went smashingly."

Florence didn't want to meet her grandmother's eyes, feeling more ashamed than when she knocked over and broke Pearl's favorite bottle of perfume, deemed untouchable from the beginning of time. Florence was ashamed because she had hurt Mia - wonderful, hardworking, thoughtful, selfless Mia - and she'd done it out of spite. Mia had been right. Florence does run away. She ran away after her brother and mother died. She ran away after her termination from Sam's 'Spresso. And she ran away this morning from a confrontation with the enemy himself. Florence sat on the ground and cradled her head. She really was the worst.

"Are you done?" Pearl asked. "I think if any more tears are shed today we will rival the Pacific."

"Yes, I think I am done," Florence sniffed. "I'm just going back to Portland."

"So you're admitting defeat before the fight has truly begun, *and* you're doing exactly what Mia, accurately, accused you of?"

Florence blinked up at her grandmother. Pearl had been kinder about the broken perfume bottle.

"Am I doing any good here?" Florence pleaded, waving her hands around the empty coffee shop. "I'm one more mouth to feed, yes, I'm an extra pair of hands and someone to run errands, but that's it. You and Mia know the business, I just make coffee. And sometimes I think that Samson and I feel some sort of...some sort of..."

Florence fell silent as she tried to choose her next word. She almost said *attraction* and it startled her.

Pearl watched her granddaughter's face very, very carefully.

"Competition," Florence finally said. "I think he feels competitive with me and maybe that's caused him to stick around when he might've left Windia all together!"

"Child," Pearl sighed heavily, looking up towards the heavens. "First, get off the floor. Second, roll up your sleeves and help me clean this place up. Busy hands distract busy minds."

Florence had heard that one before. She stood up and brushed off her pants, sticky with syrup.

Pearl's face softened a bit. "Are you doing any good here, you ask? Well, for starters, I don't think I've seen Mia sleep more in the last few days than she has in five years. You found our popular little bean blend. And darling, Mia and I are no better suited for this place than you are. You're a Mackenzie. This is your home. Please, leave it at that. And as for Samson Richards, why shouldn't you have a competition, as you say? You're both good-looking, young, entrepreneurs...take that frustrated energy and make a spark."

"Make a spark," Florence repeated. "You're not talking about arson, are you?"

Pearl laughed. "Sweet Gaia, no! Too messy."

"For the record, there's no spark between me and Samson Richards," Florence lied.

"Of course not, darling," Pearl lied. "Then it should be no problem to whisk him out of town for good. But we need reinforcements. If money talks then money, or lack thereof, will certainly make him walk. Can you call Harper? She'll be a quick study to help at the counter."

"That's a good idea," Florence agreed. It was actually a really good idea and the thought of having her best friend in town was making her feel better already.

"And if anyone will be run out of this town, it's him. Doesn't his coffee cart have wheels on it?" Pearl peeked into the bag of saboteur supplies. "Unless you slashed his tires as I suggested?"

"There wasn't an appropriate moment," Florence explained, chuckling at the fact she was explaining this to her elderly grandmother.

"Hmm," Pearl said, tapping the bag thoughtfully. "Never mind, there's time for that later. Right now, we clean and we strategize."

The front door opened and a customer rushed in with the help of the blustery wind behind them. Another customer immediately followed suit.

"You start, I'll take care of this," Florence said, wiping the last of her tears off her face and squaring her shoulders. She turned and greeted the customer, offering them one of the candy canes sitting in a jar on the counter.

Pearl stopped to watch, just for an extra beat, just to get the feeling from that moment and how it felt very, very right.



That evening, when the shop was closed and the day's work was cleaned up, Florence apologized to Mia over a loaded homemade pizza. And Mia, being Mia, accepted with a nod of acknowledgment and no further comment. They drank wine and put Diana to bed and drank more wine, spinning schemes and conjuring shenanigans that would encourage customers to keep returning to The Yurt. They called Harper while they

were still lucid enough to dial the phone number, and cheered when Harper agreed to come help for a few days and get some ocean air and Pearl's éclairs. The Mackenzie women went to bed late, warm and happy, ready now for the next day and dreaming of the strong coffee they'd need in the morning.

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Chapter Eleven

WITH THE NEXT MORNING falling on a Monday, the Mackenzie women assumed the morning rush would be significantly smaller. They hadn't exactly set a time record for serving customers the day before, so a morning stop for coffee before work might prove difficult. But luckily the people of Windia had anticipated the wait and prepared for it, the way all true coffee lovers do.

Tap. Tap. Tap.

Florence opened one eye. Her throbbing head demanded she immediately close it.

Tap. Tap. Tap. Tap.

Florence opened both eyes, looking over to the digital clock on her nightstand. The neon lights came into focus in the fuzzy darkness, reading 4:54 am. Florence turned over and looked at her bedroom window, where the source of the tapping sound was located. Expecting to find a squirrel or neighborhood cat, Florence whisked back the lighthouse-print curtain and looked straight into Barb's face.

Florence screamed.

"Morning!" Barb called through the window glass, waving emphatically. She breathed into her gloved hands. "A bit chilly out here this morning!"

"It's still night!" Florence blubbered. "What's going on?"

Barb looked around as though she was just realizing it was still dark out. She shrugged cheerily.

"Is everything alright?" Florence asked, looking out the window for an intruder or fire or impending tsunami. She screamed again as she spotted another form in the darkness, leaning against the side of the house. It waved at her.

"Morning!" Mark greeted. "Didn't want to scare you!"

"Thanks," Florence breathed heavily, holding her hand over her racing heart.

"You see, dear," Barb said quite seriously. "It was a bit of a wait yesterday, which was fine, but we thought you might open a bit earlier today?" She peered at Florence with a doe-eyed expression. "We really need our coffee."

Florence looked over at her clock, which now read 5:01 am. The Yurt usually opened at 7:00 am, which had never been a problem before, as the other businesses in Windia open at 8:00 am and the residents have no commute. Florence could count her hours of sleep on one hand, but she also knew she could make Barb and Mark's favorite drink quickly and maybe catch another hour of sleep before opening.

"Sure," she said finally. "I'll let you both in, hold on."

"Oh!" Barb waved for Florence's attention before she left. "There are a few other people here, too."

"Really?" Florence stretched her neck around but couldn't see anyone else in the dark except for Mark.

"They're all out front," Barb explained. "You'll see!" Then she and Mark disappeared around the side of the house.

A small pit suddenly formed in Florence's stomach as she stumbled through the darkness and down the hall. She pulled on the rope to lower the stairs to the attic and scrambled up, dashing over to the little window that

provided a view of the front steps of The Yurt. The pit in Florence's stomach expanded into a full chasm as she spotted a crowd of 60-70 people gathered around the entrance, some wrapped together in blankets, others bundled in warm layers, their faces illuminated by their cell phones. And on the twilight beach, one group was setting up a campfire, complete with folding chairs.

"Wake up!" Florence shouted, stumbling across rolls of Christmas wrapping paper and stubbing her toe on her mother's sewing machine. She made her way back to the attic stairs and tumbled down, taking two steps at a time before reaching the floor.

"Wake up! Wake up!" Florence shouted again, banging door to door until the other Mackenzie women appeared bleary-eyed in the hallway.

"Where's the fire?" Mia ran in circles through the hallway, fire extinguisher in hand.

"No, no, put that down," Florence commanded. She pointed towards The Yurt. "They're here."

"Who?" Pearl asked, raising her fists as though ready to join the fight. She turned back to her room. "I'll get my staff."

"No! No!" Florence exclaimed, pulling at her disheveled hair which now had a layer of dust and cobwebs throughout it. "The customers! There's a whole lot of them out there and it's barely 5:00 am!"

Pearl and Mia blinked as Diana appeared in the doorway.

"I'll preheat the oven," she said dryly, tying her robe as she passed her aunt.

Florence stomped her foot, which was a poor choice as it was the foot she'd stubbed on the sewing machine. "C'mon, what did we say last night?"

All the plans we had? And, yes, there was a lot of wine, but we owe it to our customers to get out there and get them their coffee!"

"I just wish last night hadn't ended two hours ago," Mia muttered, reaching into her room to grab a hoodie. She was already wearing yoga pants and paired with the hoodie, she looked like many Pacific Northwest girls. Mia tightened her messy top knot as though preparing for battle. She walked past Florence and then stopped, looking back.

"Good pep talk, kid," she smirked.

Florence smiled and turned to her grandmother, who had already disappeared into her bedroom. In a blink, she was back, fully clothed with an elven crown adorned in her braided hair. Her makeup was impeccable too with tones of plum and shimmery pink. Had Pearl gone to sleep like that? Florence rubbed her head. She couldn't remember.

Pearl adjusted her crown. "Regality makes me feel invincible," she explained. She snapped her fingers in Florence's face, causing her to blink. "Well, let's get going!"

"Just let me get dressed-" Florence stopped talking as she looked down, expecting to see pajamas but found she was wearing a long skirt and fitted T-shirt. "What..." she whispered, sticking out her feet. She was even wearing sneakers.

"Just go with it!" Pearl called over her shoulder.



The Mackenzie women fell into their respective roles as though 100 customers gathered at their door at 5:00 am was a perfectly normal occurrence. Pearl stayed strictly in the kitchen, popping out one warm tray

of breakfast goodies after another with astonishing speed, delivered by Diana to the window box for purchase. Florence greeted customers and took orders, jumping in to finish drinks that Mia had started at the coffee bar. This cycle went on and on, round and round, customer to customer until only the last few couples remained in The Yurt, the campfire outside extinguished, and the first signs of dawn illuminating the flat white sky.

"Since when have Teresa and Jonathan been together?" Florence whispered to Mia. They both pointedly looked over their shoulder from where they had been wiping up the bar. Mia squinted her eyes at the couple canoodling at the corner table, hands wrapped together, faces leaning together in a long, passionate kiss.

"Oh my." Mia looked away quickly. "That's a bit much."

"That looks like love," Florence whispered, still watching.

"Stop!" Mia chided. "And I had no idea they were together. I just saw her last week at book club and she didn't mention anything."

"Hmm," Florence murmured as she took a long drink of her iced Americano. "By the way, we did great."

"We did really great," Mia agreed, a bright smile spreading across her face. She looked out the window at the parting clouds. "I'm starting to feel like we can really do this."

"Harper should be here by this afternoon, then we can really rock 'n' roll." Florence looked up as another group of customers came in who glanced startingly at Teresa and Jonathan's kissing session as they passed by. "If we can keep up this traffic all day, then Samson Richards doesn't stand a chance."

"Well, we always get a late afternoon pick-me-up crowd, but coffee in the evening?" Mia shook her head. "Not in this sleepy town."

"I may have a few ideas," Florence said slyly before turning to the next customer and greeting, "What can I get you?"

"Actually, I'm here to help you," the woman replied, opening her messenger bag and pulling out a leather notebook. "I'm a reporter for the Windia Bee newspaper. Pearl asked me to come by."

"Oh, did she?" Mia propped her hands on her hips, looking over as Pearl appeared in the kitchen doorway.

"Yes, I did." Pearl wiped her hands together, sending clouds of flour into the air. "And I've already informed her of the dastardly villain desecrating Four Corners Square."

The reporter seemed to be fighting back a smile. "Yes," she said slowly. "We did have an interesting conversation last night."

Florence's face reddened as she recalled Pearl making a phone call around the same time she was calling Harper. They had consumed way too much wine at that point to be calling anyone but close friends and family.

"Of course, I'm doing my own research into Samson Richards, this 'dastardly villain,' as you call him."

Now it was the reporter's face that turned a slight shade of red. She brushed her blond hair out of her face and back into place. Florence noticed the color of her red lipstick. That was not the color of lipstick to wear to an interview with three sleep-deprived women at a coffee shop. Florence assumed word had spread to the Windia's Single Club about Samson's undeniable good looks and the reporter was dressed to impress for her "research."

Mia must have noticed the reporter's reaction as well, stepping up to the counter. "Can I start you one of our specialty drinks? On the house."

"Oh!" the reporter exclaimed, eyes brightening. "Absolutely!" She flipped a few pages of her notebook. "And while she's working on that, fill me in on all the upcoming events you have planned." She paused with her pen hanging mid-air.

"Events?" Florence queried with too many blinks.

The reporter looked from Pearl to Florence. Her eyebrows furrowed. "Yes, Pearl said you have a whole string of events planned to finish out the year and run Samson Richards out of town."

"Oh, did she?" Florence didn't turn to Pearl but she could feel that it was her grandmother's face burning red now. "Right. Well, we weren't quite ready to talk about them yet. Still ironing out the details, you know?"

The reporter clicked her pen and frowned. "Well, that's disappointing."

"But!" Mia exclaimed, handing forward a steaming Christmas Cookie Latte. "We would be happy to give you the details first."

The reporter clicked her pen again. "Great!"

Mia turned to Florence, her eyes very wide. "Go ahead, Florence."

Florence's face was a blank smile as her mind replayed both the reasonable and the completely illogical ideas the Mackenzie women had conjured up the night before.

"A bake sale," Florence blurted out, grandly gesturing over to Pearl. "Featuring treats from Pearl herself."

"Bake sale?" The reporter's nose wrinkled.

"And," Florence continued, holding up her finger. "We're going to challenge Sam's 'Spresso to an "espresso off" race."

"Ooh! That sounds intriguing. What happens if you win?"

"Well, the loser has to jump in the ocean - naked."

"What!"

"And then there's the Decaf Delight evening event...for lovers."

"Amazing! What else?"

"Our usual New Year's Eve bash - bigger and better, of course."

"Is there a theme?"

"Magic at midnight."

"Wow!" The reporter lowered her notebook and shook her head. "Incredible! Good for you ladies, I can't wait." She raised her Christmas Cookie Latte. "And I can't wait to get Samson's reaction to this!"

With a swish, the reporter dashed out of The Yurt, pausing for a startled beat at Teresa and Jonathan's heated exchange. Florence watched her leave with a frozen smile plastered across her face, afraid to turn to Mia, whose gaze was burning a hole in her jaw.

"Oh, enough!" Pearl shouted, brushing past Florence to break up Teresa and Jonathan, shooing them outside. "Out! Good Gaia, come up for air!"

After Teresa and Jonathan stumbled, dazed, outside, Pearl turned back to her granddaughter, arms crossed.

"Florence Siobhan Mackenzie," Pearl roared. "What have you done?"

Florence felt herself shrink at the proclamation of her full name, half expecting her grandmother to levitate and burst into flames.

"I...I..." Florence stammered. "You put me in this position! You made me talk to the reporter!"

"Yes! Because you're hip and young and your brain works faster than mine!" Pearl exclaimed, pulling at her hair for emphasis.

Florence carefully looked out the corner of her eye at Mia, who was terrifyingly quiet, her gaze now shifted to the countertop.

"Magic at midnight," Mia repeated. She shook her head and looked at Florence. "I love it."

Florence breathed again. "You do?"

Pearl gaped. "Really?"

"Let's do it," Mia said, sounding as though she surprised herself. "All of it. Let's do it!"

"Yeah," Florence nodded, excitement rising in her stomach. "Yeah, let's do it!" She turned to her grandmother, smiling. "Will you take up arms and fight?"

Pearl looked from Florence to Mia and muttered something under her breath. She brushed back her flyaway hair. "Diana!" she hollered. "I need the backup flour from the basement!" She walked up to Florence and Mia and kissed their cheeks. "I guess we're having a bake sale tomorrow."

The front door opened and Harper entered, carrying a large coffee tumbler in one hand and dragging a rolling suitcase with the other. She stopped, surprised at all three Mackenzie women staring at her.

"Am I late?" she asked.

"Poor dear," Pearl whispered, patting Florence on the shoulder. "She has no idea what she's gotten herself into."

Chapter Twelve

Bake Sale at The Yurt!

Today only - sunrise to sunset!

Featuring Pearl's baked treats!

All proceeds go to the organization:

"Keep The Yurt, Ditch The Jerk"

FLORENCE SMOOTHED THE FLYER and added an extra piece of tape to its location on Dave's Donuts window front. She waved at Dave inside the dimly lit donut shop, who greeted her back with a thumbs up. He was possibly the only other person who had a reason to be up at that early morning hour. Other than Harper, who was out helping Florence hang flyers. And the Mackenzie girls, who were back at The Yurt, setting up the bake sale and serving the long line of early morning customers. No wonder Windia was a sleepy town, everyone got up too early.

"Is 'Keep The Yurt, Ditch The Jerk' an actual organization?" Harper asked, her eyes scanning the flyer. "Also, you spelled *spanakopita* wrong." Her voice was muffled from the heavy gray scarf wrapped around her face. She was used to the Oregon chill in the winter, but not the Oregon *coast* chill in the winter, delivering dampness that threatens to immobilize a person's joints if they don't keep moving.

"I declared it an actual organization as of yesterday," Florence replied, moving on to the next window front. "And I'm a barista, not a linguist."

Harper sighed. "That's not right, either."

A loud pickup truck with a weathered canopy drove up and parked several feet away from them, drowning out any further conversation. A man jumped out of the running vehicle and opened the back canopy, pulling out a thick stack of newspapers that he deposited into the newspaper vending machine. After locking up the machine and glancing at the two women watching him, he tipped his hat and drove down to the next vending machine.

"The article," Florence and Harper said at the same time, running up to the vending machine. Florence tried to open the door and noticed the price of 75 cents per paper.

"Do you have change?" Florence asked, rummaging through her tote bag full of flyers, keys, and her cell phone.

Harper shrugged. "I don't live here."

"We don't have a special currency here, Harper!" Florence barked.

"And I don't carry change, Florence, unless I know I'm going to feed a parking meter!" Harper barked back, throwing her hands in the air. "Who prints papers anymore, anyway? Everything's online!"

"I don't know!" Florence gave one more futile tug on the newspaper vending machine.

Both girls twirled and jumped at the sound of change loudly rattling in the quiet Windia morning air. Samson Richards stood behind them, a sly smirk on his face, hands in his pockets.

He looked from Florence to Harper. "Good morning."

"Hey," Harper replied quickly, looking Samson up and down uncouthly. "How's it going?"

"Just stopping by for my morning paper before I start the day," he crooned, pulling three quarters out of his pocket. He looked Florence in the eye as he dropped each quarter in one by one, listening to every coin travel noisily down the chamber. Florence glared at him.

"Nice." Harper smoothed her hair. "We had the same thought, but we both forgot our change." She batted her eyes in follow-up.

"Oh?" Samson feigned concern as he opened the vending machine door and took a copy of the paper. "Can I help?"

"Sure!" Harper squeaked.

"No," Florence interjected. "We're fine."

Harper gave Florence a puzzled yet exasperated look but said nothing.

"And our customers aren't waiting for us to go pick up a paper, they're being served back at The Yurt," Florence continued. "Bad practice to leave your customers waiting, don't you think?"

"Oh, I completely agree," Samson said, shaking out the fold in the paper. "That's why I hired another employee to help me at the cart, he's been there since 4:30 this morning."

Florence gritted her teeth so hard she heard them creak.

"*Yurt faced with worthy competition*," Samson read aloud the title of the front-page story. "This should be an interesting read. Wasn't that reporter just lovely?"

"You're Samson Richards?" Harper asked darkly.

"The very one," Samson replied, reaching out to shake Harper's limp hand. "And you are?"

"No."

Samson turned back to Florence. "Friend of yours?"

"We're done, let's go," Florence grumbled to Harper, adjusting her tote bag. She scoffed as Samson reached into her bag and pulled out a flyer.

"A bake sale!" Samson announced. "Keep The Yurt, Ditch The Jerk...very catchy. Maybe I'll stop by to pick up some treats for the cart." He nodded as he walked away. "Don't keep those customers waiting!"

Florence watched Samson walk away and let out a long, trembling sigh. Harper wrapped her arm around her friend's shoulders and gave it a squeeze.

She stifled a laugh. "You didn't tell me he was hot."



The morning sunlight stretched completely across the gold and gray sand by the time Florence and Harper finished hanging the remaining flyers. The morning coffee crowd was mostly gone when they arrived back at The Yurt, a handful of customers lingering on the beach as they waited for the bake sale to officially begin.

"Did you read the article?" Mia asked as Florence joined her behind the counter.

"No, I didn't have any change to buy the paper," Florence grumbled, hanging her empty tote bag up next to the aprons.

"A customer brought one to me," Mia shrugged, pointing to the newspaper sitting on the counter, which Harper promptly grabbed.

Florence sighed, "And?"

"And," Pearl piped in, emerging from the kitchen with a tower of trays covered with tasty treats. "He's got a few things to say about you." Pearl

handed the trays to Florence and turned back to the kitchen for more.

Florence struggled with the weight of the trays and wondered how her grandmother had not. "Like what?"

"'Florence Mackenzie is a disgruntled former employee of Sam's 'Spreso,' says Samson Richards," Harper read aloud, the open newspaper propped in front of her face. "While we cannot disclose the reason for her termination, I will say her involvement at The Yurt makes me concerned about the quality of drinks served at that establishment."

Florence took a huge gulp of air to stop herself from dropping the armful of trays.

"Richards says the Mackenzie's have long enjoyed a monopoly on the caffeine needs of Windia," Harper continued. "And believes healthy competition encourages everyone to do their best. 'I gladly accept Florence Mackenzie's challenges,' says Richards. 'And I look forward to politely and gentlemanly showing her how a successful business owner behaves.'"

"Basically he's saying he's going to kick your butt," Diana chimed in, walking past her aunt with an armful of freshly-baked focaccia bread.

"I...I..." Florence stammered, breathless as the anger rose in her throat and threatened to explode.

"Don't drop the lemon tarts," Pearl said, leading her granddaughter towards the door. "No man is worth that."

Florence didn't have time to focus any more energy on her hatred of Samson Richards as the Keep The Yurt, Ditch The Jerk bake sale had officially begun. Using the pop-up canopies the Mackenzie's setup for their summertime indie book sale event, the front entrance was populated with table after table of Pearl's best and most-requested baked goods for sale.

With many customers still gathered and waiting for a morning treat to go along with their coffee, Pearl's delicacies began to sell like hotcakes. Danishes, bagels, scones, and donuts went first, followed by fruit tarts, fresh bread for sandwiches, and another round of iced coffees for the lunch crowd. The rain and wind held off, unexpected and uncommon for a late December day on the Oregon coast. By the time the 3:00 sun appeared on the edges of the distant horizon, the bake sale was down to a half dozen cakes, some crumbled biscotti's, and a few sad-looking cheese Danishes with the frosting smeared off.

Samson Richards had not shown up yet, which irked Florence more than anything because she just wanted his appearance over with. The cool, late afternoon wind was picking up now, fluttering the edges of the canopies like a warning signal of what was to come.

Mia looked at the remaining cakes on the table. "Well, I guess we can each have a cake for dinner," she said as she finished counting up the cash earned for the day. "Pearl, you outdid yourself, as I knew you would."

Pearl bowed. "Thank you. But let's wait a few more minutes." She looked over at the sea. "I think the storm will hold off."

"Ooh!" Diana jeered. "Look whose coming! Watch out, Auntie!"

Samson Richards appeared on the beach, his form starting as an indistinguishable speck in the distance, sharpening into a clear figure as he approached the bake sale. His hair was disheveled from the wind and his face bright pink from the exertion of walking through the sand. Florence watched, unblinking, as he brushed the sand off his pants and walked to the table. She swallowed hard.

"Hello, Mr. Darcy," Harper whispered in Florence's ear.

"Stop!" Florence hissed, brushing her snickering friend away.

Samson Richards raised up his hands, one of which held his wallet. "I come in peace," he announced with a grin. "Please do not launch any baked items at me, I am here to make a purchase."

"We're closed," Florence sniffed.

"We're open," Pearl corrected. "What'll you have?"

Samson scanned the limited items left on the table. He shrugged and opened his wallet. "I'll just take it all." He handed over a credit card. "You take card, I'm assuming?"

"Yes, sir," Diana answered, taking his card with a big smile.

"You don't have to call him *sir*, Diana," Florence interjected.

"That's right," Samson agreed gravely. "You can call me Sam."

"That's not-"

"So let's see," Samson interrupted Florence, pointing from cake to cake to unfrosted Danish. "Looks like I owe you 70ish dollars, so let's round it up to a neat hundred."

"Great!" Diana grinned, swiping his credit card.

"Hold on," Florence interrupted. "Those prices are for Windia residents only."

Harper stifled a laugh and Mia covered her eyes with her hands. Pearl watched the interaction and shook her head.

"Excuse me?" Samson's voice had a twinge of annoyance to it.

Florence picked up on the twinge, smiling in response. "Yes, these prices are for loyal residents of Windia, not big business that's trying to run us into the ground."

"I'm literally here giving you money," Samson said flatly. "How is that running you into the ground?"

"I think..." Florence ignored him, tapping her chin. "400 dollars should do it. With an extra 100 for the slander in today's newspaper."

Mia gasped, "Florence!"

Florence and Samson locked eyes for a long time, longer than was necessary. Finally, Diana cleared her throat.

"So...how much?" she asked, looking between the two.

Samson stared at Florence a beat longer before muttering, "500."

Florence clapped in success and helped Pearl load up the cakes and other remaining goods into a box, which she pushed in Samson's direction.

Samson grabbed the box, startled by the weight of it. He grunted as he lifted it off the table. "And as I learned from the Windia Bee reporter, I have been challenged to an 'espresso off,' is that right?"

Florence nodded. "Are you backing out?"

"Oh, absolutely not," Samson huffed, readjusting his grip on the box. "Your place or mine?"

"Your choice, it's the least I can do, considering I'm going to humiliate you in front of everyone."

"My place," Samson said quickly. "After the morning rush. And bring your A-game."

"Oh, I'll bring my C-game!" Florence promised, puffing out her chest.

Samson nodded, confused, then turned and waddled back down the beach, stopping occasionally to reposition the box of cakes in his arms.

"C-game?" Harper asked.

"C-game," Florence repeated. "C for coffee."

"That doesn't work," Harper whispered.

"I told you I'm not a linguist!" Florence sighed.

Harper shook her head. "Never mind. But can we talk about how you just got that man to give you 500 dollars for a few cakes?"

"What do you mean?" Florence asked.

"I mean, what's his motivation to do that?"

Florence paused. "To make himself look good, I guess."

"I guess." Harper twisted her lips and started tearing down the last pop-up canopy, saying nothing more.

Florence joined her, untying the other end of the pop-up canopy. She had to admit she felt a bit unsavory about her behavior; but this was Samson Richards, her family's competition. It didn't matter that no one was looking, he bought those cakes for his own benefit. She shielded her eyes as she watched Samson's figure completely disappear into the sunset. Didn't he?

Chapter Thirteen

"WELCOME TO THE FIRST Annual Windia Espresso Off!"

A red-faced man in a heavy wool sweater stood atop the stage erected in the center of Four Corners Square. As expected for a winter's day on the Oregon coast, the wind was blowing so hard that the rain practically fell sideways, smacking any pedestrians directly in the face. The man raised his hand and wiped the rain off his face, repositioning the knit cap on his head that was looking more and more soaked with each passing minute.

"I, Windia Mayor Jimmy Lincoln, will be serving as officiate for the main event, and I assure you I will be a fair and impartial judge. Even though there was that one time Pearl and..." Mayor Lincoln's voice trailed off and the rest of his statement disappeared into the wind. He looked across the scattered crowd and caught Pearl's piercing gaze, causing him to immediately back up and wipe his face again.

"Bear with us a few moments," Mayor Lincoln shouted into the wind. He stepped back as two public works employees scrambled to set up a canopy over the stage. "Water and electricity don't mix!" Mayor Lincoln chuckled loudly.

"Are you going to die?" Diana asked, turning around to look at her aunt. She, the older Mackenzie women, and Harper were gathered tightly together beneath an overhang on the edges of Four Corners Square.

Florence's teeth were chattering and she convinced herself it was from the cold. "No, of course not. They'll make the stage nice and safe."

"I mean, when you have to jump in the ocean," Diana clarified.

"Diana!" Mia chided. "Aunt Florence is not going to lose." She paused and looked over at her sister-in-law. "But I did bring a change of clothes, just in case."

"Now, now," Pearl jumped in. "We have the tempests on our side. The sister winds blow from the west, she will aid your intuition."

"You can still forfeit," Harper suggested. She poked her head out and blinked into the rain. "Just say these are unsafe conditions and you could sue the city or something."

"I'm not going to lose, I'm not going to drown, I'm not going to get electrocuted, and I'm not going to quit," Florence ranted, flapping her arms up and down for both warmth and dramatic effect. "I am, however, going to kick that little rich boy's-" Florence stopped and looked down at Diana, adding, "Buttocks."

"That's the spirit!" Pearl cheered. "But in case you do end up in the water, remember - don't fight the riptides. Just let it carry you down the coast and I'll pick you up where it lets you off."

Florence sighed and closed her eyes.

"In all seriousness, could you even go down there?" Mia asked, her eyes softening as she looked in the direction of the roaring sea.

Pearl, Diana, Mia, and Harper fell silent as they watched Florence's face. Florence tried, but she couldn't hide the welling emotions that threatened to boil over at the thought of going down to the beach. To the water's edge where she had played and dreamed and cried countless times over the span

of her life. But she hadn't been down to the beach in four years and she was not prepared to go back.

"Will the challengers join me up on the stage, please?" Mayor Lincoln shouted. The canopy was now standing precariously, flapping furiously against the westerly wind gusts. Two long, folding tables had been placed beneath the canopy, each topped with a shiny espresso machine, a bucket of ice, bottles of syrup, stacks of cups, and other barista tools nearby.

Florence ran through the rain and puddles to climb up the stairs to the stage, taking her place at the first espresso station. Moments later, the door to the Sam's 'Spresso cart popped open and Samson emerged, dressed in jeans and a bright orange Sam's 'Spresso sweatshirt. He waved to the gathered crowd and shook Mayor Lincoln's hand as he stepped on stage. Samson whispered in the mayor's ear, who nodded in response.

"Ladies and gentleman of Windia!" Samson shouted to the beleaguered crowd standing in the pouring rain. He walked to the front of the stage. "My name is Samson Richards and I am here to represent Sam's 'Spresso in this competition! It has been my pleasure to serve and meet many of you over the last few days, and I look forward to continuing to serve you in the future! Thank you!"

The crowd responded with a hesitant clap, except for Diana, who booed loudly until Mia stopped her. Samson waved and stepped back, pausing for a moment as the Windia Bee reporter aggressively pushed to the front of the crowd to take a photo, waving back at Samson.

A long moment of silence followed.

"And you?" Mayor Lincoln whispered to Florence. "Why don't you introduce yourself?"

Florence blinked at the crowd, an unrecognizable mix of hooded figures getting drenched in the rain. "I'm Florence Mackenzie," she announced with a wave. "You know, from The Yurt."

The Mackenzie women responded with applause and by shouting, "Go Florence!"

"Well, let's get started!" Mayor Lincoln jumped in loudly. "The competitors will have 30 minutes to make as many drinks as possible! Only one drink per customer, please! And I'd like to thank the patron of our event, who has graciously donated the espresso beans for today's competition! Ma'am? Ma'am, where are you?"

Mayor Lincoln squinted into the crowd, finally pointing out a small figure on the outer edges of the gathering. Florence followed Mayor Lincoln's eye line and spotted the Serendipity blend saleswoman, who nodded in reply. With the prospect of free morning coffees, the crowd clapped again.

"The moment of truth is finally here!" Mayor Lincoln bellowed. "Who will be crowned the fastest barista in the west? Who will humble themselves with a naked dip in the Pacific? We'll find out today! Starting now!"

Before Florence could blink, a loud foghorn blasted and her first customer was at her table, a young man in a nice, although soaked, coat. He ordered a Sam's 'Spresso specialty drink and from his occasional sly glances over to Samson, Florence could only assume he was sent to confuse her.

"No problem!" Florence said loudly with a forced smile. "I know that drink like the back of my hand."

Samson glanced at her with a frown as he watched and scooped ice from his espresso station.

One by one the drenched customers finally got their coffees, and while most of them left to finish their day, a few remained in the square to see the outcome of the competition. Mayor Lincoln silently ticked off each time a drink was served, dramatically pacing and tapping his chin with his pen. The Windia Bee reporter obnoxiously snapped pictures, increasing in rapidity once Samson stripped off his sweatshirt and revealed a sweat-soaked T-shirt underneath. Florence had long since lost track of how many drinks she had prepared but seeing Samson's flustered state encouraged her that she was on her way to the win.

"Time!" Mayor Lincoln shouted, waving a racing flag in the air.

The remaining crowd members clapped and cheered, gathering in front of the stage. Florence sat down on the edge of the stage, wiping the sweat off her face with the sleeves of her shirt. She was splattered in caramel and whipped cream and would undoubtedly reek of old milk very quickly. She took a shaky breath in and out, looking over her shoulder at the beach. The nerves were settling in now. She had not thought this out when she threw down the challenge.

"I have been keeping careful track throughout the competition, which remained neck and neck from the start," Mayor Lincoln announced. He motioned for Florence and Samson to join him by his side. "And the winner of the First Annual Windia Espresso Off is..."

Florence closed her eyes and felt her stomach drop. The crowd held its breath and leaned forward. The Windia Bee reporter held her camera at the ready.

"Samson Richards!"

"Yes!" Samson cheered, raising his fist in the air triumphantly. He posed for the reporter, offering a handshake to Florence, who took his hand

limply.

"Good race," Samson said. "I'll be honest, I struggled to keep up. Maybe my dad made a mistake when he fired you."

"Thanks," Florence mumbled blankly. She could barely hear what Samson was saying over the loud beating of her racing heart. She began to contemplate how quickly she could run to her car and drive away from Windia forever, but that fantasy was interrupted by Mayor Lincoln's bellowing voice again.

"We will now cross Main Street and descend down to the beach where, um..." Mayor Lincoln faltered, then turned to Florence and whispered, "Do you still want to do this?"

"Of course she wants to do it!" Samson interjected. "I won fair and square and those were the terms of the challenge."

"Yes, but, if the lady..." Mayor Lincoln frowned.

"He's right," Florence blurted out. She pulled off her hoodie and threw it to the ground, rousing a gasp from the crowd and a picture snap from the reporter. "Let's go."

Florence descended from the platform and crossed Main Street with her head held high, the multitudes following silently along as though she were being led to the guillotine. Adrenaline got her across the street and the dozens of eyes behind her compelled Florence to the edge of the sand. But once the crashing waves came into sight, Florence felt her knees buckle and her heart pick up speed, warning her to run, run fast away from the memories and moments that would be waiting for her there. She stopped, taking deep breaths to control the trembling that started in her hands and threatened to spread to the rest of her body. Whispers and murmurs began to ripple through the crowd of onlookers, who parted so the other Mackenzie

women and Harper could reach the front. Mia wrapped her arms around Diana, who was beginning to look teary-eyed at her aunt's distress. Pearl wrung her hands, for once not sure what to do.

Samson turned and looked around at the forlorn crowd, who all seemed to understand what Florence's hesitation was about. He leaned over to Mayor Lincoln.

"What's the holdup?" he asked.

Mayor Lincoln grimaced and removed his hat, shaking his head slowly.

Samson waited for a few more beats, cleared his throat loudly, and peered over at Florence, who was standing still as a statue, other than the rapid rising and falling of her chest. Looking behind him, Samson spotted the elder Mackenzie and sidled up beside her.

"So," Samson began with the most charming smile he could muster. "She can't swim?"

Pearl looked at him sharply. "Sweet Jupiter, no. She was the captain of her swimming team."

Samson looked from Pearl to Florence and back to Pearl again. "Afraid of little nudity?" he chuckled.

This time Pearl rolled her eyes. "You've obviously heard nothing about Mackenzie women."

"Oh." Samson blinked quickly. "Then what?" He motioned to Florence's frozen body.

Pearl's face fell. "My daughter...Florence's mother...had a heart attack down on the beach several years ago," she explained, her voice strained. "And it was Florence who found her." She paused in a visible effort to collect herself. "And she's never been back to the beach since."

"That's terrible," Samson whispered, shaking his head. "Then why make this stupid challenge?"

"I don't know," Pearl snapped, eyes blazing. "I'm sure she thought she could beat the likes of *you*."

"The likes of me?" Samson snapped back. "It has been 'the likes of me' that has been more than patient, even generous, with your family. This is business, nothing more."

"You're right," Pearl said matter-of-factly, her gaze cold like steel. "There is nothing more for us than our business."

A hush washed over the crowd as Florence finally made some sort of movement. She crouched down to remove her socks and shoes. As she reached to pull off her tank top, Florence stopped and turned back at the sound of Diana's loud sniffing. She looked from Mia, to Harper, to Pearl, and then to Samson. But she didn't seem surprised to see him standing there by her grandmother. Her eyes lingered on his face and Samson felt his stomach drop. She looked sad. Terribly, miserably sad.

"Oh, for God's sake," Samson grumbled, yanking off his T-shirt, which caused the crowd to collectively gasp. The Windia Bee reporter jumped in front of Samson and snapped pictures furiously.

Florence's mouth fell open as Samson sprinted past her, stripping off his clothes as he shouted incoherently into the wind, barreling towards the sea. He was completely naked by the time he reached the freezing water, diving headfirst into a wave with a high-pitched shriek.

The crowd erupted with applause and cheers, even from the Mackenzie women who shouted more out of relief than joy. Florence watched with her hand over her gaping mouth, breaking out into tearful laughter as Samson's head bobbed above the water, only to overtaken by another crashing wave.

He continued to swim in the biting water, showing off an impressive broad stroke and floating on his back, causing another flurry of photos from the Windia Bee reporter.

"Well, I'd say that settles it!" Mayor Lincoln announced jovially, handing Florence back her socks and shoes. "Let's move along folks, give the man of a bit of privacy before he freezes to death."

Within minutes, the street had all but cleared out, even the Windia Bee reporter left, cursing her dead camera battery. Mia took a much-relieved Diana back to the car while Pearl went down the street to Beth's Mercantile for more chamomile tea. Harper walked up to Florence, carrying a large beach towel and Florence's hoodie that had been discarded in Four Corners Square. Florence was still watching Samson in the water but took the hoodie, although she was already soaked from the drizzling rain.

"Why did he do that?" Florence asked her friend quietly.

"To make himself look good, I guess," Harper answered, a sly smile on her lips.

"I guess," Florence sighed, smiling weakly as she bumped shoulders with Harper.

Harper tucked her arm into Florence's arm to lead her back towards the car.

"Wait." Florence stopped and took the beach towel from Harper, setting it atop a nearby bench on the sand's edge. She took one last look at Samson, who was still fighting to swim in the Pacific Ocean and walked back with Harper towards Mia's waiting car.

Chapter Fourteen

THAT EVENING WAS FILLED with comfy clothes, movies playing in the background, couches covered with blankets, and enough Chinese food to feed half the town of Windia. No customers came to The Yurt even though it was technically still open for business; that's how it was in Windia, somehow everyone knew when to give a family their space while still being there for them, all along. The Mackenzie women worked hard but they also knew when it was time to recharge, and after the Espresso Off, they were at their critical point. There was still the Decaf Delight and New Year's Eve bash ahead of them, and massive amounts of Chinese food coupled with classic romantic comedies seemed the only way to prepare for the long days ahead.

Even though they all went to bed early, Harper and the other Mackenzie women let Florence sleep in the longest, and it was halfway through the morning rush when she finally woke up. It hadn't been the rain or the 30-minute chaotic coffee competition or even losing that drained Florence. It had been the prospect of stepping foot on that beach again, a place that haunted her nightmares but also where she longed to return to. Sometimes she wondered if she just put on her big girl pants and stomped down to the sand this would all be over. Maybe she'd realize it had all been for nothing and her fears of reliving those feelings had been unfounded.

But her mother had been special, and to have died alone with the ocean waves threatening to take her away, it all seemed so wrong. Her mother

should have lit up the sky after she passed, but instead, her body was discarded like driftwood on the sand.



"Good morning," Mia greeted from behind the counter, her hands moving from drink to drink effortlessly. It was towards the end of the morning rush, and Diana and Harper were wiping down empty tables while Pearl started on the kitchen dishes.

Florence nodded to Mia and took the orders from the remaining customers in line, who all seemed to have an extra touch of patience with fragile Florence. Chitchat topics remained on the weather and plans for the upcoming Decaf Delight evening event for lovers. And there seemed to be a lot of lovers these days, Florence noted, as almost every customer approached the counter with a partner at their side. She chalked it up to the holidays and the general magic of that season, but at this rate, there would no longer be a need for a Windia Single's Club.

Once the last customer had left and was on their way to continue their day, the women gathered around the counter and ate a late breakfast/early lunch of leftover Chinese food. They discussed the plans for the evening but did not talk about the day before, although it hung in the air between them like a fog.

Mia reached beneath the counter and pulled out two large shopping bags filled with decorations. "I asked Barb to pick up some party supplies at Destiny's," she explained, referencing Destiny's Delightful Thrifts located in a converted barn store on the edge of Windia. It was operated by a high

school friend of Mia's, who was actually named Sarah, who claimed she was led by destiny to find the most obscure treasures in a 50-mile radius.

"In other words, who knows what we'll find in there," Florence said with a smile, feeling more like herself after a heavy helping of Kung Pao chicken and a large caramel macchiato.

Harper had already started digging through the bags, her eyes alight. "Oh yes," she said. "I can make this work."

"Great," Mia said, turning to Diana, who was on her fifth fortune cookie. "Sweetie, you'll help-"

"I know," she interrupted, her mouth full of cookie. "I'll help in the kitchen."

"You're becoming a proper kitchen witch," Pearl beamed. She motioned to Florence and muttered loudly, "You have more of a touch for it than this one."

Florence shrugged. "And you're also more patient with this one here," she retorted, winking at Diana. She turned to Mia. "Let me guess, I'm on errand duty?"

Mia nodded. "We need lots of decaf." Mia's nose crinkled a bit at the word *decaf*.

Florence reached for her bag and hoodie, which was stuffed below the counter. The door opened and four customers entered The Yurt, shaking the rain off their coats. Mia and Harper took their places at the counter while Pearl and Diana carried the empty Chinese food cartons back to the kitchen.

"And we're running low on Serendipity blend," Mia added as Florence turned to leave. "Pick up whatever you can fit in the cart."

It was heavily storming as Florence drove to Windia's Wonderland, rain falling sideways across her windshield as the wipers struggled to keep up.

Anywhere else this weather may have threatened an upcoming event, but not in Windia, where this type of weather literally came with the territory. Florence's hoodie was soaked through by the time she wrangled a shopping cart from the parking lot, as she began to realize why she was always suggested for errand duty. Once inside, Florence draped her hoodie over the shopping cart to dry out in the welcoming warmth of Windia's Wonderland.

Spotting Paulie at one of the registers, Florence lowered her head and went the other way down the coffee and tea aisle, tossing a few armfuls of decaf into her cart along the way. Florence stopped halfway down the aisle when she noticed the usual Serendipity blend end cap was gone. She turned to the shelves and looked through each one meticulously, her heart racing a bit faster with each shelf she found without Serendipity blend.

Florence was sprawled out on the floor, sifting through the bottom shelf of exotic espresso blends, when Paulie turned and walked down the aisle. Florence cursed under her breath and kept digging through the bags of espresso, ignoring Paulie until his feet were right next to her face.

"Good morning, Florence," Paulie greeted.

"Morning," Florence muttered.

"Looking for something?" he asked.

"Nothing I can't find myself." Florence shifted over a few feet and began digging through the next section of espresso beans, marked "discontinued blends." She froze as she found a lone bag of Serendipity blend, holding it up to Paulie.

"This...can't be?" she gasped.

"Afraid so," Paulie shrugged.

Florence stumbled to her feet, holding onto the lone bag of espresso beans like it was a life raft. "But we *need* these beans. We seriously *need*

them. That's why everyone comes to The Yurt!"

"That can't be the only reason," Paulie offered.

"No, it is! We need more of this, it's very important!"

"It was a one-time buy," Paulie explained. "We never meant to keep it on the shelves. And you all cleaned out the stock we did buy very quickly."

"Why didn't you tell me?" Florence wailed, louder than she intended to, but panic was settling into her vocal cords.

Paulie frowned. "Because you and I talk so much."

Florence sighed, her shoulders drooping.

"Look," Paulie said, a bit more gently. "The saleswoman said this was a limited blend. She was nice, offered to help sell it in the store, so we took it off her hands."

"Where is she now?" Florence pressed. "Is she here in Windia? Do you have contact info for her? Maybe I can find out more about the blend?"

Paulie studied Florence's face. "Why does this matter so much? We transferred in some Frank's Classically Roasted Beans for you all from another store. Just go back to that."

"No, we can't go back!" Florence exclaimed. "It's not good enough anymore." She tossed the last bag of Serendipity blend in the cart.

"Is this about the new coffee guy?" Paulie asked.

"Samson Richards," Florence muttered.

"Right." Paulie's jaw tightened. He looked down at his feet and sighed hard. "I'll see if I can find a phone number for the saleswoman, maybe on an invoice."

"Really?" Florence beamed hopefully.

Paulie smiled in response to her change in demeanor. "But it'll cost you. Let me have a few moments of your time tonight."

"Tonight?" Florence repeated. "At the Decaf Delight..."

"Evening event for lovers? Yep, that's the one."

Florence looked around the empty aisle. "Are you bringing someone?"

Paulie stared at her. "Nope."

"Oh." Florence quickly gathered her hoodie, only slightly damp now. "I'll just...go to self-checkout. I'll see you tonight."

Scurrying down the aisle, Florence rushed through self-checkout, making quick small talk with another customer who had been at The Yurt earlier that morning. She was soaked again by the time she loaded the decaf into her car and spent the drive home with the heater blasting and trying to figure out how to break the Serendipity blend news to Mia. By the time she got back to The Yurt, Florence decided to take the "no news is good news" approach and wait to see what Paulie finds out before telling Mia anything.

Luckily, the chaos within The Yurt kept anyone from asking Florence any questions, as Mia attempted to serve customers around Harper and her sprawling decorations.

"I'm going for a woodland theme, like an evening stroll through the forest," Harper announced over the whir of the sewing machine she'd set up in the lobby. A thick bolt of dark green velvet tumbled across her lap and onto the floor. She stopped the sewing machine and sighed, "It's going to be lovely."

In the kitchen, Diana and Pearl worked together flawlessly, removing baked goods at the perfect time without a timer, taking turns stirring the large pot of French onion soup, and keeping a steady flow of clean dishes moving from the milky white soapy water to the giant dish drainer that hung above the sink. Florence tied on an apron and joined the hubbub, hoping to help but also to avoid any interaction with Mia.

The Yurt closed at 5:00 pm for final preparations before promising to reopen to the public again at 8:00 pm. Pearl, Diana, and Florence finished in the kitchen, complete with all the dishes washed, dried, and put away; a job that had quickly been allocated to Florence once her lack of "kitchen magic" became painfully obvious. When they finally emerged from the kitchen, Diana gasped and squealed with delight, running around the coffee shop that had been completely transformed into a true forest wonderland.

"My word..." Pearl marveled, fingering the light green lace that hung from the ceiling like lichen, intertwined with fairy lights that twinkled like white stars. She walked over to Harper and hugged her, pulling back to look into Harper's beaming face. "Are you sure there isn't a little bit of magic in you?"

Florence silently made her way around The Yurt, studying every careful detail. The chairs had been transformed into toadstools and the tables into tree stumps, each topped with a candle that smelled like fir. The ground was sprinkled with pillowy puffs of cotton as though walking through a field of Cottonwood seeds. The lights were turned off except for over at the coffee bar, where the subdued illumination revealed menu items such as raspberry brie tartlets, beef Wellington bites, and sweet potato crostini. Florence had to wipe the tears from her eyes before turning back around. Everything reminded her of the events her mother used to hold, and how she dearly loved and believed in the little space that was The Yurt.

Florence hugged Harper, who was a disheveled mess but looked thoroughly pleased to contribute. "You are doing the decorations for New Year's Eve, right? Let me rephrase that, you *have* to do the decorations for New Year's Eve, okay?"

After The Yurt was cleaned up of leftover decorations and the desserts for the evening were stocked in the window case, Harper and the Mackenzie women retreated to their rooms for a quick nap and shower, making sure to allow enough time to get ready.

"I don't know what I'm going to wear," Florence sighed, digging through her suitcase that was filled with jeans, graphic T-shirts, and more hoodies than she'd ever need.

"You can wear one of my dresses," Harper offered, waving at her suitcase with her mascara wand. "I've got loads."

Florence had done her duty as a friend and worn many of Harper's creations, but tonight was not the night to glitter like a fairy. Actually, it probably was. "Maybe I'll see if there's anything in my old closet. I don't think I ever cleaned it out before I left."

The closet screeched just the same way Florence remembered it did, although exacerbated by time and the ocean air. The contents of the closet were a strange look into a past that didn't seem that long ago, and Florence's heart skipped when she spotted the dress she wore to both her mother and brother's funerals, wrapped in the soft plastic from the dry cleaners. She pushed the funeral dress aside to the farthest reach of the closet and finally settled on a long khaki skirt, fitted tank, and an oversized cardigan she used to wear all the time because the pale blue reminded her of the ocean at the first light of day. Florence's hair was mostly dry from the shower and she pulled it up into a loose top knot with a few tendrils framing her face. Her skirt was long enough to reach the floor so she opted to pamper her aching feet and wear a pair of house slippers.

Harper caught Florence slipping into the fuzzy brown slippers and stared at them hard, her eyes wide as they wandered up to Florence's face.

"What? It's my house," Florence reasoned. She paused and added, "But don't tell Mia."

Harper shrugged and returned to her makeup.

"Speaking of Mia," Florence continued hesitantly. "I didn't want to tell her, but I couldn't find any more of the Serendipity blend today."

"I'm sure the store will get more soon," Harper assured, leaning in closer to the mirror to brush her eyebrows.

Florence bit her lip. "No...they won't. Paulie said he'd try to track the sales rep down."

"Paulie," Harper repeated and turned to look at Florence. "Your ex from when you lived here?"

"He's coming tonight," Florence confirmed. She bit her lip harder. "And he wants to talk with me."

"Oh boy," Harper sighed. "That's never good." Her face twisted into an ornery smirk. "Maybe Mr. Richards will come tonight as well."

Florence snorted, about to retort something snarky. But she stopped and hesitated, as though someone reached out and grabbed her tongue and told her to wait and think.

"Maybe," she said finally.

Chapter Fifteen

THERE WAS ALREADY A crowd of couples gathered outside The Yurt when they opened the doors, bundled together in heavy coats and scarves, which were deposited with Diana for the makeshift coat check they'd set up in the kitchen. Florence stayed behind the counter to help Mia with the strictly decaf specialty drinks, trying her best to elevate them even though they were missing the magical addition of caffeine. Harper remained at the door to greet guests and tidy up after those that left, although most customers chose to linger in the warm, softly-lit Yurt.

Harper politely pushed through the crowd up to Florence, who was putting the finishing sprinkles on a pile of whipped cream.

"Do we have a maximum occupancy limit? Because I think we're getting close," she panted, her cheeks flushed.

"That's a good thing," Mia chimed in, looking cool under pressure. She took inventory of their remaining bags of decaf. "I'm glad you picked up so much decaf, we're going to need it. And you got more Serendipity, right?"

Florence and Harper exchanged glances.

"What?" Mia narrowed her eyes.

"I think it's my turn here on the register, why don't you go mingle, Florence?" Harper tried to sound convincing but it came off more suspicious.

Before Mia could interject, Florence quickly agreed and disappeared into the crowd. With the overhead lights dimmed to a dreamy level of

illumination, it wasn't hard to blend in with the group, except for the fact that Florence was single and everyone else was matched up in lovey-dovey pairs. As she strolled through the gathering, Florence studied the partners with interest, some of who she always thought would be perfect together, and some that surprised her with their pairing. Florence's eyes were drawn to the only other person in The Yurt that was not engaged in breathy conversation as she spotted Paulie standing in the corner by the greeting card rack, darkly looking from one end of the room to the other. He straightened up when he saw Florence approaching.

"Looks great in here," he said, looking around from one end of the room to the other. His eyes finally settled on Florence. "Your mom would be proud."

Florence nodded, fighting back tears that kept threatening to return.

"I found something," Paulie quickly continued, pulling a folded piece of paper from his pants pocket. "Name, contact number, and an address that the sales rep left on her invoice." Paulie shrugged. "I haven't called it yet, but hopefully this helps. If she doesn't want to sell directly to you, just let me know, we can work something out at the store."

Florence accepted the folded paper. "Thank you," she said quietly. "I really appreciate it. I know I've been short with you lately, but I really do think you're a great person."

"I used to think you felt that way about me," Paulie said, his voice edged with a touch of steel. "Now, I just feel like you hate me."

"I don't hate you," Florence sighed shakily, knowing this conversation was about to happen. "But things changed after high school. We became different people, and that's okay."

"So that's the only reason we broke up? We were just becoming different people? No other reason?" Paulie pressed.

Florence faltered, a bit taken aback by Paulie's sudden burst of intensity. "Well, I just-"

"I was there for you when both your brother and mother died."

"I know."

"You needed me. You leaned on me. I was important to you."

"I needed you as a friend. And I appreciate-"

"Then you left. You ran away from your family, Windia, and me."

Florence felt a fire begin to rise in her chest. "Paulie, we had been broken up for over a year before my brother passed away. I'm sorry I broke up with you, I didn't want to hurt you, I still wanted you in my life as a friend. I know that's not what you want to hear and I didn't want to have to repeat it, but we are friends. I tried to make that very clear again before I left Windia. I didn't want you to hold out hope."

"Oh, I haven't held out hope," Paulie snapped. "I don't have a lot of hope in someone like you."

The room seemed to hush but truly all the couples were too immersed in their own conversations to notice the exchange between Paulie and Florence. Pearl approached the two, dressed in a long white gown that could have been a wedding dress, dripping in pearls and strands of shells that jingled as she glided around The Yurt. She patted her hair which Diana had adorned with little plastic moths and dragonflies. She wrapped her arm around Florence's shoulder and held out her hand regally in Paulie's direction, who blinked in surprise and hesitantly knelt down to give it a quick peck.

"Paulie Vandermeier," Pearl crooned, withdrawing her hand and looking him up and down. "You look dashing. How are you this evening?"

"Uh, fine," Paulie replied, adjusting his shirt collar as though suddenly too warm.

"Wonderful," Pearl seethed through a forced smile. "And where's your other half?"

Paulie shifted between his feet. "What?"

"Your guest?" Pearl leaned forward, raising her voice a bit. "This is an event for couples, dear. If you don't have a guest, then you best be on your way."

Paulie snorted. "And where's your other half?"

"Oh precious," Pearl laughed, waving her hand at Paulie. "There aren't any men good enough for a Mackenzie woman in this town."

Florence forcefully bit her lip to keep from laughing. She looked up to see Paulie's face reddening as he tightened his jaw.

"Your family's crazy anyway," he muttered, pushing past Florence and Pearl as he stomped to the front door.

"Oh yes, darling!" Pearl called after him. "We most certainly are!"

What followed next was the most maniacal, witch-like cackle that Florence had ever heard uttered by her grandmother. She threw back her head and seemed to summon the laugh from the depths of her soul, releasing it to reverberate between the walls, bounce off the ceiling, and rush around the room like a gust of wind. Paulie ran out the door and it slammed behind him. Florence was joining in before she knew what was happening, tears streaming from her face in a fit of release. Behind them, Mia howled from the coffee bar as Harper watched with a mixture of horror and fascination. They laughed and howled until they were gasping for

breath. The Decaf Delight attendees stared at them, unflinching until Pearl clapped her hands and commanded, "As you were!" As though a skipping song had just corrected itself, the Decaf Delight event continued without a word about the raucous cackling and howling.

"Why don't you go get some air?" Pearl suggested with a swish of her lacy shawl. "I have crumpets to arrange."

As everything seemed under control inside The Yurt and she had allowed enough time for Paulie to stomp through the sand back to his car, Florence agreed that the bracing December air sounded like what she needed. After grabbing a sweatshirt she had stashed behind the greeting card rack earlier that day while cleaning, Florence slipped through the front door unnoticed.

Outside, Florence huddled beneath the bright porch light that had the most infuriatingly difficult replacement bulbs to find, but it was another of Great-Grandfather Mackenzie's installations and they couldn't bear to replace it. Everything past the reach of the porch light's beams was hazy darkness, the evening fog especially thick and heavy that night. Florence stared into it, listening to the steady rising and crashing of the waves until she felt like her breathing matched its rhythm. She pushed Paulie out of her mind with intention, recognizing he still felt pain but also accepting she had done everything possible at that time to let him know they were over. But sometimes hurt is hard to get over. Florence looked towards the sea and closed her eyes. She knew all about that.

She opened her eyes at the sound of footsteps approaching, preparing herself that it may be Paulie back to have the last word. Florence's stomach did a flip flop when she instantly recognized the outline of Samson Richards' form emerging through the mist. He was carrying a folded towel, the same towel she'd left for him the day before while he tousled with the

freezing Pacific. He was dressed in slacks and a crisp checkered collar stuck out from the neckline of his wool sweater. Florence looked down and made sure her slippers were still covered by her skirt, then straightened up and cleared her throat.

Maybe he'd already seen her standing on the porch, but Samson was not surprised by the sound of Florence loudly clearing her throat. His steps slowed as he cautiously approached the entry to The Yurt and offered the folded towel out like an olive branch.

"Nice slippers," he remarked with a smirk.

"Thank you," Florence said with a small smile, taking the towel. "I wasn't expecting this returned."

"No, thank *you*," Samson replied solemnly. "It was sorely needed. And don't worry, I had the motel wash it."

Florence laughed and nodded, unsure why she was laughing and unsure what to say next. Actually, she was sure, and it had been weighing heavily on her mind since yesterday. She sobered and clasped her hands together.

"While we're on the subject of thank-yous," she began, looking down at her hands and forcing herself to look up again. "Thank you for what you did yesterday."

"No problem," Samson answered quickly. "I guess I can take that off my bucket list."

"The Espresso Off or swimming naked in the ocean?"

"Both."

The music tempo changed inside The Yurt and climbed up a few decibels, inciting a cheer and loud, pulsing stomps.

"Sounds like quite the party in there," Samson remarked.

"Yes, it's good we don't have any neighbors too close," Florence agreed, thinking back to many, many instances where the sounds emitting from The Yurt over the years would have unsettled a resident or two.

Samson put his hands in his pockets and turned to look towards the dark sea, roaring in and out beyond the dense fog.

"You do have an amazing location here, there's no doubt about that." He turned back to Florence and shrugged. "At the risk of putting our polite and civil conversation in peril, I have to say there is a lot of untapped potential here."

Florence sighed and Samson put up his hands in a sign of surrender.

"I know, I know," Samson said quickly. "Family. If there's one thing I understand about your...unconventional...family, is that you clearly love and look out for each other."

"And you're missing something else," Florence added. "We are all we have. This is all we have. My mother, my brother...this is all we have left of them, too."

Samson stared at Florence. "Your grandmother told me about your mom, I'm sorry. But your brother, too?"

"Six months before her. The cancer came quick and took him." Why was she telling him this? Why was he asking?

Lowering his eyes, he sighed and shook his head. He finally looked back up. "What was his name?"

"Dylan. Dylan Mackenzie."

"Your poor niece. I'm sorry. I have a brother, too. Josh is his name."

"He was my big brother. He always knew what to do," Florence croaked, trying not to cry. "The Yurt wasn't really his thing, but he always pitched in

when he could. He and Mia had wanted to start a restaurant together, he had plans to build it next door."

Samson looked to the north of The Yurt towards a vacant lot that was usually filled with beachgoers. "I can see a restaurant working great there, I'm sorry it didn't work out." Samson seemed to catch himself and looked up at Florence. "I mean, I'm sorry your brother passed away."

"Sometimes I wish, if they had to both die...sometimes I wish Dylan had died after my mom," Florence whispered. "I think it killed her to see him go." It was a thought she'd never felt brave enough to say out loud. And now that it was out, free in the air, she wondered what wings it would take.

They stood in silence for a long minute, Florence trying her best not to sob and Samson trying his best not to stare. Finally, when Florence's sniffles seemed to be picking up speed, Samson climbed the steps to the porch and enveloped her in a hug. His arms wrapped completely around Florence, encircling her with a ring of strength that seemed to say *nothing can pass this*. Florence buried her face in his chest; it was warm and smelled like clean cotton and motel soap. She closed her eyes and cried in that safe space where he said nothing but understood everything.

The front door creaked open and then shut quickly, but the motion was enough to get Florence's attention and snap her back to the present. She wiped her running nose on her sweatshirt and backed up from Samson, who released his embrace. He studied her face as Florence tried to look anywhere but at him.

"Sorry," she finally muttered.

"No, it's okay," Samson said, shrugging. "Really."

"Thanks." Florence finally met Samson's gaze and lingered there until he turned back to the steps.

"Well, I better go and let you get back to your event," he said quickly, descending down the steps and back onto the sand.

"Did you want to come in?" Florence asked.

"Thanks anyway, but I'm sure there's a fair amount of baked ammunition in there and this is my last clean shirt."

They both laughed and Samson waved a farewell and started to walk away.

"Wait," Florence called out suddenly.

Samson stopped. "What?"

"My mom's name was Flora," Florence blurted out. She felt like he should know.

Samson nodded. "Flora. That's a nice name." He paused, then waved again. "Goodnight."

"Goodnight." Florence watched Samson leave, his footsteps still audible although his presence was cloaked by the fog.

The front door to The Yurt flew open with a burst of music, revealing Diana who was up entirely too late past her bedtime.

"Aunt Florence!" she exclaimed. "There you are! You've got to come, Pearl is dancing all crazy and Mom says she's gonna break a hip!"

"Oh dear, I'm coming," Florence laughed, assuming her grandmother was dancing on the countertop again. She took one last look in Samson's direction and followed her niece inside, closing the door and leaving the darkness outside.

Chapter Sixteen

B EING NEW YEAR'S EVE fell on a weekend and most of Windia's coffee drinkers were up late at the Decaf Delight evening event for lovers, the Mackenzie's felt safe opening The Yurt a few hours late so they could sleep in. The party had stretched until the first hint of dawn started to peek on the horizon, finishing with promises to continue the festivities that night at the Magic at Midnight New Year's Eve event.

Florence was asleep before her head hit the pillow, but not before setting an alarm to wake up before the rest of the women. She wanted to make a phone call but not within earshot of her family members who had exceptionally excellent hearing for a child, a woman that sat front row at countless concerts, and an old witch who plays gothic chants in her headphones at full volume. The cell reception inside the house was terrible, so Florence was forced to use the landline in the kitchen, an off-white plastic phone with a cord long enough to stretch halfway across the house.

Tiptoeing across the hall, Florence breathed a sigh of relief when she finally reached the kitchen and curled up on the bench tucked into the phone corner, topped with a thick cushion and blanket for late night or early morning conversations. On the wall hung a bulletin board with a hodgepodge of business cards and old flyers pinned to it and on the floor was stashed a few fashion magazines for long hold times. Florence unfolded the piece of paper that Paulie had delivered the night before and picked up the receiver, slowly dialing each number as though the sound of

each tone would wake up the other women in the house. As the number rang, Florence looked around the filthy kitchen and realized she had no idea what she was going to say.

The phone rang seven times and just as Florence was about to give up, a female voice on the side whispered, "Hello?"

"Hello?" Florence fumbled with the note from Paulie. Along with the phone number was written *Sally Creighton, Jupiter Knight Coffee and Teas*. "Can I speak with Sally Creighton, please?"

"Speaking," the woman replied.

"Oh, thank goodness. My name is Florence Mackenzie and I purchased your Serendipity blend beans at a store in Windia, Oregon," Florence blurted out.

"Windia's Wonderland?" Sally interjected. "Charming store."

"Yes, that's the one." Florence took a deep breath. "And you see, my family owns a small coffee shop in town and once we started selling your blend, well, business took off. And there's a competitor in town we *need* to keep up with to show him there's no use staying in town. But I've bought all the stock at Windia's Wonderland and they told me it was a one-time buy and to call you direct." Florence took a breath. "I need to order more Serendipity blend and have it shipped here as soon as possible, please." Florence lowered her voice to a whisper, "It's imperative."

Sally said nothing but Florence could hear her breathing so she knew they hadn't lost connection. She somehow got the distinct impression that Sally was smiling.

"I'm sorry," Sally chuckled. "I understand your plight, but that was the extent of Windia's allotment, I'm afraid."

"Allotment?" Florence repeated.

"Yes." Sally sounded serious. "I can only allot so many beans of Serendipity blend per town; it's all based on population size."

"I...don't understand. Are you out of stock?"

"Oh, no, no," Sally laughed.

"So, I need to order more," Florence said sternly, trying to use her best business-owner voice.

"Your town has just the right amount." Sally sounded a bit firmer this time.

Florence was silent. She rubbed her head, hard.

"Florence," Sally said slowly. "Have you noticed anything different about the residents of Windia?"

"No, they just want their coffee and you're stopping me from giving it to them!" Florence snapped.

Sally seemed unfazed. "Any...new attachments that surprised you? Long, unrequited love that finally came to bloom?"

Barb and Mark immediately came to Florence's mind, along with a few dozen other couples that Florence had no idea were attached until last night's event.

"Maybe," she said finally. "Why?"

"Mm, hmm," Sally murmured. "Lovely."

Florence had a thought. "Are you a witch?"

"Maybe," Sally replied wryly. "Why?"

"Did you put some sort of curse or spell on my town?" Florence demanded. "Because my grandmother-"

"Well," Sally gasped. "That's quite an accusation. I provide products for consumption, I don't dally in curses, dear."

"And are these *enchanted* products, by chance?" Florence pressed.

"Did you even read the label?"

"What label?"

"On the beans."

"What...you mean the *there's magic in every bean*, thing?"

"Couldn't be any clearer, really."

Florence laughed nervously. "That's just a slogan." She stopped laughing. "Isn't it?"

"Lovely speaking with you, Florence," Sally said, her voice suddenly sounding far away. "Happy New Year!"

Then the phone went silent. Florence panicked and whispered to herself, pressing the receiver frantically and redialing Sally's number. She tried it three different times but each call resulted in a message stating the number was disconnected. Florence slammed the phone back on the receiver and stood up to throw Sally's number in the trash. She jumped and screamed at the forms of Pearl, Mia, Diana, and Harper standing in the kitchen doorway.

Pearl crossed her arms. "What have you done?"



"So we've infected our town with magic love beans?"

The Mackenzie women and Harper were gathered in Pearl's study, a converted sunroom that had once housed a Jacuzzi, plant starts, and gym equipment over the years. Once Pearl took over the room, she lined the walls with shelves of multicolor books and hung long, ancient plants in front of the floor-length windows, which filtered the light with a chartreuse hue. Several long tables were pushed together in the middle of the room, covered with pots, jars, little statues, and more books. When Florence was a

child, Pearl told her to stay out because it was her magic conservatory. Now, Florence realized it was just because the room is a complete mess.

"We can fix this," Pearl muttered, squinting her eyes as she browsed through her shelves of books.

Florence sat in an oversized stuffed chair, tucking her knees under her sweatshirt and hanging her head. "I didn't mean to," she mumbled into her arm.

"What's the harm? Everyone needs a little love. And it's been good for business." Mia shrugged. "It's not like we gave them lice."

Harper grimaced and scratched her head. "That's a terrible comparison."

"The harm, dearest, is that enchantments are a manipulation of the mind and spirit, however innocent a magic love bean may seem," Pearl explained. She looked over her shoulder at Mia. "And we look after the people of Windia. So that's why we are going to fix this."

"Found it!" Diana announced from where she'd been sprawled on the tile floor, looking through stacks of mismatched jars. She presented a large jar of richly colored herbs to Pearl, who patted her great-granddaughter on the head.

"Excellent work, Diana. That enchantress wouldn't stand a chance against you," Pearl said as she held the jar up to the light.

"Enchantress?" Harper repeated. "Did I wake up in a fairytale this morning?"

Pearl ignored her granddaughter's friend and tapped the glass jar with her finger. "This is uncrossing incense," she explained. "Sure to break any enchantment or curse."

"How does it work?" Mia asked. She'd long ago relinquished the last of her skepticism over the beliefs embraced by the Mackenzie family. It was

easier to aid them and get it over with.

"It must be burned in a subject's presence and the smoke will wash away the enchantment," Diana spoke up in a very adult-like tone.

"Very good!" Pearl clapped.

"What exactly have you been teaching my daughter? I thought she was learning to bake," Mia queried.

Pearl dismissed her concerns with a wave of her hand. "Magic and baking go together," she insisted. "And Diana's correct. The smoke from the incense will cleanse the afflicted of their curse."

"I don't know why you are all calling this a curse," Harper interjected. "I haven't had a date in a year. I could use a little of that *curse* myself."

"Enchantment or curse, whatever it is, I started this mess so I'm going to fix it," Florence announced, standing from her chair. "Even if it means going to every house in Windia and setting this right. It'll take me time, but I'll do it."

The other women stared at Florence's outburst.

"Darling," Pearl said gently, exchanging glances with the others in the room. "Everyone will be at the New Year's Eve party tonight. We can just do it then."

"We'll just wait for the stroke of midnight so any outside stragglers will come in for the countdown," Mia added. She paused and raised a hand to her head. "Oh, good grief. *Magic at Midnight*, could we be any more on the nose?"

"And this way we can keep an eye on them for any reactions," Diana also added. "Although I'll probably have to go to bed before that," she muttered.

"Oh." Florence sat back down. "Yeah, that's easier."

"But great job being committed to fixing your mistakes," Harper assured her friend. She took a long swig of coffee. "I better get started on the decorating."

"And I need to clean." Mia followed Harper with her own coffee in hand. "There won't be any magic happening around here with the state of The Yurt."

"It's almost as though someone was up partying until dawn," Diana said with a sly smile.

"How did you get so sassy?" Mia laughed, reaching out for her daughter's hand.

"Great-grandma," Diana answered sweetly. "And Florence. And you."

"Oh yeah," Mia laughed again. "Come on, I'll make you a hot chocolate."

Pearl looked over at her granddaughter, who was slumped against the side of the armchair.

"You don't have sole responsibility in this," she assured. "That could have been any of us that picked up those beans."

"I know," Florence sighed.

"I've dealt with a fair amount of enchantments over the years, most involving love or lack thereof," Pearl continued as she looked into the jar of uncrossing incense. "Of all the curses an enchantress could have placed on Windia, this is fairly tame."

"But why Windia?" Florence lamented. "And why coffee beans?"

"Ah, dear, there have been wandering witches like this since the dawn of time. And why not?" Pearl shrugged. "It worked, didn't it? A clever way to spread a spell, if you ask me. And I'm guessing there are mechanics to an enchantment like this. Can't have someone running off and falling in love

with a plank of wood." A small smile quirked at the corners of Pearl's lips.

"Say, you've been drinking the espresso, right?"

"Heavily," Florence admitted.

"Do you remember the first time you drank it?"

"At Windia's Wonderland, I think. The saleswoman, er, enchantress was giving out samples."

"Who else was there?"

"Well, the enchantress. Paulie was around somewhere. And Samson Richards."

"I see," Pearl whispered as she opened the jar of uncrossing incense and took a light sniff. "Interesting."

"Pearl," Florence said firmly. "I am not under a spell and in love with Samson Richards."

"I didn't say that you were."

"And he is not under a spell and in love with me, either."

Pearl closed the lid delicately. "Again...I didn't say that he was."

Florence exclaimed something unintelligible and stomped towards the door.

"Florence," Pearl called after her. "It wouldn't be so bad if you did. Or even had an inkling of it. The business will be fine. We'll all be fine. Nothing good comes from ignoring our heart's desire."

Stopping at the doorway, Florence looked over her shoulder. "There's no inkling. And besides, even if there was, it'll all be washed away tonight, right?"

Florence fled before her grandmother could say another word or sense the shift in her emotions. Because there was an inkling and she didn't want to admit it to herself, much less her infuriating grandmother who always

seemed to know everything. She didn't want to admit she'd been distracted all night after Samson left, revisiting that embrace over and over again, wanting to remember every detail of that feeling that everything was going to be okay. And wondering why he, of all people, could make her feel that way.



The theme for the Decaf Delight event was a magical forest, so of course, it was only appropriate that Harper chose a dreamy beach theme for Magic at Midnight. It took a solid two hours to hang the twinkle lights and dark blue gauze across the ceiling of The Yurt. This time Mia went on the shopping trip to Windia's Wonderland while Florence helped customers until The Yurt shut down early again to prep for the evening reveal. They had learned from last night's event to remove the tables and chairs and separate the food from the coffee station. Diana worked on assembling a magical beach-themed playlist while Pearl whipped up treats such as chocolate cream éclairs, coconut tarts with strawberries, and salted caramel cheesecake. The New Year's Eve event at The Yurt had been a yearly tradition since Pearl was a teenager and most of Windia included it as part of their evening festivities, with even the most skeptical resident stopping by for a little bit of magic for the new year.

"It'll be a full moon tonight," Pearl reminded the girls. "Get ready for an extra dose of special."

Chapter Seventeen

THE WINDIA BEE REPORTER shifted from cradling her chin in her left hand to her right hand. She blinked rapidly in an attempt to soothe her stinging eyes that were irritated by her heavy layers of mascara. A gust of wind blew a tendril of straightened hair into the reporter's face, sticking to her lips that were slathered with strawberry gloss. She picked away the hair as femininely as possible, taking her time so to showcase her nails that were done that very morning.

Samson drummed his fingers on the picnic table in Four Corners Square where he and the Windia Bee reporter had been conducting an interview for over an hour. Some of the reporter's questions seemed a bit invasive, but Samson politely played along, besides, who was really going to read the story, anyway? Samson looked over his shoulder at the decent line of customers queued outside his coffee cart. A loud clattering and shout erupted from inside the cart where his employee was struggling to keep up.

"Well, I think I need to get back," Samson declared, accompanied with his most charming grin. "But thank you so much for your time and the positive press for Sam's 'Spresso."

The Windia Bee reporter snapped out of her dreamy state and fumbled with her recorder. "Of course!" she exclaimed. "You're a busy man and I'm so grateful that you made some time for me." She fluttered her eyes. "Makes me feel special."

Another shout and loud clattering from within the Sam's 'Spresso coffee cart rang through the air, causing the customers in line to exchange worried glances.

"Well, that's my cue!" Samson said as he jumped up from the table. "Looking forward to reading the story. Tomorrow, right?"

"Mm-hmm, front page, I'm sure," the reporter confirmed. "And I'll see you tonight, right?"

Samson halted his escape. "Tonight?"

"New Year's Eve, you silly," the reporter giggled.

"Yes..." Samson furrowed his brow, wondering if he had committed to something unknowingly.

"New Year's Eve at The Yurt," the reporter said impatiently. "The Magic at Midnight event? Everyone's going to be there."

"Well, I'm not sure I'd be welcome." Samson tried to sound charming but in truth, he wasn't sure how he'd be received by the Mackenzie women if he attended. And he wasn't sure how he'd feel about it, either. He'd spent all night pondering that very thought.

"You have to come," the reporter whined. "Those women are a bunch of loons but they do throw a good party."

Samson scowled. "They're not a bunch of loons."

The reporter didn't seem to notice Samson's correction. "Plus, I'll be there. That's incentive enough, right?"

This time Samson was saved by a scream followed by a loud hiss inside the coffee cart.

"I'll see what I can do! Take care!" Samson called as he sprinted back to the coffee cart.

It didn't take Samson more than 20 minutes to serve the customers in line, whipping up Sam's 'Spresso classics like Minty Mochas, Vanilla and Carmel Twists, and Chocolate Hazelnut lattes. Free to experiment away from the regimented menu designed by his father, Samson was rather proud of the drinks he had conjured up himself. But whether or not his father would be interested in his drink designs were the last of Samson's worries.

The little Sam's 'Spresso satellite shop had a great deal of pressure on its spindly shoulders. Samson stretched and went outside for some fresh air once the customers were gone, feeling a similar sort of pressure on his own shoulders. He looked out towards the Pacific at the quickly setting sun, reflecting on how his time in Windia was likely coming to an end as well. He was told to expect a phone call from his father by the end of the day and Samson would bet his life it was not to wish him a happy new year.

"Let's close up early, what do you say?" Samson called out. His employee eagerly agreed and the two men locked the shop's windows and door, although there wasn't much threat of vandalism in Windia.

"So are we closed tomorrow? For the holiday?" Samson's employee asked. He was a borrowed barista from the Portland team who had been requested/ordered to come assist at the Windia branch. He'd been staying at the only motel in Windia just like Samson and been on his best behavior around the owner's son.

Samson paused before answering, checking his cell phone for that anticipated phone call. He slicked back his hair and tried to put on his best managerial voice that sounded a little too similar to his father's for his liking. "You know, why don't you go ahead and return to Portland. Have a good New Year's and I'll contact you if we need any further help out here."

"Really?" the employee's eyes lit up. He checked his watch, visibly adding up the time it would take to pack up at the motel and drive back to Portland. It seemed to have a favorable result since the employee quickly shook Samson's hand and started walking back to the motel with a spring in his step.

Samson checked the coffee cart one last time and started walking in no particular direction. He just needed to walk, to clear his head, to ease his churning stomach. He passed the coin laundry mat and waved at Tellie, the elderly owner who Samson learned used to have a longstanding "correspondence affair" with a previous president of the United States, although she wouldn't say which one. He walked by the small park with a slide and swing set that looked to have provided fun for more than a generation or two. Then Samson realized where his feet were taking him, to a lone bench uphill that he'd discovered on one of his morning jogs, a bench he'd never seen anyone else at, as though it was placed there just for him. Overlooking most of Windia, the bench provided a perfect view of the Pacific, over the treetops, to the sparkling waters that stretched to the horizon and far beyond.

Samson sat on the bench and closed his eyes. His time in Windia had not gone as planned. He had been here for longer than intended and achieved far less than hoped for. He'd, in fact, accomplished nothing.

When his father started Sam's 'Spresso in a little shop on the outskirts of their Portland suburb, Samson was a toddler who thought nothing was more fun than hiding behind the counter. As the years went by and the Sam's 'Spresso shop graduated into a chain of coffee carts, Samson learned quickly he could see his father more if he showed interest in the business. And he was interested, for the most part.

But he wasn't a teenage boy picking up a shift after class, anymore. He'd attended business school and interned at numerous marketing agencies, trying to learn all he could to help grow their brand. But what Samson learned fell on deaf ears, stuck forever in pretty presentations that Sam Richards had no interest in. But one suggestion did strike home. Expanding beyond the bustle of Portland had finally been the middle ground they could agree on. Samson had his own spring in his step that fateful afternoon when Sam agreed to allow his son to go negotiate a deal with a carefully vetted, hidden gem undiscovered by their competitors. A little town named Windia.

Surely this little coffee shop will be elated to have an offer like ours, Samson remembers thinking as he walked up the steps to The Yurt for the first time. But that had not been the reception he'd received. Samson moved on to Plan B, convincing his father he needed the mobile cart to show Windia what they could offer.

But these Mackenzie women! Samson kicked the earth, a mix of rich soil and gray sand. He had to admire their dedication to their own brand, he'd give them that. He'd probably even do the same thing. Samson thought he might have a chance when Florence came along. She seemed more reasonable, a bit more level-headed, and she was just the type of cute he'd be attracted to if they weren't in this situation. Samson rubbed his face hard. Because he'd had to admit to himself last night, he *was* attracted to her, despite the circumstances. Why else would he half freeze to death in the Pacific just because he didn't want to see her cry?

But this was his business. His family's business. This was his future. His family's future.

"I'm counting on you," Sam Richards had said. "Make this deal happen and I'll put you in charge of development. I'll give you until the end of the

year to settle the details."

Now it was sunset on New Year's Eve. Samson's cell phone rang. He took a deep breath and answered.

"Hello, Dad."

"Sammy!" Sam Richards exclaimed on the other end of the phone line. There was a loud commotion of voices, music, and dishes clattering in the background. Apparently, New Year's Eve celebrations had already begun.

"Starting the night early?" Samson chuckled.

"Of course, no other way to do it!" Sam laughed deeply and loudly. "Your aunt's got the tots going. I'm sorry you're not here and off in backcountry."

Samson looked around himself, at the shimmering ocean that had accepted the setting sun, at the forest beside him that was settling down for the night, and the little town of Windia that was buzzing with the excitement of a new year.

"It's not so bad," Samson admitted finally.

"Well, I certainly hope not! Especially if it's the next conquest in the Sam's 'Spresso empire!"

Samson said nothing.

There was a rustling on the line and the sound of muffled voices as it appeared Sam Richards was moving away from the party. Next came the loud slam of a door and Sam returned to the line.

"In my office now," he explained, his voice much clearer. "Can't talk business out there with those ruffians your cousin brings over."

"Dad..."

"Okay, fill me in. What've you worked out? Did bringing the cart into town help?"

"In a way," Samson sighed. "I've definitely met a lot of town folk and they've all had a positive response to our drinks and our prices."

Sam Richards waited.

"But," Samson said through gritted teeth. "There's also a lot of loyalty to the Mackenzie's shop. And the Mackenzie's themselves...well, they're not budging."

"Why?" His father's voice showed no emotion.

"There's a great deal of sentimental attachment to the shop. Not to mention it's the only source of income for the family."

"Our offer would take care of them for years to come, it was more than generous." Now Sam's voice sounded like low, rumbling thunder.

"I'm aware of that," Samson agreed. "But it's not about the money for them."

"Of course it's about the money."

"It's not in this case, it's about their family." Why did Samson feel like he was defending them?

Sam Richards was silent for a length of time that made Samson check if his cell phone had lost connection.

"Your job, as our representative, was to make them see the benefits of the deal," Sam said finally. "And to negotiate and close that deal in a way that benefits *your* family."

"I understand that. But-"

"And, to be honest, son, I've been in this business a long time and I hate to say it, but I had a seed of doubt about you. So I made a few calls."

"Called who?"

"First, I called Mayor Lincoln to make an introduction and invite the man out to our lake house. You know, it never hurts to get in good with the local

politicians. So he and I start chatting about our endeavors and he informs me of a little bit of history about *The Yurt*, as they call it. He told me the original deal for the land rights with the old Mackenzie fellow was sealed with just a handshake."

Samson said nothing but continued to listen. He wasn't surprised, he'd learned a great deal of obscure local history in his time at Windia.

There was the sound of papers shuffling as Sam continued. "That's how things used to be, you know, a handshake and a man's word meant something back then. But something still didn't sit right with me. Call it instinct or maybe the wariness of an old businessman, but I thought it warranted a call to City Hall. And, my son, listen here. *They still don't legally own that property.*"

"What?" Samson shouted so loud a flock of birds scattered and moved onto another section of the forest.

"I'm telling you, I don't know how it's gotten by, but they never filed anything official. There's no legal records, nothing in their name to say that property belongs to them. The folk down at City Hall don't seem concerned about it since, as they said, everyone knows that's Old Mackenzie's land." Sam continued. "But a handshake doesn't hold up in court these days."

Samson shook his head. Did the Mackenzie's know?

"So things look a little different now, don't they? That's what we call leverage."

"More like a knife to their throats," Samson grumbled.

"I think that deal will look a little sweeter to them now, unless they want us to report them to the authorities." Sam sounded very pleased with himself. Samson could imagine his father leaning back in his chair with his heels up on his desk. "It all works out in the end."

"And what if I don't want to?" Samson asked.

"How's that?"

"What if I don't want to go threaten a group of women that are just trying to keep their business afloat?"

"It's not a threat, it's business! They're on that property illegally! We have every right to report them and take that land right off the city's hands!" Sam roared.

"I scouted this location," Samson growled. "I drafted the contract. I'm here doing the work. So I'll decide what I want to do with this information."

"Well, if that's how you feel, alright then," Sam replied coolly. "And if this deal falls through, I'm sure you'll accept the consequences."

Both men were silent.

"Happy new year, son."

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Chapter Eighteen

FLORENCE LOOKED UP AT a knock on her bedroom door. She'd finished her hair and Harper was done applying her makeup, promising to keep it as natural as possible while still adding a bit of Magic at Midnight sparkle. After Harper left to light the candles and handle any other last-minute touches, Florence felt the overwhelming need to lay down. To stare at the ceiling she'd stared at a thousand times before. To soak in the familiar light of her childhood bedroom. Something inside told her to breathe. Something inside told her everything would change after tonight.

Florence stood up and opened the door. It was Pearl, dressed in attire best described as an elegant mermaid who was blessed with one night to walk on land. She was holding a dress draped over her arm, wrapped in protective plastic from the dry cleaners.

She held up the dress. "Can I come in?"

Florence moved aside to allow her grandmother inside.

"I'm already dressed," Florence said, pointing down at the long blue skirt and flowy white top that Harper had chosen for her.

Pearl blinked and looked her granddaughter up and down. "Yes, dear. You're wearing clothes." She held out the plastic-covered dress. "But a special night calls for a special dress."

Florence removed the plastic to reveal an A-line, knee-length black dress, covered with dark sequins that changed color with each movement, like

scales catching light beneath a dark sea. Florence twirled the dress and it swished like a wave crashing on the beach. It was beautiful.

"It was your mother's," Pearl said quietly, as though she heard Florence's thoughts.

"Really?" Florence marveled at the dress. "I don't remember her ever wearing it."

"Some things get put away after we have children, dear," Pearl sighed, sitting down on the bed. "But that's not to say it never happened." She paused, searching for the right words to say next. "You should wear this dress tonight. And I want you to help me with the uncrossing ceremony."

Florence almost dropped the dress. "Me?" she exclaimed.

"Yes, you," Pearl confirmed. She looked down at her hands. "Sometimes I fear you've forgotten a part of yourself. You tease about Diana and her penchant for magic. But dearest, it was not long ago that you were that little girl, helping me in the kitchen, creating magic of your own. I fear you've distanced yourself too much. I can understand why. I know with your mother and your brother...I know there was so much pain. Or maybe time simply passed and you got caught up in life, I don't know. But there are some very core parts of you, my dear, that you've forgotten. And I believe tonight, with the full moon behind you, is the time to find your way back."

Gently fingering the soft satin that lined the inside of her mother's dress, Florence said nothing. Standing from the bed, Pearl gave her granddaughter a long hug, finally pulling back and looking her directly in the eyes.

"You'll do fine," she whispered, patting Florence on the head. She turned to exit the room but stopped at the doorway. "But, no matter what, do not wear that. You look like a pirate in a potato sack race."

Florence laughed through the tears as her grandmother gently closed the door behind her. She looked at the clock. It was almost 9:00 pm. Diana would be asleep, tucked in bed and the doors to The Yurt would be unlocked. She could already hear the laughs and the voices of the residents of Windia outside, excitement for the evening ahead bubbling through the crowd. A knot twisted in Florence's stomach. She understood what her grandmother had told her, how a part of her had been silenced when her mother and brother died. It was safer that way; it was one less thing to remind her of them. The numbness that came from leaving Windia and quieting her inner voice brought Florence a reprieve from her grief. But slowly over time, she'd started to feel like someone else, which was never the plan or intention.

Florence unzipped the dress. It was time to feel complete again.



"You guys really know how to throw a party!"

Harper dodged an arm that was waving along with the blasting music. She was taking a moment of respite from behind the counter, where Mia was fulfilling a flurry of orders. Pearl was dancing in the center of The Yurt amongst the crowd, leaving only to get a drink of water, rearrange the food, or switch the song when it slowed down.

"They come prepared to party like this," Mia shouted with a smile, remembering her own years as an attendee instead of a business owner. It was still fun, even as the person serving the drinks instead of consuming them.

The Windia Bee reporter pushed through the crowd, collapsing on the counter with a dramatic flair. She rearranged her curls and smoothed down her tight satin dress.

Mia recognized her and put on her most charming smile. "Happy New Year! What can I get you?"

The reporter was only half interested in what Mia was saying as she scanned the room. "Nothing for me, I'm here professionally but also personally, as well. Maybe I'll have a drink when my date gets here."

"Oh? Who's your date? There's been a lot of new attachments lately," Mia said, giving Harper a sideways look.

"Samson Richards." The reporter looked at the girls slyly and watched for their reactions.

"Oh." Harper and Mia said at the same time.

The reporter held up her camera. "I'm off to take some snaps. Catch up with you ladies later."

"Have a great night," Mia said through gritted teeth as the reporter blended back into the crowd.

"Speaking of Samson Richards, where's Florence?" Harper asked, looking around. "I left her ages ago back in her room."

Harper looked over at Mia when she didn't answer. She was staring, openmouthed, behind Harper. Florence had emerged from the shadows, her black sequined dress almost blinding when it caught the light just right. She had redone her hair as well, pulling it down from the slick bun Harper had styled and letting it hang free with her natural waves.

"You look amazing!" Harper gasped. "Like, really amazing!"

"You look like your mom." Mia brushed by Harper to hold Florence by the shoulders and look her over closely. "It's incredible."

A holler erupted from the center of the dance floor as Pearl directed all eyes back to Florence.

"That's my granddaughter!" she bellowed. "Get out here, girl!"

"Oh no," Florence moaned, her eyes widening to the size of large coffee mugs. She turned to retreat.

"You heard her!" Mia laughed, gentling pushing Florence towards the dance floor.

The crowd cheered and parted for Florence, who had no choice now but to respond to her grandmother's flamboyant beckoning. With a flick of Pearl's wrist, the music abruptly changed to an energetic Scottish tune, which incited another cheer from the crowd. Much to Florence's relief, the call of the music was too much for the crowd to deny as they joined her in the center of the dance floor. It didn't take long for Florence to forget that her dancing was anything but rhythmic, allowing herself to get swept up in the rushing beat of the music and the frenzy of the crowded dance floor.

With a rising crescendo, the music halted and switched to a song with a slower tempo, allowing the crowd a chance to catch their breath and recover. The Yurt was stifling with the combination of body heat and the little wall heaters that started with a loud buzz when the outdoor temperature got too low. While Florence opened the stiff windows, Pearl went to pop open The Yurt's front door. As she flung open the door, Samson Richards stumbled inside, catching himself right before he hit the floor.

"Well, well, look who I found." Pearl looked slyly over at Florence.

No one else seemed to notice Samson's stumbling entry other than Florence, who was pressed against the window behind the crowd. Samson was dressed in the same tailored blue suit he wore the first time she saw him, probably the only suit he brought to Windia to conduct a simple

business deal to buy a coffee shop. Florence had to smile to herself as Samson straightened his suit and looked around to see if anyone noticed his blunder. The poor guy had no idea what he was in for when he packed that suit for Windia.

"Sam!" a voice squealed above the music.

Florence watched as the Windia Bee reporter shoved her way to Samson, knocking a plate of appetizers out of a reveler's hands. Her heels clacked across the wood floors until she reached him. Florence couldn't hear their conversation but their body language said it all as the reporter played with her hair and Samson kept his hands firmly in his pockets. The reporter motioned towards the coffee bar as though to offer Samson a drink, which he waved away with a small smile and shake of his head. She didn't appear to take no for an answer, bobbing her head as she motioned for him to wait while she went to the coffee bar. Once she turned and left, Samson appeared to plot his escape and looked around for a dark corner to hide in. His eyes fell on Florence, kept moving, then rushed back to her. He smiled and ducked through the conga line to get to Florence.

"Is this the hiding spot?" he asked as she joined Florence up against the wall.

"Well, I came to open a window and stayed for a break from the crowd," she smirked. "And to escape my grandmother's highland dancing."

"Oh, I missed that." Samson snapped his fingers.

"You didn't miss much, she's the only one who really knows how to highland dance. The rest of us are just trying to keep up."

"Well, if you were out on the dance floor you must have stolen the show." Samson leaned a little closer, his eyes searching her. "Because you look amazing."

"Thank you," Florence accepted the compliment with a little bow. "This is my mother's dress."

"Then I'm sure Flora would think the same thing."

A bell rang in the distance and for a moment Florence thought it was in her head until the sound of Pearl's voice followed it.

"Ladies and gentleman!" Pearl shouted, ringing a bell high above her head. "Midnight will be here soon! Let's slow it down and set the mood for *magic*." Pearl turned around and winked at Mia, who shook her head in response. "So take the hand of whoever is nearest to you and come dance our way into the ether, that place between this year and the next." This time Pearl looked over at Florence and winked before ducking back into the kitchen. The lights lowered and the mood in The Yurt seemed to instantly change from breathless celebrating to hushed conversations.

"I believe that was your grandmother's very clear direction that I should ask you to dance," Samson said, offering out his hand.

"Oh no, don't let her bully you," Florence protested.

"But what if I want to?" Samson asked, his hand still extended. "And what if you want to, too?"

Her lack of hesitation surprised Florence as she took Samson's hand and followed him into the swaying crowd of slow-dancing couples. For someone she once cast a banishment spell on, Florence felt surprisingly comfortable being so close to Samson. Trying to look anywhere but up at his face, Florence's gaze fell on the stiff figure of the Windia Bee reporter, standing with a drink in each hand and fury on her face as she watched them dance.

"I think your admirer is a bit perturbed," Florence whispered.

Samson followed Florence's eye line and smoothly shuffled them to the side so another couple blocked her view.

"Well, I'll be out of sight, out of mind, soon enough," he sighed, looking down at Florence. "That's part of why I came tonight. I'm here to wave the white, offer-stained flag of defeat."

"You're leaving Windia?" Florence's voice was a strange mixture of surprise, relief, and disappointment, which surprised her even more.

Samson said nothing, looking in the other direction as though wrestling with his thoughts.

"Why?" Florence finally asked.

"It doesn't matter why, does it?"

"Well, I'd like to know."

"It just...isn't going to work out."

"It seemed like you were a getting fair amount of business at your cart."

"Yes, we were, but...look, aren't you glad I'm leaving? Isn't this what your family wants?"

Florence quietly answered, "Yes."

Samson sighed and nodded. "Good," he huffed, readjusting his shoulders.

The song transitioned into the next and Samson and Florence said nothing for the entirety of it. Florence was heavy in thought. She was happy about the security for her family's business. She was happy about returning to normal business hours. But she wasn't happy about Samson leaving. And a frantic race began in her mind, urging her to tell him now or never. To tell him she didn't want him to leave, after all.

But she looked at the clock and remembered. 11:45 pm. That race in her heart and mind was a lie, a spell, a manipulation. She wasn't really feeling

what she was feeling and it would all be gone in a matter of minutes. There was no reason to risk her family's future for a fleeting feeling.

As if Samson heard her thoughts or maybe was having similar thoughts of his own, he cleared his throat as Pearl announced this was the final song before the midnight blessing.

"There is another reason I came here tonight," he said finally. "And I suppose it's all connected to why I'm closing the business."

Florence winced. *Don't say it.*

Samson sighed, finally looking back down at her. "I've really grown fond of your family, even if you are the most aggravating lot of women."

He paused their dancing and Florence's heart felt like it was going to beat out of her chest. She reluctantly looked up at Samson. *Don't say it.*

"And I've grown especially fond of you. In fact, I think about you all the time, ever since I saw you in that store with that coffee sample. So if I leave - when I leave - I still want to see you. Once you're back in Portland, I'd like to take you out and we can start over?"

Florence stared up at Samson. She knew everything he said was hard to say because it was all the things she wanted to say herself. But it wasn't real. It was the spell. He stared at her intensely for a reply.

The overhead twinkle lights flickered and Pearl clapped for the crowd's attention.

"Attention! Attention!" Pearl called out as the music lowered. "All you outside, get in here! It's nearly midnight, gather around!" Pearl looked through the crowd until she spotted Florence. "Florence, now's the time."

"I have to go," Florence murmured, fighting back tears as she removed herself from Samson's embrace.

"Wait, you didn't answer me." Samson held onto Florence's hand.

Florence pulled her hand away. "Because I can't bear to."

She pushed her way through the crowd, which was now even thicker as the revelers from outside on the beach filled The Yurt to maximum capacity. Florence wiped any sign of tears from her eyes as she joined her grandmother by the coffee bar, where a metal bowl of uncrossing incense was already lit and smoldering.

Pearl held onto the bowl tightly. "Take this," she ordered firmly. "Can you follow me along?"

"Yes." Florence accepted the bowl from her grandmother. The smell was almost overpowering, taking Florence to the edge of lightheadedness. She looked down at the pile of hot incense as it sparked and crackled, inhaling deeply as she blew a long, hot blast of breath into the embers. She looked up at the hushed crowd and found Samson right in the front, watching her closely. Harper shut the windows and The Yurt's front door. Florence looked up at the clock. 11:59 pm.

"Listen here, beloved brothers and sisters of Windia!" Pearl called out, looking at Samson and adding, "And to all those who wander our way."

Florence inhaled and blew hard on the embers again, sending a smoky blast of incense into the crowd.

Pearl stomped her feet rhythmically from beside her. She looked over at Florence, shouting, "Ten!"

"Nine!" the crowd shouted excitedly.

"You will welcome the new year clean!" Pearl shouted, raising her arms up.

"Eight!"

"Free from all tricks and misleadings!"

"Seven!"

Florence blew harder on the uncrossing incense and she began to see the haze throughout The Yurt, suspended above the heads of all those she held dear.

"Six!"

"You will accept love and love others as you wish it!"

"Five!"

"You are free from the chain of enchantments!" Pearl's voice rattled the windows.

"Four!"

"And may you have a safe-"

"Three!"

"Prosperous!"

"Two!"

"And blessed happy new year!"

"Happy New Year!"

Pearl lowered her arms and the windows and front door flew open, the clouds of uncrossing incense swooshing out of The Yurt with a great blast of wind. The crowd cheered and hugged and kissed as *Auld Lang Syne* played loudly in the air. The crowd clapped for the Mackenzie women gathered together by the coffee bar with the smoldering uncrossing incense. The overhead lights slowly built to full illumination as the guests took their cue to leave and continue their celebrations elsewhere or simply go to bed, content to start their new year wrapped in the warmth of a Mackenzie blessing.

The Mackenzie women and Harper watched and waited as The Yurt cleared out. Florence felt like she couldn't blink, scanning the room for

Samson, hoping maybe he was still there and the spell had no effect on him. But Samson was gone.

Pearl took the bowl from Florence and set it on the counter. She held her granddaughter's face in her hands.

"Very good, my love," she whispered. "Welcome back."

The Yurt was locked up as the Mackenzie women closed the windows and left the mess for later. As the others went to bed, Florence turned off the last of the lights, standing in darkness in the center of The Yurt where she had danced with Samson. She examined herself and felt no different, other than smelling like she'd bathed in aromatic campfire smoke. Maybe the enchantment would break after a good night of sleep because as her mother always told her, everything looked brighter in the morning.

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Chapter Nineteen

UNLIKE MOST NEW YEAR'S Day mornings, Florence woke up just before the cusp of dawn. But it wasn't because of an alarm or even being fully rested. It was because of a feeling, a nudge, an urge that was as clear as a shake of her shoulders. Rising out of bed, Florence pulled a hoodie over her pajamas and crept down the hall, avoiding the creaky parts of the floor she'd memorized as a child. She entered the messy Yurt, still showing signs of the New Year's Eve party only hours before, as though suspended in time. Free to make a little more noise now that she was away from her sleeping family, Florence began her morning caffeine of choice, staring absently out the window at the still morning skies, lined with the first hint of dawn.

Once her drink was finished and poured into an oversized mug, Florence roamed The Yurt, kicking at trash and discarded noisemakers. That same urge that woke Florence now drew her to the door, as though a thread linked her hand to the knob. And instead of resisting, Florence followed its tug and exited The Yurt into the shocking cold of early morning, closing the door behind her. Her senses were overwhelmed with the damp salty air, heavy with mist and the distant marine layer. Everything was quiet and asleep except for the sea that kept a steady watch on the town of Windia, like a sentry forever on duty. The beach was illuminated with a flat gray glow as night and morning transitioned, the full moon standing by until day quietly began.

In front of Florence stretched the path frequented by many residents and visitors alike, leading from The Yurt directly down to the sea. It was also the path Florence's mother used to take every morning and the path Florence took the day she found her mother dead. Florence took a long drink of her coffee and stared at the path, lined by rocks and tall, soft grass that swayed in the gentle wind. The wind grew stronger, whipping the grasses flat. Florence's coffee spilled as the earth suddenly began to tremble, starting with a slow rumble and building to a deafening thunder.

Florence abandoned her coffee and held breathlessly onto the porch railing, screaming into the whirlwind of flying debris. Suddenly, a great shadow rose in the distance, growing higher and higher with each passing second. Florence gasped. A giant tsunami wave of bubbling, brown coffee was barreling straight towards her and The Yurt, towering so high it blocked out the moon. She could smell the coffee and feel the heat as it pressed closer. Florence braced for impact but stopped when she noticed a small figure riding atop the tsunami wave. It was Samson, in multicolored swim shorts, casually riding a surfboard. He waved at her and shouted.

"What?" Florence shouted.

Samson kept shouting as the wave rushed closer and closer.

"Florence!"

"Florence!"

"Sweet Gaia, this girl sleeps deep!"

Florence opened one eyelid at a time, adjusting from her dreamscape to reality. As her eyes focused, the figures of Pearl and Mia swam above her.

"Wake up! It's almost 11:00," Mia insisted.

"It's New Year's, everybody sleeps in on New Year's," Florence mumbled, turning over and burying her head in her pillow. She didn't want to face

today, she'd gone to sleep already dreading it. She didn't want to wake up and feel different about Samson. Or forget Samson. Or whatever the uncrossing incense's effect would be. She rolled back over. So far she felt the same.

"You're lucky we're closed today. I can't imagine the gripes if you'd had to get up for the morning rush," Mia grumbled.

"Well, things will be going back to normal, now," Florence snapped, tossing her pillow to the ground. "Samson's leaving."

Mia and Pearl stared at Florence, looked at each other, then back to Florence, who had now buried herself under the covers.

"I'm...sorry?" Mia said with a shrug, looking to Pearl for an explanation. "Isn't this a good thing?" she whispered.

Pearl silenced her with a wave of her hand. "Darling," she said loudly. "Mia needs to return the karaoke machine in Allensville and I need to visit the bulk store, I'm almost wiped out of flour and everything else, for that matter."

Florence mumbled an incoherent reply.

Pearl patted the bed. "Take a few more moments, center yourself with Mother Earth, and allow yourself to accept the energy of a new year."

"Don't take too many moments, Harper and Diana are counting on you to help clean up," Mia said dryly. "And don't forget to make Mia some lunch, and I'm not talking about a bowl of chips."

Florence pulled down the covers. "You'll never let me live that down, will you?"

"We'll be back as soon as we can and talk about this more. But for now, I've got to get this karaoke machine back before noon or they're going to

charge me double." Mia ruffled Florence's hair before she exited the room, already shouting reminders to Harper and Diana.

Pearl smiled down at the crumpled mess that was her granddaughter.

"I was quite proud of you last night, you know," she said, fingering the layered necklaces around her neck.

Florence kicked her feet off the side of the bed. "It was nothing," she sighed. "I just blew some smoke into the crowd. I don't even know if it worked."

"Time will tell, it always does," Pearl said sagely. "And it wasn't nothing, Florence. I felt your connection, I felt a light inside you. You see, there's a little witch inside you, after all."

Florence looked up at the mischievous twinkle in her grandmother's eye and couldn't help but smile.

"I'll get dressed and go help," Florence conceded, stumbling over to her suitcase and pulling out a pair of sweatpants and a T-shirt. Her feet were throbbing, angry with her for wearing heels the night before. She glanced over at Pearl, who was hesitating in the doorway.

"What's wrong?" she asked.

Pearl fingered her necklaces, clutching them hard. "No...nothing," she faltered before catching herself. "Nothing! See you soon."



Much to Florence's disappointment, the state of The Yurt wasn't much different than how it appeared in her ridiculous dream. Harper swept the floors with a giant broom, gathering discarded food crumbs, empty water bottles, and loose pieces of decorations in one swoop. Diana was covered in

a pile of tangled tulle and twinkle lights, biting her lips as he methodically separated strand from strand.

"Finally!" Harper huffed, wrapping her thick hair into a haphazard bun. She yanked off her hoodie and fanned her flushed face. "You really put your guests to work around here!"

"Sorry," Florence laughed, taking the broom from Harper. "Anyway, you're not a guest, you're family."

"Oh great," Harper replied with a playful smirk as she sat on the coffee counter. "My family is already crazy enough without your lot thrown in."

Florence made quick work of the sweeping, finding freedom from her thoughts as she powered through the cleanup. Much to Harper's protests about the cold, Florence opened all the windows to rid the last lingering scent of the uncrossing incense. The bracing wind took their breath away, chasing the trash around The Yurt and knocking the remaining decorations down from the ceiling. The clear sky outside promised no rain so the rugs were hosed down and hung outside to dry quickly in the sun and wind. Within an hour, Hurricane Florence had either cleaned or led the charge in cleaning the entire Yurt, a stack of boxes containing decorations waiting to be stashed in the attic.

Collapsing in the middle of the freshly-mopped floors, Harper and Diana tried to evade Florence's frantic scooting of the tables and chairs back into place.

"Take a break!" Harper hollered, dodging a sliding potted plant moving from one end of The Yurt to the other.

"I will...when I'm done..." Florence huffed, breathing hard as she rode the cleaning high.

"I'm hungry for lunch," Diana moaned, holding her head in her hands. "Breakfast was forever ago."

"See? Your niece is starving," Harper pointed out. "So stop!"

"Okay!" Florence exclaimed, leaning the feather duster up against the wall. "I'm sorry! I just want things back in place. I just want everything back to normal."

Harper sighed and stood up, hugging her sweaty friend. "I get it. I'm sorry. But doing a day's worth of cleaning in one hour is not going to solve anything."

Florence nodded. Harper was right although it did feel good to sweat out her worries.

"Okay, Harper, if you take the decorations back up to the attic, I'll get started on lunch. Diana, will you go see if the rugs outside are dry yet?"

Harper and Diana went off to their respective duties as Florence closed The Yurt's windows and went back to the kitchen to make lunch. As she dug through the cupboards and examined the near-empty refrigerator, she understood why her grandmother had wanted to stock up on food. She finally assembled three plates with grilled cheese sandwiches, leftover peach crisp, and the last of the sparkling apple cider split between them. Precariously balancing all three plates and glasses, Florence carried lunch into The Yurt and called for Harper and Diana.

Harper returned from her last trip to the attic, grabbing a glass of sparkling apple cider from Florence and guzzling it. She smacked her lips and grimaced.

"There's no caffeine in that, is there?" she asked.

Florence shook her head. Harper smacked her lips again and rushed behind the coffee bar.

"Useless liquid, then," she mumbled.

Florence laughed as she laid the plates down on the counter and called for Diana. She took a bite out of her sandwich, waiting to sit down until her niece returned from the outside. She called again with no response or sign of Diana.

"Didn't she come back inside?" Florence asked aloud, putting down her sandwich.

Harper stopped grinding her espresso beans. "No, I haven't seen her."

Florence walked to the open door and looked outside. The bright blue sky was already hinting at the approach of afternoon, large towers of stacked white clouds rolling across the sky. The washed rugs hung over the side of the porch railing, flapping like capes in the blowing wind.

"Diana!" Florence shouted. "Lunch!"

Florence paused and listened, hearing nothing but the ocean. Then she began to hear her heartbeat thump harder and harder. Harper joined her outside.

"She's not answering, I can't find her," Florence panicked, racing down the steps.

"I'll go look inside," Harper said, disappearing back into The Yurt.

"Check the attic, make sure she didn't follow you!" Florence shouted after her, scrambling beneath the porch, one of Diana's favorite hiding spaces with the spiders and cold sand. No Diana.

Emerging from beneath the porch, Florence brushed herself off and ran barefoot from one end of the property to the other, along the empty drive that led to The Yurt, back down to the edge of the garden. No Diana. Circling back to the front of The Yurt, Florence shouted for Harper through the door but got no response.

"Where would she go?" Florence whispered to herself as she paced, her voice hoarse from yelling. A thought popped into her mind. *The beach.*

Florence's heart jumped into her throat, looking again for any sign of Harper, but she was still somewhere inside The Yurt or the house. Florence reached for her neck as the panic started to rise in her chest. But she couldn't wait another second, maybe she'd already waited too long. The path down to the beach stretched out in front of her like a long tunnel and the sound of the ocean crashed in her ears. Breaking free, Florence ran as fast as her feet would take her, her chest burning as she forgot to breathe.

Once Florence reached the beach, she stopped to lean on her knees and to catch her breath. There was no one on the beach except for a few distant figures, too tall to be a child. The sea was calm, the waves gentle as they reached the beach but soaring in the choppy waters towards the horizon. This was not like the last time Florence had been on the beach, when the wind had nearly knocked her down and the ocean had raged. Or at least, that's how Florence remembered it.

"Diana!" Florence took a deep breath and shouted.

"Is lunch finally ready?" Diana asked.

Florence fell over in surprise as she turned to find Diana nestled up against the shoreline where the sand and the grass meet, where she was engaged in building an intricate sandcastle. Florence stumbled over to her niece and wrapped her in her arms, crying and laughing at the same time.

"I've been looking everywhere for you!" Florence exclaimed. "What are you doing down here by yourself?"

Diana pulled away, eyeing her disheveled aunt. "I'm allowed to come down here by myself, as long as I don't go by the water."

"Says who?"

"Mom."

"Since when?"

"Since my last birthday." Diana raised an eyebrow and added dramatically, "Remember, the one you missed."

Florence sighed and sat next to her niece, looking out towards the ocean. She said nothing as she allowed time for her heart and breathing to return to normal. "I'm sorry," she said finally.

"It's okay." Diana shrugged. She looked sideways at Florence. "You really thought I was lost?"

"Yes," Florence choked, trying not to get emotional again.

"So you came down here to look for me, even though you were afraid?"

"Well, yeah, I love you. I don't want to lose you or for you to be hurt."

"So, if you do something you're afraid of, it might not be so bad, after all?" Diana watched Florence's face carefully.

Florence smiled and squinted her eyes. "How old did you turn at that last birthday?"

Diana shrugged again. "Pearl said I'm an old soul."

"I think she was right, as she is about most things," Florence sighed. She looked over her shoulder back towards The Yurt. "We better get back before Harper calls the police, if she hasn't already."

"And now I'm starving," Diana added, standing up and brushing the sand from her clothes.

"I hope you like cold grilled cheese sandwiches," Florence said as she stood up, sore and stiff from her panicked running around the property. "Hey, we don't *have* to tell your mom about this, do we?" she asked, wrapping her arm around her niece.

Diana looked up at her aunt. "Oh, I'm definitely telling her."

"Great," Florence sighed.

Back at The Yurt, Harper, Mia, and Pearl were gathered outside the coffee shop. Their chatter stopped abruptly when they spotted Florence and Diana approaching back up the beach path.

"Oh, thank goodness." Harper collapsed to the ground. "I was about to call the police!"

"Told you," Florence whispered to Diana and winked.

"You...went to the beach?" Mia gasped.

Florence had hoped no one was going to make a big deal out of it, but that was wishful thinking. "Well, you're welcome for finding your child I thought was lost."

Mia visibly bristled. "First of all, if you really thought Diana was missing, your first call *should* have been to the police, the second call to me, third-" Mia stopped herself. "Third, I'm just super proud of you."

Florence nodded. "Thank you."

"Can we go eat now?" Diana moaned, walking past the group to go inside.

"You haven't fed her yet?" Mia snapped at Florence. "It's the one thing I asked you to do!"

Florence threw up her hands as Mia and Harper walked Diana inside The Yurt. Pearl said nothing, which was not a typical response.

"Yes?" Florence looked to her grandmother, bracing for some grand statement about the healing power of the ocean.

"I knew you could do it," Pearl said simply, smiling at her granddaughter.

Florence smiled, relieved to leave it at that. As they ascended the steps to The Yurt, Florence turned to Pearl.

"Did you know that Diana was allowed down at the beach by herself?" she asked.

"Of course, since her last birthday," Pearl replied, turning to give side-eye. "Remember, the one you missed?"

"How can I forget when I have my family to remind me?" Florence sighed, admitting defeat.

Pearl winked. "And you can always count on us, dear."

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Chapter Twenty

THE REMAINDER OF NEW Year's Day was filled with activities befitting a holiday, including naps, an afternoon movie, and endless snacks. With the coffee shop closed for the day, the women were tucked away from the rest of town, which was dormant since most of the shops and businesses closed for the holiday as well. Florence tried her best to keep her mind off Samson, fighting the urge to jump in her car and go look for him. He left after the enchantment was broken, there was no point, she told herself. Florence found numerous excuses to go back down to the beach until her family told her she didn't need a reason and to just go enjoy the sea. She sat on the sand and stewed, looking over her shoulder towards Windia, wondering what was going on in the hearts and minds of those that lived there and if they felt like she did - no different.

New Year's Day marked the end of Harper's vacation and visit to Windia. She loaded her suitcase into the backseat of her car and positioned a pile of snacks and soda in the passenger seat for the drive back to Portland.

Harper wrapped her oversized sweater around herself, still dressed in the dusty athletic wear she'd worn to help clean The Yurt. Pearl, Mia, and Diana had already said their goodbyes but Florence wanted to walk her friend out to her car. Harper looked up at the late afternoon sky.

"I should be home in time for a late dinner, Tony and the group are going out downtown," she said, opening the driver's side car door.

"Have fun and tell them 'hi' for me," Florence said, reaching out to give her friend a long hug. "It was said a few dozen times inside already, but we couldn't have done all this without you."

Harper embraced her friend. "Well, it all worked out in the end. The Yurt will go on and you'll come back to Portland soon, right?"

Florence nodded and sighed. "I just need a few more days here to let the dust settle and figure out what I'm doing. Which is why I came here in the first place."

Harper raised her eyebrows at the tone of her friend's voice. "You do *want* to come back, don't you?"

"Of course. There's nothing for me here," Florence shrugged.

"Right..." Harper said slowly. "Did you really like that Samson?"

"I did. I thought I did. But it was just the coffee," Florence said miserably, looking down at her bare feet.

"I'm sorry." Harper hugged her friend again. She offered her biggest, most encouraging smile. "When you get back, we'll go out and forget all about him."

Florence managed a smile and nodded.

"See you soon!" Harper said as she climbed into her car and shut the door. She opened it again. "And happy new year!"

Florence waved and watched her friend drive away until she was out of sight, on the road back to Portland. Back inside, the other Mackenzie women were snuggled together on the couch and watching a holiday movie. Florence sat down on the carpet and twitched as she tried to find a comfortable position.

"Miss Restless, why don't you take some of that nervous energy and go make me some chamomile tea?" Pearl asked from where she was buried

under a pile of knitting, looking at her granddaughter over the rim of her reading glasses.

Florence jumped up and said nothing, walking briskly into the kitchen. She was anxious and confused. Her mind was spinning with a million thoughts, now preoccupied with returning to life back in Portland. Setting the kettle on the stovetop, Florence rummaged through the box of miscellaneous tea bags. She leaned across the kitchen counter and held her head in her hands while she waited for the kettle. Her eyes fell upon the latest issue of the Windia Bee that Pearl and Mia had picked up while out in town.

Picking up the paper, Florence flipped through pages of news stories and advertisements from local businesses wishing the residents of Windia a happy new year. Florence froze when her eyes fell upon the "Community" section with a picture of Samson beaming as he stood next to his coffee cart. The headline read, "Handsome entrepreneur follows dreams." Florence's hands began to tremble as she started to read the article.

"Windia residents were surprised to find another coffee establishment in town this week. The shop is operated by Samson Richards, the dashing and talented son of the Sam's 'Spresso coffee empire in Portland. This reporter had the pleasure of sharing a white chocolate mocha with the eligible bachelor on New Year's Eve morning, when he took time from his busy day of charming customers.

"Richards came to Windia just over a week ago, but his interest in our little town started many months before. His impressive educational background is surely an asset to his mogul father, and when Richards approached his father about expanding outside of Portland, he naturally supported his son's inspired ideas. Richards says our town's idyllic location, proximity to Portland, and limited competition made us a natural choice.

"That is, until the Mackenzie women gave him pushback. It's no surprise to anyone in town that while the Mackenzie's certainly make great drinks and their New Year's Eve parties are a Windia tradition, they are still a bit mad. Anyone would have to be mad to reject Richards' generous offer to buy The Yurt, but they refused, although Richards gentlemanly added he still thought they were 'lovely ladies.'"

The kettle's persistent whistling snapped Florence out of her concentrated reading. She reluctantly pulled herself away from the paper and messily poured the hot water into the waiting cup of tea, jumping back to where she left off in the story.

"Ever an inventive problem solver, Richards traveled to Portland and returned to our fair city with his mobile coffee cart. This cart generated so much business he had to bring in extra help. Of course, as most residents know from my

previous articles, Florence Mackenzie repeatedly distracted our intrepid visitor with absurd antics, although Richards says he holds no hard feelings.

"So what drives Richards to fight for Windia against the obstinate Mackenzie's? Richards says if he can make it work in Windia, his father will promote him in the family's company, which this inspiring young man says he's worked his whole life towards. What is more attractive than fervently following one's dreams? This reporter certainly doesn't know, but she hopes to learn even more about the handsome Samson Richards at tonight's New Year's Eve party with the rest of you."

Grabbing the newspaper, Florence ran into the living room.

Pearl looked up from her knitting and squinted. "Tea?"

"Oh, tea," Florence mumbled, running back into the kitchen, removing the steeping tea bag, and carefully, but quickly, returning to the living room with Pearl's chamomile tea. After she handed off the cup, Florence jumped in front of the television and held up the Windia Bee newspaper, causing an uproar from Mia and Diana.

"Did you read this?" Florence asked, waving the paper in the air like a flag.

Mia reached for the remote and paused the movie. She squinted at the wrinkled paper in Florence's hands.

"He left Windia for us! He could've been promoted but he sacrificed all that and left for us!" Florence cried out after receiving no response.

"Who?" Mia asked.

"Samson Richards!" Florence bellowed.

"What's that got to do with the paper?" Mia asked, looking from Diana to Pearl.

Pearl shrugged and continued knitting.

Florence groaned. "They did a story on Samson in the paper. He said if Windia had worked out, he could've been promoted at Sam's 'Spresso."

"So?" Mia bristled, sitting back against the couch. "This is our livelihood. He can make it work somewhere else."

"I just...wish I had understood more," Florence lamented. "Maybe we could have found some way to make it work, look at all the business we had even with him here! But I was so worried he would find out about the property and-"

Florence clapped her hand over her mouth and looked at Pearl, who suddenly stopped knitting. The room fell silent other than the sound of Diana loudly crunching popcorn.

Mia sat forward. "What about the property?"

Florence pressed her lips together hard, staring at Pearl to say something. Clearing her throat, Pearl gently laid down her knitting, gave Florence a pointed stare, then turned to Mia.

"Darling, we didn't want to worry you," Pearl began. "You work so hard and we appreciate everything you've done for our family."

Mia leaned forward farther.

"But," Pearl sighed. "We have a teensy problem." She held up her fingers to demonstrate.

"Yes?" Mia urged.

"We don't own this property, I'm afraid."

The room fell silent again other than Diana's popcorn consumption. Florence's eyes darted from Mia to Pearl and back again. Even Diana turned to her mother for a reaction. What happened next was not what the women expected. Mia started laughing. She laughed so hard that she leaned back to hold her stomach, wiping away the tears until another wave of laughter overtook her. Pearl narrowed her eyes, genuinely confused. Was this relief? Confusion? Madness?

Finally, Mia composed herself, wiping away the last of her tears. She shook her head and took a deep breath.

"We own the property," she giggled breathlessly. "Of course we own the property."

Pearl turned in her seat, unaccustomed to being corrected. "No, we do not," she said hotly.

Mia covered her mouth to stop laughing. "I'm sorry, this is just crazy," she mumbled. "This whole time you thought we didn't own the property here?"

"Yes!" Pearl and Florence shouted.

"But we do!" Mia shouted back. "Dylan and I had all the property lines drawn when we were prepping for the restaurant. I have the deed in my filing cabinet with all the other restaurant paperwork!"

"But..." Pearl went pale. "I thought...the city...they didn't..."

Mia nodded. "Yes, it was a mess down at City Hall. Great-grandfather Mackenzie *did* start the deal with a handshake, but then several years later had his attorney draw up the official paperwork with the city. It was supposed to all be filed but that was around the time of the big fire

downtown and I think paperwork got lost in the shuffle. Either way, Dylan and I were in the midst of straightening it all out when...anyway, I have copies of everything." Mia shrugged. "And no one would actually question we owned this property. Well, other than you two."

Florence felt like her whole body deflated. Pearl sat back on the couch, heavy in thought. She looked at her granddaughter pleadingly.

"I'm so sorry, I honestly didn't know," she whispered.

Dropping the newspaper, Florence dashed into the kitchen for her purse and ran outside, Pearl calling out after her. Still barefoot, Florence fumbled for her keys in the depths of her purse. The sun had set and the transition to night had begun, the moon standing by from where it had been silently keeping watch in the sky.

Peeling out from the driveway, Florence forgot her seatbelt until the car's insistent warning beeps caught her attention. She wiped frustrated tears from her eyes and traveled the short road to downtown Windia. Forget the spell and the coffee. The feelings she'd been toiling with all day were real. And she believed they felt real to him, too.

But when she drove by Four Corners Square, the Sam's 'Spresso coffee cart was gone. Parking haphazardly on the empty street, Florence left her purse in the car and wandered into the Square. Illuminated by hanging street lamps, the Square was completely empty other than the existing stone benches and tables scattered across the tile ground. Florence searched for any note or signal that Samson may have left for her. But the area where his cart had once been parked was empty other than a neatly coiled hose that Samson had borrowed from the mayor. Florence sat on the hose. Samson was gone.

After a few minutes, Florence stood up and crossed Main Street, to the place she often retreated to when life became too much. When she needed to cry or breathe or think, the ocean reminded her there was an expanse beyond her worries, but it was still there to hear her out all the same. The beach was empty, now completely dark other than the moon that stared at her like a giant eye in the sky. The wind whipped at Florence, easing up on her only to blast her in the face unexpectedly. Florence had left the car so quickly she forgot her sweatshirt, so she wrapped her arms around herself and kept walking, breathless as she approached where the dry sand transitioned into wet.

She didn't care if it was the middle of winter, Florence allowed the bitingly cold waters to touch her bare feet; that was all part of the cleansing experience. She closed her eyes and listened, opening them in time to watch the next approaching wave as it submerged her feet, then up to her knees, depositing a sticky, wet leaf on Florence's left calf. She reached down to pick off the leaf, examining the speckled pattern of mold, dirt, and sand. She flipped it over and discovered written on the other side, in faded black marker, the words *Samson Elijah Richards*.

Chapter Twenty-One

SAMSON LOOKED IN THE rearview mirror, a low rumbling sound drawing his eyes from the dark forest road in front of him. Even though it was nighttime, he could still see the outline of the coffee cart attached to the hitch behind his truck, jostling along with Samson on his way back to Portland. Focusing again on the road illuminated by his headlights, Samson chewed hard on his gum and turned his radio up again.

He had waited until sunset to see if Florence would change her mind. He wasn't going to go chasing after her, Samson told himself a dozen times over the course of his miserable day. Florence had made herself quite clear the night before after he'd idiotically laid his heart out for her. Samson even had a fleeting moment of wondering whether his father was right. But within a second, Samson dismissed the thought. He couldn't do it. He wouldn't do it. He'd figure something out for himself back in Portland. And when the sun set and Florence never showed up, he left Windia and started back home.

A loud gust of wind blasted through the trees on the driver's side of Samson's truck, startling him enough to lower the radio again and peer through the windshield at the dark forest beside him. He looked to the other side of the road where the trees were completely motionless. Shaking his head, Samson focused again on the empty road but kept the radio lowered.

He instinctively braced for impact when another loud rumble erupted, followed by a gale-force wind, bending the trees and sending branches,

rocks, and dirt into the roadway. Samson exclaimed loudly and slammed on the brakes as the earth began to shake and more debris tumbled into the road. He shouted again and swerved off to the shoulder as Florence appeared out of nowhere and ran into the road, waving her arms above her head for him to stop. The truck's windshield was pummeled with rocks and dirt as the vehicle skidded to a stop, struggling with the extra weight of the coffee cart towing behind it.

Once he was finally at a stop, Samson peeled his sweaty hands from the steering wheel and tried to catch his breath. Remembering Florence was out there in the apparent earthquake, he opened the door and stumbled out of his truck.

But when Samson touched the ground he found it was no longer shaking. Florence was still in the road, frantically dragging hazards out of the way so other cars would not hit them. She froze when she saw Samson approaching.

"What's going on?" he gasped, still trying to catch his breath as he ran up to her. He grabbed Florence's shoulders, expecting another earth-rumbling gust of wind at any moment.

Florence lowered Samson's arms and grabbed his shoulders. "I'm sorry," she said pleadingly. "I just had to tell you I'm sorry."

"For what?" Samson asked. He looked around the dark forest. "And how did you get here?"

"I'm sorry for all of it!" Florence continued, throwing her hands in the air. "The attitude, the stupid competition, my crazy family. I had no idea what this meant to you, too." She paused and looked up at him. "You should have told me."

"I'm the one who should be sorry for trying to take away your family's business. You did it all to protect your family," Samson replied, shaking his head. "And that's just part of what I like about you."

"And I like so many things about you, I don't care about the coffee spell anymore," Florence said, grabbing Samson's hands.

He squeezed them. "Really?" Samson asked, leaning closer. He blinked. "What coffee spell?"

Florence bit her lip. "The whole town's been under a love spell from some enchanted coffee beans."

"Is that so?" Samson raised an eyebrow.

"But we broke the spell last night," Florence continued quickly. "So I thought...after the spell...I'd feel different about you. Or you'd feel different about me."

Samson drew closer. "And you don't?"

Florence didn't move away. "I don't. And you?"

"Well, there's something you should know about me," Samson whispered as he touched Florence's upturned face. "I don't believe in magic."

"Hmm," Florence chuckled, glancing down towards the ground. "You might change your mind about that."

Samson followed her eye line and looked down at the ground. He exclaimed and grabbed onto Florence's waist as he realized they were levitating off the ground. He frantically tried to get his footing back on the ground but they were slowly floating higher and higher. Florence slipped her arms up Samson's shoulders and wrapped them around his neck.

"Just go with it," she whispered.

Florence had to admit it was a masterfully orchestrated and absolutely perfect first kiss. With the full moon as a backdrop, the silent forest held its

breath and watched as the duo floated above the empty highway. The weightlessness encouraged Samson and Florence closer and closer as they fumbled for balance in the open air. Distracted by the fact that he was floating, it only took Samson a few moments to focus his attention back on Florence, whose face was inches from his own. She searched his eyes, looking for confirmation for the feelings burning in her chest. When Samson smiled down at her, she smiled back and knew she had found it. His kiss tasted like saltwater, his embrace enveloped her in warmth and lit her from inside, like that first glorious sip of hot coffee. When she opened her eyes, Florence sighed and rested her head against Samson's chest, listening to his strong beating heart. This wasn't her grandmother's type of witchcraft. This was another kind of magic.

"Florence?" Samson whispered, his voice rumbling in his chest.

"Mm-hmm?" Florence blissfully replied.

"I really, really don't want to ruin this moment," Samson panted. "But I'm terrified of heights."

"Oh no!" Florence exclaimed, pulling back and clapping her hand over her mouth to keep from laughing. She looked down at the ground, which by now was a good fifty feet away. "You can bring us down now!" she shouted.

Samson howled as they dropped suddenly to within inches of the ground, slowing down as the drop shifted to a gentle float. He released Florence and sat on the ground, clutching his churning stomach.

"Who are you talking to?" he gasped, looking around the deserted forest.

"My ride," Florence replied, running her hands through Samson's hair as she walked to the opposite side of the highway. "You'll take us home, right?"

Samson nodded, taking deep breaths to steady his spinning stomach as he cradled his head. He squinted his eyes and watched Florence disappear into the dark.

Sliding down the side of the gravel embankment, Florence climbed into the tree line. It was easy to find Pearl by the little windstorm caused by her floating broom. Grinning like a Cheshire cat, Pearl floated closer as her granddaughter approached.

"Nice one," Florence said with a smirk.

Pearl shrugged, her legs remaining perfectly crossed atop the sturdy oak broom handle. "I do what I can."

"You always do," Florence grinned. "Thank you."

Pearl winked. "You're welcome." She leaned forward and peered at Samson, who was on his feet again and looking for Florence. "Should I go over and say hello?"

"Let's ease him into this," Florence laughed, waving her hands. "I think the floating incident is enough for one night."

"Oh, you're no fun," Pearl teased as she placed one hand on her waist and the other firmly on the broom handle. Like a balloon releasing into the air, she slowly floated upwards into the sky. "I think I'll go for a little spin. Don't wait up." She paused her ascension and peered down at her granddaughter, yelling, "I love you!"

"I love you, too!" Florence called back but her voice was swallowed by the rush of wind left in her grandmother's wake. She looked over to Samson, who had been knocked off his feet again by the gust of wind.

Florence smiled. Her grandmother could keep her evening flybys. She'd pick a truck ride with Samson over that every time.

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Chapter Twenty-Two

"**I** S THIS GOODBYE?"

Florence stopped spraying a thick layer of whipped cream atop the iced almond milk mocha, her hand frozen midair. She was behind the counter at The Yurt, her sweaty hair pulled up in a messy bun, as several escaping flyaway hairs danced in the breeze from the fan. Worried the whipped cream would melt, Florence quickly slapped a lid on the drink and passed it across the counter along with a straw.

Barb accepted the drink and nodded slowly. She was dressed in shorts, a tank top, and a giant sun hat. "It's goodbye, but Florence, let's not be sad." She looked lovingly over at Mark, who was already halfway finished with his drink. "Part of me can't believe this is actually happening. But it is! It really is!"

"So you're leaving now?" Florence asked, wiping her sticky hands on her shorts. "You know Pearl and Mia will want to say goodbye."

Barb pointed over her shoulder, mid-sip. "I already saw them next door," she explained. "And this isn't goodbye forever. You know we'll sail our way back around to Windia eventually."

"I know, but I'll still miss you," Florence sighed, running around the counter to give Barb a hug. She also gave Mark a hug, who stiffly patted her back.

Barb looked around The Yurt and over her shoulder at the open front door. She turned back to Florence.

"Your mom would be so proud," she whispered. "It feels like her."

Florence smiled and looked around as well. She had to agree with Barb. Florence felt like her mother would love The Yurt even more. The building had experienced a deep cleaning and spiritual cleansing since coming under Florence's management. She also hired Harper to create a fresh yet familiar aesthetic for The Yurt, now that Harper had started her own design consulting business and was living her best life in the loft she shared with her new boyfriend in downtown Portland. Even the menu had simplified but expanded, offering drink concoctions of Florence's design and baked treats from Pearl every Tuesday and Friday.

Reaching out to give Barb one final hug, Florence bid the couple bon voyage on their oceanic adventures in retirement. Once Barb and Mark left, their hands interlocked while holding their coffees with the other, Florence walked around The Yurt and opened all the windows. It was an unseasonably warm day at the coast and the town was buzzing with the approach of summer.

With all the windows open, a strong gust of wind swept through The Yurt and spun Florence around to the door. She pushed her loose hair out of her face just as Sally the Enchantress walked through the door, her sandals clicking across the wood floors. Her long dark curls were perfectly in place as she smoothed down her long, paisley-print maxi skirt and casual tank top. She lowered her sunglasses and looked around The Yurt until finally settling her eyes on Florence.

"Blessed morning," Sally greeted, tucking her sunglasses into her hair.

"Well, hello," Florence greeted back, crossing her arms against her chest. "Look who the wind brought in."

Sally winked and motioned towards the coffee bar. "I was just passing through and thought I'd stop for a coffee. Do you mind?"

"As long as you're only passing through, I don't mind at all," Florence replied, leading Sally to the coffee bar. "What'll you have?"

"Surprise me," Sally shrugged, still looking around The Yurt with admiration, nodding to herself. "It's lovely in here. Very good energy."

"Thank you, I tried," Florence admitted as she grabbed a cup. "And that's quite brave of you."

Sally blinked coyly. "What is?"

Florence smirked. "Letting me pick your drink."

Sally smiled and rifled through her purse for a bottle of some sort of perfume, which she promptly misted all over herself. "I know there are no hard feelings. How could we over a harmless little coffee bean?"

"Harmless?" Florence called over the milk steamer. "I'll have you know we performed an uncrossing ceremony on the whole town to cleanse what you did."

Sally put a hand on her chest. "What I did?"

Florence rolled her eyes. "C'mon. The love spell? Magic in every bean, remember that?"

Covering her mouth and laughing to herself, Sally reached into her purse for a crisp 20 dollar bill, which she slid across the counter.

"You really didn't read the label, did you?" she chuckled, accepting the drink offered from Florence. "Keep the change. And what is this?"

"Thank you. It's a Chili Mocha," Florence answered. "And what did I miss?"

Both women turned their attention to the front door as Samson stomped through. Dressed in khaki cargo pants and a faded T-shirt, he held up

multiple pages of orders in his hands.

"I'm just dropping these off, there's a flood of people coming in from a tour bus, I'll come help when I can," he said breathlessly, scattering the orders across the counter.

"It's okay, I got it," Florence said, calmly gathering the orders.

"Okay, good," Samson sighed. He looked over at Sally. "Hello."

"Hello," Sally replied, taking a long sip of her drink. She looked Samson up and down, then over to Florence, murmuring, "Mm, spicy." Lowering her sunglasses back over her eyes, Sally held her coffee cup up to Florence in thanks and walked towards the door. "Have a blessed summer!" she called over her shoulder, disappearing with a swish of her skirt.

"Was that...?" Samson turned to Florence, pointing his thumb at the door.

"Yep," Florence said with a sigh. "But it's all good, you go take care of the busload of customers."

"Sure thing, boss," Samson said with a grin, jumping across the counter to give Florence a quick kiss before running back outside.

They worked together as a team, Florence whipping up drink after drink with Samson running them out to the customers. When Florence reached the order marked for *Paulie and Marigold*, she recognized a familiar drink and decided to deliver the order herself.

Outside, the bright sunlight forced Florence to blink until her eyes adjusted. She was met with a symphony of sounds; the ocean waves, customers laughing and talking, and the hammering and drilling happening at the construction site next door. The outside of The Yurt had been transformed by Samson just in time for summer, with sand-appropriate landscaping and a dozen outdoor tables and chairs scattered around the

front for customers. Florence scanned the tables until she spotted Paulie at a table with the Windia Bee reporter.

"Good morning," Florence greeted sweetly as she approached the table, where Paulie stiffened and shifted in his seat at the sight of Florence. "For you," Florence said as she extended Paulie's drink to him. "And...Marigold?"

The Windia Bee reporter nodded and smiled saccharinely as she accepted the drink from Florence. She was dressed in a long flowery dress and yellow sunhat.

"Thank you," Marigold said. "Yes, it's Marigold Stevens."

"Well, nice to officially meet you," Florence said, swerving her head over to Paulie, who flinched in response. He reached out to pay Florence but she dismissed him with a wave of her hand. "Coffee's on me. How are you, Paul?"

Paulie put away his wallet and visibly relaxed at Florence not using his pet name in front of his date. He was dressed nicely in a button-down shirt and slacks and his hair was slicked back with a heavy amount of shiny wax.

"Doing well, the store's doing well," he replied. He looked across the table. "And Marigold and I are doing well, too."

Marigold reached out and clutched Paulie's hand, her layered bracelets jingling against the table. She nodded and took a long sip of her drink. She paused and took another long drink.

"That's...really good," she admitted. She hadn't been back to The Yurt since the New Year's Eve event and seemed to have forgotten what she was missing.

"Thank you," Florence replied. She winced at the sound of an earsplitting saw roaring at the construction next door.

Paulie looked over his shoulder. Several paces from The Yurt and still on Mackenzie property stood the beginning bones of Mia's new restaurant. The construction site was bustling with workmen and trucks and plenty of noise.

"Mia's restaurant is really coming along fast. When is it supposed to open?" Paulie asked.

"The plan is to be open by end of summer and before the rain. And it can't come soon enough, the construction goes from sunrise to sunset," Florence explained. She shrugged, adding, "But I couldn't be happier. This is what Mia and Dylan always dreamed of."

"And not be rude, but..." Marigold said coyly. "How are you all...affording this?"

"No, it's a reasonable question," Florence smirked. "We have an investor."

As if on cue, a loud voice bellowed an order from the center of the construction site. Emerging around the corner and wearing a bright red hard hat was Sam Richards of Sam's 'Spreso himself, moving from workman to workman and distracting them from their job.

Excusing herself from Paulie and Marigold's coffee date, Florence crossed the sandy beach to where Sam, Pearl, and Mia were speaking with the foreman. She listened to the end of their conversation regarding the restaurant's kitchen.

"Whatever my kitten wants, my kitten gets," Sam demanded of the foreman, sweetly looking over at Pearl, who was staring at the foreman with eyes narrowed. "And if my kitten wants a fourth sink, she gets it. With her at the helm, this restaurant is gonna be the talk of the Pacific coastline."

"But we don't want to affect the opening date," Mia interjected. "Pearl can't be a chef if she doesn't have a restaurant to cook for."

The foreman looked over at Sam's stern expression and swallowed hard. "We'll get it done in time, no problem," he mumbled before turning and skulking off to his pickup truck before they could suggest any more changes.

"Well, that's settled," Sam sighed, batting his eyes at Pearl. "Do you feel better now, Sugarplum?"

Pearl's expression softened as a smile pulled at the corners of her lips. "A bit," she admitted demurely.

Sam took Pearl's hand and kissed it passionately, eliciting a groan from Mia and Florence. "Then allow me to whisk you away on a scenic drive to bolster your spirits," he offered, stretching his hand out towards the horizon. "We'll chase the sunset, just you and I."

Pearl paused for a second before answering. "With stops for treats when I'm hungry?"

Sam nodded deeply. "Every time."

Accepting this arrangement, Pearl took Sam's arm and he removed his hard hat, tossing it to the ground. With a tiny wave, Pearl was escorted to Sam's red sports car and they sped off towards the highway.

Mia watched them drive off in search of the sunset. "There really is someone for everyone," she laughed.

Florence studied her sister-in-law's face. "Are you...?"

"Oh no, no," Mia protested quickly. She looked over at the construction site. "*This* is my someone. This is for Dylan." She looked at Florence and smiled. "This is what we wanted."

"I know," Florence whispered, giving Mia a hug. It was true, Mia walked like a hundred pounds were off her shoulders now that Florence was managing The Yurt.

"And, speaking of someone special, I need to go pick up Diana," Mia said, quickly wiping tears from her eyes before Florence could see them. "It's the last day of school before summer break and she is more than ready. You know she wants to shadow the foreman all summer, right?"

Florence laughed. "I wouldn't expect anything less."

The foreman was returning from his pickup truck with a large roll of blueprints and a worried expression.

Mia sighed. "I better deal with this. Can you go grab my purse for me? I stashed it under the counter."

"Sure," Florence said, turning to sprint back to The Yurt and grabbing a handful of orders from Samson on the way. She left the orders by the register and dug under the counter for Mia's purse, which was stashed next to a basket of miscellaneous and nearly empty bags of espresso beans.

"Well, this needs to be cleaned out," Florence said aloud. As she pulled out the overflowing basket of beans to set on the counter, one bag of beans fell to the floor. Florence reached down to pick it up. It was a mostly empty bag of Serendipity blend espresso beans.

Florence studied the label. "There's magic in every bean," she whispered, smiling and shaking her head at the events that little statement started. She stopped and squinted. There was a tiny arrow pointing to a corner flap on the label. Florence picked at it with her fingernail and held her breath as the label peeled back to reveal the interior.

It read like this:

Please note: There is no real magic in these beans. While we did grow these with love, there is no magic stronger than a natural connection. Here at Jupiter Knight Coffee and Teas, we believe all lovers need a little help once in awhile. And what better way to start a conversation than with a cup of coffee?

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